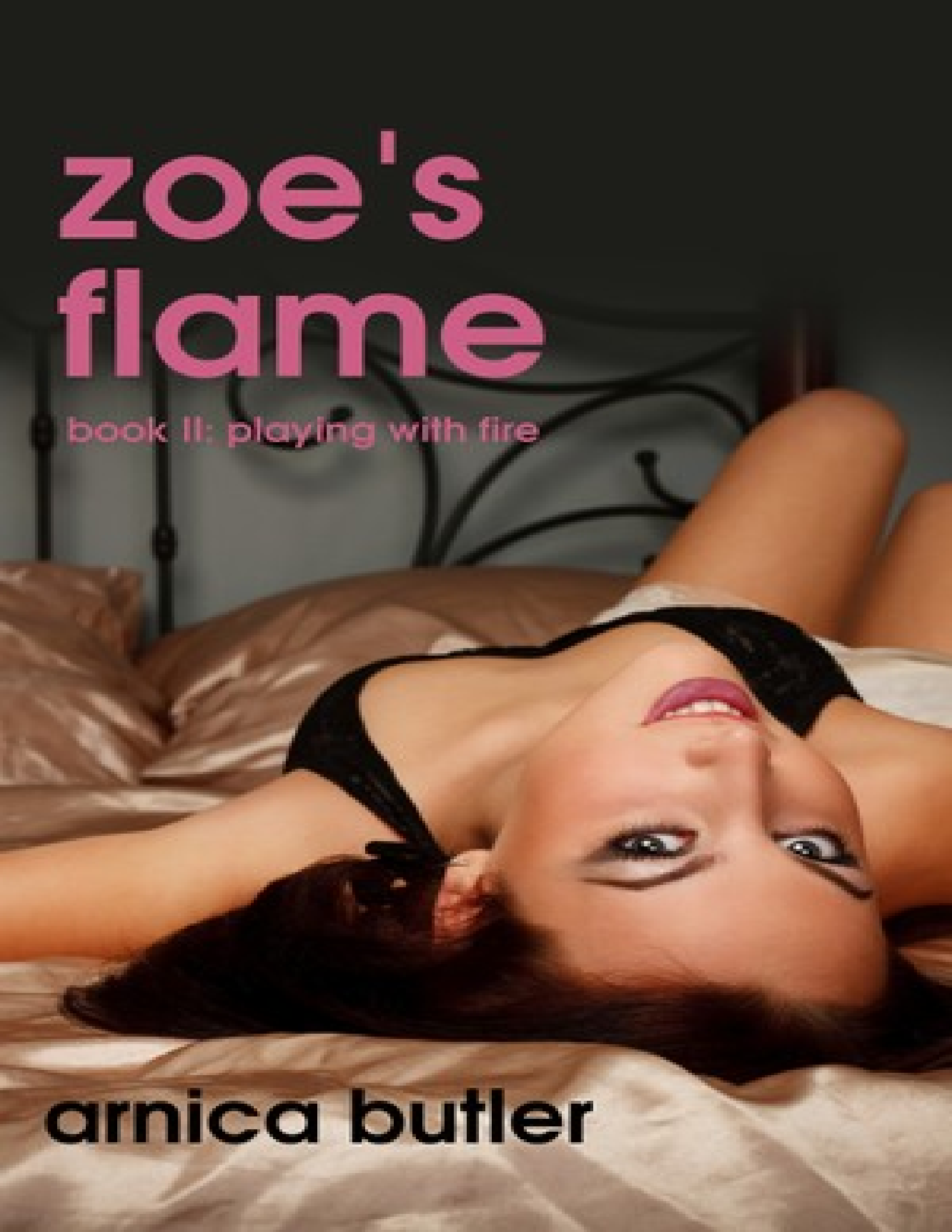


zoe's flame

book II: playing with fire

arnica butler



ZOE'S FLAME

BOOK II: PLAYING WITH FIRE

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

"You aren't dead."

Alicia sounded almost disappointed, but that was the default tone of her voice.

Zoe, still partly asleep, connections to the real world severed or seeking a place to anchor, rubbed her eyes. For a moment, she didn't know what time of day it was, what day of the week, or why Alicia might be calling her. And for a blissful few moments, she was also free of the memory of the preceding night.

She looked over at the clock, and for a moment it confounded her: it read 10:17, but it was light outside the gauzy curtains, and Alicia was not the type to -

Everything hit her all at once.

Randy, her ex-boyfriend's fifty-two-year-old father, huge cock sawing in and out of her, fingers curled up against her tailbone from inside her ass, while she lied to her husband on the phone and told him she was out with friends. Waking up to the realization that she had fallen asleep at Randy's house, that it was past four in the morning and she had not gone home, her pussy still full of another man's cum.

Finding Josh gone, thankfully, and evidently unaware of what had happened, or the late hour at which she had arrived.

And then, the realization that she had fallen asleep again, and was now an hour and a half late for work.

She was frozen by the horror of it all: the irresponsibility, the betrayal, the very *badness* of everything she had done.

"So, where are you?" Alicia said impatiently to her silence. "Car trouble or something like that?"

This last question was delivered as biting sarcasm, Alicia's voice like an eye roll turned to sound.

Zoe cleared her throat. "I... no, I just... I can't understand how this happened. I overslept."

Alicia was quiet on the other end of the line, and Zoe wondered what she was doing. This might be something that Alicia didn't care about, and she was scrolling through her Instagram account.

Or she might have her on mute and be telling the whole office that Zoe was a crazy slut. You never knew with Alicia.

"Well," Alicia said. "You must have needed the sleep, but if I were you I wouldn't tell nobody that. You better call in sick and come up with something good because Neil is starting to, you know, fidget, and ask about you whenever he walks by your cubicle."

Zoe sighed. "Okay... okay."

"You coming in?"

Zoe looked around her. The temptation to call in sick was strong, but she didn't really want to spend the day here, alone, thinking about what to do when Josh came home. She would have to face him, and look him in the eye, and she still didn't know what she was going to do.

She wouldn't get much done at work, but at least she'd be distracted from her big problem.

"I, uh... yeah. I'm coming in, can you go tell him I called you and I have car trouble or something?"

"Yeah," Alicia said, as if Zoe were repeating something for the third time. "Listen, can you drive through a Wendy's on your way? I want one of those square hamburgers." Alicia dismissed herself with one of her Latin tsks. "Ssh."

Zoe stared at the wall. Was she serious?

"Yeah, fine, whatever. But go tell Neil I'm on my way and I just called you because... you're in my phone. Or something."

"Neil is in your phone -"

"Please, Alicia. God."

Zoe hung up with a swipe that failed to cut the connection in time to miss Alicia's cackle. Because the swipe was unsatisfying, she tossed her phone violently onto the bed.

She picked it up. Why in the hell had her alarm not worked?

But before she was able to unravel *that* mystery, she saw the messages from Randy.

She had entered his name in her phone as Dr. McIntyre, almost unthinkingly. She still thought of him as "Dr. McIntyre" much of the time. Dr. McIntyre was Derek's dad, and the man she met for drinks and from whom she had solicited advice about Josh's fantasies. Dr. McIntyre was the

person she had thought would be a good choice for enacting Josh's fantasies.

But the messages were not from "Dr. McIntyre." They were from Randy.

Randy was the man Dr. McIntyre had turned out to be, and she wasn't sure what to think about *him*.

What time did you leave? Get home okay?

It was an innocuous message. Zoe wasn't sure what she had wanted it to be. She hated his brazen references to their sexual encounters, but she also felt disappointed that he hadn't even alluded to them.

Just thinking about Randy, even this convoluted mix of thoughts, had activated the raw pulse in her sore pussy. She let herself fall on her back on the bed, phone in hand. She closed her eyes. Maybe she could just lie here and let everyone else act. Whatever happened would be what happened, and she could just let it all happen however it would.

Her eyes flew open. She was late for work, and if there was one thing she knew for sure, it was that *oversleeping* was irresponsible. There wasn't any gray area there.

She jumped out of the bed, took a look at herself in the mirror, and decided a second shower was warranted.

She turned on the water and stripped out of her clothes. She remembered the dirty clothes from her night with Randy, which she had stuffed in the hamper hurriedly as she crept about the house, trying to deceive Josh, who she had assumed was sleeping, into believing she had arrived home earlier and been in bed all night while he slept.

Her heart skipped another beat. Josh.

Josh's message:

Okay... well, I tried calling you and I guess you lost track of time. So text me when you get this so I know you're okay. I'm having a hard time sleeping, thinking, Pete's giving me nightmares. I'm going to try to get some work done at Reggie's.

She couldn't have really gotten away with it, could she have?

It was almost worse that she had, because now if she continued to lie to Josh it was a deeper betrayal.

Unless she ended things with Randy.

She stared at her reflection in the mirror.

She *should* stop seeing Randy. It was something that had gotten out of control very quickly, something that had evolved into something much different than she had wanted it to be... than Josh had wanted it to be.

She fished her clothes violently out of the laundry hamper, taking out her anger at herself on the clothing. She set them on the bed in a bundle so she would remember to take them to the laundry room and get them in the washer before she left.

No sense having decisions made for her, by Josh finding cum-stained clothing in the hamper.

Her phone was on the bed. The message from Randy, unanswered, was nagging at her. Nagging at her to ignore it, nagging at her to respond to it. She wanted to run away from the entire situation with Randy, but she could feel a part of herself unwilling to do that. She didn't know what the pull was: loyalty? Deference? Sexual addiction? Or just fear, that if she did cut things off with Randy, she might never tell Josh the truth?

It could have been any one of those, she realized, her heart in free-fall, as she picked up the phone and typed a message to him.

Any one of those things, or all, or none.

Fell asleep. Had to get home. Late for work now.

She jumped in the shower, rinsed thoroughly again, taking extra time to wash her lower body as thoroughly as she had the night before, when she had sneaked in. While she was dressing, her phone rang, and she ran to it. She stared at the screen for almost ten seconds, her mind in turmoil, before answering.

"Hey," she said. Her voice sounded strange even to herself.

"Are you okay? You didn't call me. I'm starting to worry."

She assessed Josh's voice. It seemed... unnatural. But she couldn't place her finger on why. Was it because he knew that she was a liar, a woman who had answered the phone while another man fucked her? Was it because he didn't know that, and was just peeved at her for not calling him?

"Oh, God, I'm sorry." Zoe pushed her hair back. "I just... I got home, and I saw your note, and I was so tired... I went to lie down for a bit and then I just... fell asleep. I'm late for work right now, actually."

A pause.

"Some night."

Zoe buttoned her blouse and looked up at herself in the bathroom mirror. "Yeah," she said, as nothing else occurred to her. She felt the vibration of her phone in her hand, and somehow she knew that the text arriving was from Randy. Her organs felt like they were eels writhing inside of her abdomen.

"Josh," she said, when he didn't immediately answer. "I really have to go... I'll call you, I don't know, later, from the car or something -"

"That's okay. I just wanted to know if you were okay."

"Okay," Zoe said, distracted.

"Because you never called."

"I am sorry. Really." Zoe was scurrying down the hallway now. "Will you be home tonight? At like, a regular time?"

There was a pause. "Why? You thinking of going out with your... girlfriends again?"

Zoe's heart stopped, and she came to a halt in the hallway. Her guilty mind had expected to hear him say "Randy," and now she was unsure of whether or not a pause had existed between "your" and "girlfriends." Or if it was only her imagination.

"Josh, no, I just wanted to know if you're going to be home tonight, is all," she said, cross.

"Yes," Josh answered.

His tone seemed odd to her. His answer, too quick. But she wanted off the phone, so she said, "Great. See you then."

"I love you, Zoe," Josh was saying, but by then the phone was away from her ear and her thumb was already swiping.

"Oh wait!" she said, after the call had already ended.

She opened her messages to type, "I love you too," because this often happened and it was just... their shtick. But her eyes were held hostage by the messages from Randy.

What are you doing tonight?

I think you need some more practice.

I have a lot of things in mind.

Zoe tossed her phone in her purse after turning it off and muttered a stream of expletives as she twisted her feet into her shoes, and headed out the door.

She was in a real situation, and right now, she just needed to get to work.

CHAPTER 2

"Hey, hey, *trasnochada*." Alicia had appeared like a genie twenty seconds after Zoe's arrival, out of thin air. She leaned against Zoe's desk. Zoe's eyes went to her leopard-print blouse, not because it was Alicia's signature, over-the-top style, but because it actually looked classy under the black blazer and shockingly knee-length skirt she was wearing. It was an actual suit.

"Did you bring me my hamburger?" Alicia asked, but she was already peering into the take-out bag on Zoe's desk.

"Thanks for covering my ass," Zoe said, picking up the bag and handing it to Alicia.

Alicia pulled the hamburger out and unwrapped it, apparently in no hurry to leave. "You go to some club last night or something? You look like hell."

"Thanks. And no."

"Then what?"

"I'm sick."

Alicia was biting into her sandwich, and she edged herself off the desk in a movement that, like her personality, was plausibly deniable but radiated sass. "Uh-huh," she said, in the tone farthest away from credulity that one could get without screaming "LIAR!"

She started to walk away, and Zoe settled into her desk.

But Alicia gave a sudden about-face, and leaned over the cubicle wall, dangling her hamburger in one hand. "This about that guy? The old guy, Jag-shrink, the one with the huge dick?"

Zoe stared at her computer as a single cursor blinked in the left-hand corner. It was perhaps the third time her heart had stopped that morning.

She looked down at her keyboard. Shook her head, reached for a tissue, and sniffed. Unconvincingly, she said, "What guy?" And then, realizing that Alicia would sniff out her lies faster than she would sniff out a prospective lover in a bar, she turned and looked at her, scrunching up one cheek and making a face one makes for lying about things. "Randy? God, don't be - what the hell are you talking about?"

"Yeah? What'd you do then?" Alicia said, amused. She tore a piece of her hamburger off and popped it into her mouth.

"How can you eat that stuff this early in the morning?" Zoe said, trying to change the subject. "And stay so thin?!" she quickly added, because with women, it was always a good idea to distract with conversations about weight.

Alicia waved her hamburger. "Got a craving for this thing, you know I don't even like Wendy's?" She shrugged. "Who knows, maybe I'm pregnant. But don't try to change the subject on me. What did you do last night?"

"Not Randy."

Alicia arched an eyebrow. She smiled. She chewed. "Uh-huh," she said, even less credulously.

"I went... me and Josh went out for some drinks," Zoe squeaked.

Alicia bit into her hamburger and smiled. "But Dr. Randy does have a huge dick," she said, looking up at the ceiling. She looked back at Zoe. "Right? Tell me I am wrong."

Zoe had no idea what to say, so she stared at Alicia.

Alicia smiled, tore off a piece of bread from her burger, and pushed away from the wall. She spun around, still grinning, and tossed it into the air, catching it in her mouth as she headed away from Zoe's desk.

Zoe's hands were shaking slightly as she edged herself into her workspace as tightly as possible and began a day of pretending to work. Her phone, in her purse, determinedly turned off.

*

Zoe sipped her drink and stared at Alicia as she ordered two appetizers, both fried, and a margarita. She herself felt like she was going to throw up. She shook her head at the waiter and asked for a refill on her Coke, which she was drinking in spite of the outrageous number of unsatisfying calories it contained.

Alicia had made the unusual gesture of inviting Zoe to lunch, her treat. "You have to go," she had added. "Because I lied for you. And you have some splainin' to do, Lucy."

So here she was.

Alicia stuck a fingernail into her ice water and fished out a cube. She crunched it noisily while staring at Zoe. "So. You sleep with that Randy guy or what? And now you have a big problem?"

Zoe opened her mouth to deny it all, and then shook her head and looked down at the table. "It's... more complicated than that."

The waiter was somehow returning with Alicia's margarita already. "Can I get a Caesar, extra pickle juice, too, man?" she barked. He left, and Alicia played with her straw in her margarita. "You feeling bad about it? It's just a one-off. You gonna tell Josh?"

Zoe put her hands to her face. She wasn't sure if she wanted to hear what Alicia had to say about any of this, but there was no backing out now.

"What? You got some kind of thing with him? Don't tell me you love him or some stupid shit like that. Wasn't he the father of your ex-boyfriend?"

Zoe shrugged. When she looked up, Alicia mimicked her shrug with her "what-the-fuck?" face on. *Shrug. Shrug.* "What the hell is that supposed to mean? You don't know if he was your ex-boyfriend's dad, or you don't know if you love him?"

She fished another piece of ice out of her water. "Look," Alicia began. "You didn't confess this to me because you wanted someone to give you a hug, *chavita*. So just tell me." She muttered something in Spanish, but it seemed to be directed at the chip she noticed in her nail.

Zoe sat back as the waiter brought the Caesar, also remarkably quickly, and set it uncertainly in front of Alicia, who rolled her eyes at him. "You think I am drinking a margarita *and* a Caesar or something?"

The sentence began dangerously, but Alicia seemed to soften midway through, and ended with a huge smile. The waiter, who had begun to look like a man on a firing wall, looked relieved. Alicia waved at Zoe. "It's for her, *Cervantes*, she has a hangover. She doesn't normally look like that."

As he walked away, Alicia leaned out to look at his ass, which made her raise her eyebrows again in an indecipherable judgment. "Okay. So what are you doing with this guy... Randy, right?"

"I don't know," Zoe said. "I don't..."

She folded her arms over each other and looked at Alicia pointedly. "If I tell you something, can you promise to keep it a secret and tell no one at all?"

The thing was, she had a feeling that Alicia, for all her blabbing and flamboyant behavior, was actually a locked vault. She had never heard Alicia divulge a secret. She was blunt, and stated the obvious, but she wasn't the gossiping sort.

"Sure," Alicia said, an amused smile on her lips. "You can trust me. I never told a single soul that Gloria used to be a man, right?"

Zoe's mouth fell open before she caught the gleam in Alicia's eye and her wry grin.

"It's super personal," Zoe said.

Alicia leaned forward. "More personal than the fact that you are having an affair with your ex-boyfriend's dad?" She made a nasal sound that defied description.

"Yes," Zoe said.

"You have my complete attention. And discretion. *Te lo juro por mi difunta madre.*"

Zoe scanned the ceiling, grasping for her freshman-year Spanish class. "Your mom... isn't..."

Alicia ignited in a flurry of hand waving. "It's just an expression. *Coño*. Tell me what you are doing that is so much worse than doing that chunk of meat."

Zoe inhaled. Alicia stared at her.

"Okay, this is going to seem, like, really crazy. But... it's, you know, not. Or it wasn't. But I... so Josh had this thing he kind of, you know, wanted to do. For a long time. And I was like... not really so much into it, but we kind of like, played around with the idea. Just not... for real, sort of like -"

"Acting, yeah, got it," Alicia said impatiently, waving her hand again. "I got it. Now get to how you end up in bed with your daddy figure."

"No," Zoe said, recoiling. "No, not... ew, no it's nothing like that. It's..."

"Right. Okay," Alicia said.

Zoe fell silent. "That's not... that's so not what's..."

"No? Because I think I am hitting a nerve."

"You're not."

"Then just spit it out, *niña*, I swear to God, Jesus is going to walk through that door and make fish out of my chips before you finish this story."

Zoe had to smile. Just a little.

"Josh wanted to do this thing to you, and you didn't want to do it, but now you did it with Dr. *Bichón*? Is that it?"

"Not... exactly."

Alicia raised her eyebrows again.

Zoe looked at her fingers. "So... Josh, what he wanted to do wasn't exactly something *he* wanted to do to me, just, uh -"

"Oh, he wanted you to have a threesome or something?" She was watching Zoe's face while she asked this, and seemed to intuit that it wasn't exactly right. Nodding, like she had just diagnosed the cause of an irrational toddler's temper tantrum, she added: "Or... fuck some other guy while he watched?"

Alicia stated this so matter-of-factly that she made it seem like the conversation was over. She had been leaning on her fingers and watching Zoe intently, and now seemed to have lost interest. She picked up a menu and started scanning it.

Zoe stared at her.

"I think I maybe need something like a, like a..." Alicia made a motion with her hand that Zoe would have interpreted as "throwing up," if it had no context.

"...a salad. You want to split one of these salads with me or what?"

"No," Zoe said. She was still stuck on how quickly Alicia had come to her conclusion. Between Randy's quick assessment, and Alicia's, she was starting to think that Josh's fantasy wasn't nearly as uncommon as she'd assumed it was.

Alicia shrugged with her eyebrows and set the menu down. She leaned in to take a sip of her margarita through her straw. "So, what did you do, you said you would sleep with this guy Randy, and then what? Josh got jealous?"

Zoe put her hands to her face again and shook her head. "Oh God," she said. "No, not like that.. it was... ugh, it's just, a mess. I don't even know what happened."

Alicia stabbed at her margarita with the straw. "So, did you do it?" She asked. "With this Randy guy?"

Zoe nodded.

"And Josh knew about it?"

Zoe chewed her lip and stared at her water. "Sort of."

Alicia made a tsking noise. "*Ay, muñeca*. Okay," she said, leaning back against the booth with her margarita in hand. Her eyes were lit up with interest. "Tell me the story. First, drink that drink."

CHAPTER 3

"So," Alicia said, after listening to the whole story. "What are you gonna do?"

Zoe had her hands up to her temples. "What *should* I do?"

Alicia had been putting away margaritas at a rate that would have made their HR rep send her to rehab, but she seemed perfectly sober. "Look, Zoe, you want to keep fucking this guy Randy?"

Zoe hadn't answered.

"You want to keep lying to Josh?"

"No."

This answer had come quickly, without thought, and when she said it, she realized it was true. Maybe she didn't exactly know what she wanted to do with Randy, but she did know she didn't want to keep lying to Josh.

Alicia had shrugged. "Okay, so then, it seems pretty simple to me. You either have to tell Josh everything that happened, or you have to cut the cord with this guy Randy and just go to your grave without ever saying anything to Josh."

"Yeah but," Zoe had whined. "That's kind of like permanently lying."

"Well," Alicia said, lifting what seemed like her fourth margarita to her lips, "I have been married three times, and there is no way to get through it without telling some kind of lie."

"But you're not married now, so..."

"Not because of that, though." Alicia laughed, a short bark for whatever it *was* that ended her three marriages. "Look, either you have to lie and act like they're so great in bed, or like the way they chew their food like a fucking animal isn't annoying, or pretend like you don't know they look at Asian porn all the time, or whatever. But you have to lie."

"Josh and I aren't like that."

"You never tell a single lie," Alicia said incredulously.

"I didn't...no, no he's that kind of guy. That's why he could, you know, tell me this thing, and it's why I felt like I could handle it, and then... I don't know, I don't know what happened. I don't know why I thought it was a good idea to do it this way. It seemed like a good idea at the time."

Alicia smiled at her like she was a five-year-old with wet shoes. "I can tell you why. Because this Randy guy was trying to boink you and he was

all, 'Oh, I'm a wise older man *and* a shrink, so my advice is all professional and shit,' but at the end of the day, he was just telling you whatever you needed to hear so he could get into your *pantis*."

Zoe stared at Alicia. Then she shook her head. "He's... not like that. Anyway, I'm the one who brought it all up with him."

"Ah-ha." Alicia smiled.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

She leaned across the table and patted Zoe on the hand. "It means, maybe you had a thing for this guy and you let your unconscious, subconsciousness, whatever, drop a little hint about something. And then what did you expect to happen? He's a guy. Of course he was gonna plant all this..." Alicia waved her fingers next to her ear, "subliminal, psychotherapy shit in your head and tell you, 'oh, yeah, just have sex with me a bunch of times and that's what your husband wants.' Whatever you needed to hear to tip you over the edge, he was gonna say it."

She looked at Zoe plainly. "You got taken."

Zoe had snapped her mouth shut. Then she got angry.

Alicia, sensing her rising anger, had held up her hands as if in surrender. "Look, don't get mad at me about it, I am just telling you what I see. Maybe you wanted to get taken, maybe a part of you, maybe fifty-fifty, maybe one hundred percent. This guy was only telling you what you wanted to hear, right? I'm not saying you're stupid, I'm saying: you can't plant seeds where you don't have any *tierra*."

Zoe was so mad - at herself, she realized - that tears threatened to well up in her eyes.

Alicia plowed ahead. "So now you got a problem, so you have to figure out. What do you want to do about it?"

Zoe shrugged.

"You want to keep fucking this guy?" she asked again.

"Yes."

And there it was.

"But you don't want to lie to your husband." Alicia nodded sagely.

"Sounds to me like you have to pick one or the other." She had looked up at the ceiling then. "Dammit. It is always like that."

And then they had paid the bill and returned to work.

Alicia, of all people, had turned out to be a good listener, and to have the right advice. She would actually have made a pretty good therapist, if there was a market for getting verbally slapped into reality by a scarily tall woman from the Bronx.

She wanted to keep fucking Randy. The answer had come to her almost as immediately as the answer about not wanting to lie to Josh.

And Alicia was right: it looked like she had to choose one or the other.

Alicia was also right that she had been taken. As she drove home, thinking about all the conversations she'd had with Randy, all of his patient comments and veneer of a therapist, she realized that if she looked at it with Alicia's objective eye, she could see what Alicia saw. He had told her exactly what she wanted to hear, he had felt out her silly, girl-crush on him, and then he had exploited it.

And she had let him.

She had continued to ignore her phone all day, acting as if she didn't have one.

She knew there would be messages from Randy, and maybe even Josh, but she was afraid of how she would react to them. Her thoughts kept going in circles: getting angry at Randy, deciding to view his actions more charitably, getting mad at herself, getting mad at Josh for ever suggesting any of this, and then back around. And even though she didn't want them to, thoughts - purely *sexual* thoughts - about Randy continued to surface. His messages floated in front of her eyes, a transparent overlay on her computer screen:

What are you doing tonight?

I think you need some more practice.

I have a lot of things in mind.

I have a lot of things in mind. The words turned into an elixir and went right through her, warming her limbs, slithering right into her lower abdomen and pulsing, until her panties were wet and she was furious with herself - and him.

When she got home, Josh wasn't there. She sat down at the kitchen island and took her phone from her purse, setting it on the countertop gingerly, as if it were an explosive that would detonate with too rough handling. She stared at it for a while, her chest tight.

She didn't *have* to respond to Randy.

She could probably just ignore him until he went away. Delete his messages without reading them, act as if none of this had ever happened. He would get the message, wouldn't he? And then, it would be as if this transgression never existed. What Josh didn't know wouldn't kill him.

She hated being that kind of person, because she was the kind of person who valued directness and facing fears head-on. If she was going to go that route, the appropriate thing to do would be to tell Randy that everything was over, that she had misjudged her ability to deal with this situation.

But she realized that she was *afraid* of facing him, and deep down inside she knew it was because she was afraid of herself: she didn't trust that she would be able to break it off with him.

"You can't plant seed where there is no tierra," Alicia's voice sang in her mind.

And if she *did* break it off with Randy, then everything she had done would be viewed in a bad light by Josh if she decided to tell him about it. She didn't know if she could even explain to him how she had been gently pushed into this wild plan by Randy, because the truth was, she couldn't even understand it herself.

Or maybe she did. Maybe the dark truth beneath all of this was that she had lied to herself. She had convinced herself that she was doing this only because Josh wanted it, when in fact, she had feelings for Randy, and with that one self-deception, she had woven a web of lies.

She reached for the phone, and it lit up at that moment.

Josh.

All of her thoughts seemed to be sent down a tunnel, condensed into a moment of clarity, in that moment. She would just jump into it, tell Josh everything, and let the chips fall where they would. Josh deserved to know the truth, Josh was the one she really cared about in the end, if she had to choose -

Somewhere in the corner of her mind, the devil of her conscience piped up. *But what if you didn't have to choose?*

She quashed it. If she had to choose, and it seemed like she did, then she would choose Josh.

She pressed talk.

"Hey," she began, her voice hurried, almost frantic. She was just going to say it: *I need to talk to you. It's serious.* If she said that, then she would have to say the rest. Adrenaline filled her veins, tunnel-vision set in, everything was crisp and bright and moving in slow motion. Her mouth started to form the first word of her semi-confession. "I -"

But Josh cut her off. His own voice was also half-frantic. He sounded tired, and annoyed. "Zoe, please, please don't be annoyed with me," he said. "I have to - fucking Pete just dumped another rendition on me. I wanted to, I really wanted to get home early. I will be home by seven, I promise. I just... God, this guy is such a fucking dick."

Josh rarely cussed, and he rarely sounded flustered. There was something almost pathetic in his voice, and something odd. Zoe's confession came to an inelegant halt in her mouth. "I, but..."

And then she heard it. The whispery inhale, the background street traffic.

"Are you *smoking*?" she said, disbelief in her voice. Josh had quit years ago, and never so much as given the slightest indication that he had ever smoked a cigarette in his life. He wasn't one of those people who leaned in to sniff cigarette smoke, or seemed frazzled when people lit up around him, or even gave a furtive, longing glance at a smoker.

A sound came through the earpiece, of Josh blowing smoke in a steady stream from his mouth. "Zoe, this guy, I am like, so close to losing my shit."

He sounded furious as he rattled off a list of things that Pete Stark had done, all of which were too technical for Zoe to make sense of. But as he talked, she came to the conclusion that he was really stressed, and angry, and that tonight was *not* the right time to drop her Randy problems on him.

"Anyway. What did you say?"

"Huh?"

"You were about to say something when I called, and I just cut you off."

"Oh," Zoe said, feeling like a deer in the headlights. "Yeah, what... was... I can't even remember. Not important. Probably."

Josh was exhaling again. He was really smoking with a vengeance. "Sorry," he said, finally. "Look, I *will* be home by eight. Okay?"

"Yeah. Of course. No problem. I'll be here." She tried to sound cheerful and supportive.

There was a long pause. Josh exhaled again. "You don't have any wild dance parties to go to?" he said, just as she was planning to say goodbye.

She felt as if he had stabbed her in the heart. "I... no. Don't be silly," she said.

Another exhale. "Okay. I'll see you then."

"Josh?"

"Yeah?"

"I love you."

There was a pause, small, almost too minuscule to be measured. The sort of pause that no one but a guilty person could even hear.

"I love you too, honey. See you soon."

*

There were no additional messages from Randy.

Zoe stared at her phone, at the background picture of her and Josh. It was from their honeymoon, an extravagance they had indulged in, going to Bali.

Zoe tapped the phone to her lips, thinking. What had seemed like such a no-brainer just moments before now seemed like the worst idea ever. If Josh was smoking, and using bad language, and this angry, then he was really on the edge. Pete Stark was causing him no end of stress, and Josh was convinced that the guy had it in for him and wanted to get him de-listed from TopTier, which would be devastating for his freelance career.

So what, then?

Zoe knew that, at a moment like this one, it was probably best to do nothing. Assess, give it a day, and then choose a good course of action.

But that wasn't Zoe's style. Not once she'd decided to jump. She might not be able to jump the way she had wanted to, but she had already gone over the edge: she was jumping somewhere.

She tipped the phone away from her jaw and held it in both hands.

Then she started to type.

CHAPTER 4

"I have to be home by seven," she said, when Randy sat down across from her.

Randy was smiling at her, but she felt sure that something almost sinister flashed behind his eyes. "So something is up," he said, flatly. "Josh is mad at you about last night."

Zoe pressed her lips together and looked at the table. "Actually, it's... oh God, it's way more complicated than that."

A waitress came by with two beers and set them on the table. Randy held up a finger as she left. "Can you grab me a Bushmills single malt, darlin? No ice." He looked at Zoe, who looked back at him with her head between her hands. "Looks like I'm going to need it."

"Listen," Zoe said, dropping her hands. "I... I can't... I don't know where to start with this. So I'll just come out and say it." But when she tried to say it, her eyes got wet, and she found she didn't have the words leaving her mouth the way she wanted them to.

When she looked back at Randy, she could tell he was already anticipating it, but she couldn't read what he was thinking behind his expression.

"I have to break this off," she said quietly, gathering courage.

Randy seemed unconcerned, almost as if he had been expecting her to say that. "Is this because you got home late?"

"No."

She stared into her beer.

Randy took a sip of his.

"Did Josh change his mind?"

Zoe looked up at him. There was something so sanitized about his tone that she found it infuriating. She couldn't be sure *why* she found it infuriating: this was exactly the kind of relationship she had hoped to have with him. But there was a certain kind of arrogance in the way he was distancing himself from the issue using his psychotherapist-calm, and seemed to have expected this very conversation.

"It's just because..." she said, distracted by her thoughts about Randy's reaction. He waited patiently, like he knew the real answer or the real reason and wanted her to say something so that he could dissect it.

Infuriating.

"It just got too complicated. Okay? And I, I shouldn't have done it, and I wish I could go back and take it all back, but I can't. So... I have to..."

She had started to look out over the restaurant, because she couldn't stand the way Randy was looking at her. The waitress returned with his shot, and she wished briefly that she had one, too, but it wouldn't do her any good to get intoxicated when she had so much on her mind, so many delicate things to balance and to say, to Randy and, later, to Josh.

She looked back at Randy when he didn't say anything, and instead lifted his shot to his lips and sipped it calmly.

"Don't you have anything to say?" she shot at him.

Randy set his shot down. "Of course I have something to say."

She glared at him, but he didn't bite.

"Honestly, Randy, you are so infuriating right now."

He slid his arms across the table and placed them on top of hers, picking them up and bringing them together in his. "Zoe. This was always about your relationship with Josh. So, if things are too complicated for you, then they are too complicated for you."

"That's it?"

Her voice was shrill, and she hated it.

Randy set her hands down, placing them carefully, as if they were pieces of fine porcelain. As he did so, he looked at them, as if they were objects he might consider purchasing.

"What about it is too complicated? This is a question out of curiosity, no more."

Zoe squinted. "What do you mean?" she said, exasperated for some reason. "This! Everything. Getting... home so late, and, and... you know. Just all of it. Anyway. Josh is in a bad place right now, and it's not the right time -"

"But you've already done it."

Zoe looked at Randy, and the sinister thing she'd believed she'd seen earlier was back. It flashed, and then disappeared, so she couldn't say with any certainty that she had even seen it.

His words, however, spilled a cold liquid into her blood. She couldn't think of anything to say, but Randy was looking at her, probing with his eyes.

"Wh - what?" she sputtered.

"You've already done it. And you haven't told Josh about it."

Anger flashed through Zoe. "How do you know that?" she countered.

Randy just smiled. "And so, you know, if what you want to do now is end it, that's of course your choice. But then it's going to be something very different, isn't it? Then, you'll just have cheated on him."

"Wha...?" Zoe said, disbelieving.

"Also," Randy said, tapping on the back of her hand gently with his pointer finger, and then trailing it down her finger in a way that - maddeningly - sent a thrill straight to her pussy, "I know that's not really what you want to do."

Zoe withdrew her hand sharply and made an outraged face. "Don't tell me what I want to do and don't want to do," she said.

Randy picked up his shot glass and sipped it again. "Okay," he said with a smug grin.

Zoe stared at him, heart racing, fury building, and, to her great chagrin, a strange arousal building inside of her.

"It's six-thirty," Randy said, while she grappled with what to say to him.

Zoe slammed her purse on the table and began to dig through it, to give him some cash for her beer. The beer, barely drunk, sloshed in the glass and some of it spilled over.

"Don't worry about it," Randy told her.

Zoe sighed, and then stood up, because she didn't have any cash anyway. "Okay. Well," she said, slinging her purse over her shoulder. "I'm glad we got this out of the way. Thanks for, you know. Understanding."

"Call me any time."

"I won't," she said, her voice necessarily harsh.

Randy just looked at her, and nodded with the kind of slow, knowledgeable way that wise old characters in movies do. It made her want to scream inside, but she didn't. She turned, suddenly uncertain about her ability to walk, and after a beat to steady herself, she left, walking as steadily as she possibly could.

CHAPTER 5

For several weeks, Josh wondered if maybe he had gone a little bit crazy. Perhaps in his zeal for his fantasy, and with all the extra hours he had been working, he had imagined something that wasn't even there. How could he know? He had a phone log of a long call, but no recording of it. Maybe he *hadn't* heard Zoe panting and slurping, or Randy telling her to do filthy things. Was it possible that he had simply heard noise in a club, and his mind had interpreted how he had wanted it to be?

And *didn't* want it to be.

Zoe had seemed ready to tell him something when he had called her the evening after, but he had let Pete Stark get inside his head, and had blown her off.

After that, she hadn't brought anything up.

Maybe there was nothing to bring up.

Time piled up between the present and *that* phone call, and Zoe seemed perfectly normal every day. He had even devised an elaborate situation to obtain her new PIN on her phone, and she had given it to him without hesitation. When he asked why she had changed it, she paused, and looked at the ceiling, but then seemed to find an actual memory there. "You know that creep Danny at work? He saw it, and I just thought... better safe than sorry."

His subsequent, furtive forays into her phone turned up nothing of interest. No "Randy" in her contacts, no messages, no phone calls logged late at night or to unknown numbers.

With all this contradictory evidence, he started to believe that maybe it had all been a figment of his imagination: maybe he hadn't heard what he thought he had heard on the end of that phone line. Maybe it was just what he had secretly *wanted* to hear.

And then he wondered if he should just tell her, outright, and see how she reacted.

But as the idea of it all being in his imagination took hold, he was reluctant to burst the strange twilight he was living in: a world in which both things were possible. Maybe his wife *was* a cheating slut, and maybe she wasn't, and would never be. Simultaneously, both possibilities were tantalizing, both possibilities disappointing and awful.

If he never *asked* her about it, though, and never found out which version was true... then he could enjoy this place where the best of each world was true because he wanted it to be. He could enjoy the idea that his wife had fucked Randy like a whore and sneaked around behind his back, but also feel reassured that his wife would never do that.

And so time passed, and even the thrill of these two ideas began to wane, and whole days would go by where he barely gave it a thought.

And then, one Thursday, he got off work early.

*

Randy's car, on top of everything, was not even parked in an inconspicuous place. It was right there, in front of the house, gleaming and black and extremely expensive. Josh pulled over at the end of the street, staring at Randy's vehicle, unable to believe what he was seeing.

It *could* have been anyone's car. But it was not. He knew that it wasn't, and he knew that something was wrong, because Zoe's car was parked in the driveway as well.

At three pm, on a weekday.

The realization that he'd been *had*: that the phone call he had overheard had not only *not* been a fantasy or a figment of his imagination, but part of a larger chain of lies and infidelities that Zoe had seemingly been hiding so well as to make him mistrust his own ears, poured over him like slow-moving, ice-cold lava.

His wife was at *their* house right now. So certain that she wouldn't get caught, or so careless, that she just allowed Randy to park right there, and they were...what? Fucking in their bed?

Because he loved Zoe, there was a part of his brain that was still pleading with the rest of his mind - the reptilian, adrenaline-fueled basal ganglia that was quickly taking over the show - that part of his brain was quietly suggesting that, like the phone call, this was all part of an elaborate game on Zoe's part. She knew he enjoyed something about catching her, having her cheat on him, and she was just orchestrating it all for his pleasure.

This voice was gone by the time he was halfway down the street. He was walking like a gangster, like a crazy person about to shoot up a post office, and he could feel it in the way his eyes never wavered, his mind could only see down the tunnel of his very narrowed vision, and his legs

moved fast, but heavily. He was now a man on a mission, facing something terrible.

There was a hedge of cedar that obscured their front "porch" - a small slab of granite on which you could precariously perch a single chair. So he was walking like this, cool and disturbed, eminently arrestable, halfway down the block, before a view of the porch cleared the hedge and he saw that Randy and Zoe were on the porch.

His mind, now reduced to a sort of primordial, survivalist set, was already moving his legs and his body to the right, before the image of them even registered in his consciousness. He kept walking, now over people's small lawns and tiny walls, the hedge between them. He walked right up to it, not bothering to try to creep. He was a man who didn't care if he was caught, but also didn't care if he wasn't.

Zoe was holding the door handle in both hands, behind her back, and she was shaking her head. Randy's body language was hard to read, but he seemed like a man who was explaining a dull subject to someone.

Josh strained to hear.

"...shouldn't even be here..."

Randy's voice was too low to hear.

"Well, he isn't!" Zoe hissed. "So.... because I told you this isn't..."

Randy reached for Zoe's arm at that point and gripped her forearm. A pang traveled through Josh as he watched their eyes lock. Randy's lips were moving, and Zoe was frozen, a deer in the headlights, unable to make a decision.

Randy began to step toward her, and she looked up at him. Their lips were coming closer together, and Zoe seemed mesmerized.

When their mouths met, Randy went in deep, hands moving to behind her head and around her waist. Zoe's arms, rigid just moments before, began to sink, floating limply to her side.

But just as suddenly, she wrenched free of his kiss, and stepped to the side, holding her hand up. "Randy, I can't. I can't do this!"

Randy leaned in and whispered something in her ear, and then smiled, and trotted away to his car.

When he opened his car door, Randy was in a position to see Josh, who was now standing, angry, staring openly at him. Randy looked up at Zoe, who put her fingers to her lips and then hurried inside. He could have seen

Josh - Josh almost willed him to see him, but Randy either did not, or did not care. He just smiled, and dropped into his vehicle.

Josh stood by the hedge for a long time, unable to move. The door to the house was closed, he was standing on his neighbor's lawn, and Randy was long-gone. He didn't know how long he stood there like that, or why he had been so desensitized to time by what he had seen. This was only a shock to see because he had convinced himself, somehow, that something he had heard with his own ears hadn't happened.

He walked back to the car and drove up to their driveway. Then he sat in the car.

Why was he unsure of what to do? It wasn't rocket science: he could just walk into his house, talk to his own wife, and tell her what he knew. What was stopping him from doing that?

He knew what it was, of course. He knew that the feeling in his stomach and chest, so close to sickness, was also a feeling he liked. That watching Zoe being touched by another man made his cock hard. That confronting Zoe about it might put an end to everything he *liked* about it, in his darkest of hearts. Did he like it enough to live with it? Did he like it enough to let it play out, whatever the consequences were for his marriage?

Because he also hated it. He hated that Zoe had resisted his fantasy for so long, and he had seen that as loyalty to him, an inability to imagine herself with another man. And then when he had finally reached a point where he thought she might actually jump off the cliff *with him*, she had actually gone off and done it all by herself. Nothing about how much he liked her fucking another man could dilute the betrayal that he felt. Even if the betrayal was hard to describe.

How long was he there? It was anybody's guess. He retreated to a place inside of his own mind, where there were no thoughts, and stared at the stucco and burned cedar exterior of his home.

He had no idea how long Zoe was standing there before he noticed her. She was frozen when he looked over at her, almost in mid-stride, mid-expression, phone in hand, purse over shoulder, on her way to something, evidently. She was looking at him, her mouth open, surprise on her face. He studied it. Was it fearful surprise, the kind we feel when we are caught? Or just the funny surprise, of seeing someone we don't expect?

After he looked at her, she slowly lowered her hand. She gave a look around, not in the way you do if you are looking for something, or someone. The kind of look you give to a place you want to remember. Or at least, that's what it seemed like to Josh.

She walked around her own, poorly parked vehicle to the passenger side of his car. She opened the door and looked in, but neither of them said anything. She could have asked why he was there, sitting in the car in the driveway. He could have asked her where she was going, or if she was going somewhere. But neither of them said anything.

Zoe sat down in the passenger seat, but left the door open. She looked at the stucco exterior, and Josh watched it too. As if they were there for a movie.

Zoe inhaled. "I have to tell you something," she said. Her voice was clear, strong, resolute. Josh looked over at her. The corners of her eyes were wet. His stomach was hurtling toward the floor, pulling his heart with it. What would she tell him?

Until that moment, it had actually never occurred to him, and he couldn't imagine why, that Zoe might tell him she was leaving. He had been so obsessed with her cheating, with the fantasy of it, with the mysterious explanations for why it happened - and then, as time had gone by, if it had even happened at all - that he had never entertained the idea. The idea that now seemed so real, so frighteningly close: what if the conversation he had just witnessed was Zoe telling Randy she would talk to him today? What if Randy had stolen her from him, and she was just trying to find the right time, or the right way, to say it?

An excruciating cold slithered through him, and the tunnel vision returned. He did feel now as though he were watching a movie.

"I've been trying to find a way to tell you something," she said, after the silence went on for a long time. Then she turned to him, as if something had just occurred to her. She frowned and wrinkled her brow. "Why are you out here in the car, just sitting?"

"Tell me what you wanted to tell me," Josh said. His voice was hoarse.

Fear lit up in Zoe's eyes. "Josh," she said, and her voice cracked this time. She looked behind them, through the back windshield. Her eyes darted around, then back to his.

"Hmm," he said, tonelessly.

Her eyes again went to the rear window, then back to his. Her lips were parted, and he stared at them. What was she about to say? What *had she been* about to say? He would never know. He would only know what she said now, and it felt like a moment that would reveal to him the depth of the fissure carving through their marriage. It was terrifying.

"Did you see Randy, just now?" she asked him.

"Randy," Josh repeated. He hadn't meant to sound like he did, sarcastically confused. Zoe frowned, looked behind them again, then at her phone, then back at the stucco wall. "Never mind. I mean, no, not... not never mind, completely..." She sighed loudly, as if exasperated with herself. "It has to do with Randy."

Josh stared at her.

She looked over at him. "What I want to tell you. It has to do with him. He was just... oh, God, it doesn't matter, he was just here, but that doesn't... it isn't what..." She looked up at the ceiling. "Oh God," she sighed. "I'm not making any sense. None of this makes any sense, I don't know what, or how it happened, and I really screwed something up."

"You slept with Randy."

Josh said this like the simple fact that it was. His voice indicated that it wasn't a guess, and it made Zoe's head snap toward him. "Wha - how did... you *knew*?"

Josh shrugged and looked at the stucco.

"So what was this, then? Randy is giving you some kind of ultimatum?" Josh sounded angrier than he wanted to. And this wasn't the question he wanted to ask, or the way he wanted the conversation to go.

Zoe stared at him. Her demeanor was changing. She bristled and stared at him, and in the periphery of his eye he could see that her mouth was open in surprise, surprise that was turning quickly to anger. "You *knew*?" she said, in a raging whisper.

Josh turned to her, resting his hand on the steering wheel, and gave her an incredulous look. *Of course I knew*, his face said. He wished, somewhere inside, that he could change the expression, but it came out of him anyway, an old defense from a lifetime of relationships and dealing with them the same way, over and over again.

Zoe sat back and made an astonished face, staring again at the stucco siding. "What the fuck, Josh?" she said.

"Me, 'what the fuck?' I'm not the one who fucked Randy all night."

"But you are the one who asked me to. Or am I getting something wrong here?"

Zoe shot him a mean look.

"I remember saying that I wanted to *see you with another man*, not have you sneak around on me with another man."

"Except," she said, waving her finger in an upside-down circle that she used whenever she was making a point that she felt she was absolutely correct about, "you *did* see me with another man, evidently, so... I guess you got what you wanted." She faced the wall again, and then yelled loudly.

"Agggghh!"

She put her hands out, fingers spread wide, and then clenched her fists. "This is so *not* how I wanted this conversation to go. This is not, this is not what I wanted... I wanted to tell you, I wanted to explain... dammit."

She got out of the car and slammed the door, walking quickly up the steps of the house.

He paused, his blood raging inside of him. Then he got out as calmly as he could, locked the car, and entered the house.

Zoe was trying to uncork a bottle of wine in the kitchen, and she glared at him when he walked in, because she was so angry that she was making a hack job of it.

He held out his hand, and she glared, and twisted, and glared some more, before handing it over to him. "Whatever you saw just now, it isn't what you think."

He set the wine bottle down and put his hands on the counter. "What about what I heard?"

Zoe looked at him, blinking. He fished his phone out of his pocket, and swept through it, pulling up the log of the hour and fifteen-minute long conversation from so many weeks ago, when he had overheard her and Randy.

But by the time he turned the screen to Zoe, realization was already blanching her face.

"It's more than an hour long," he said, and Zoe paled again.

She shook her head and looked down at the counter. "Fuck," she whispered. "God, I was so *stupid*." She put her hands to her face. Shook her

head again. When she sniffed, he could hear the lump growing in her throat. "Josh," she began, but the words caught in her throat.

"So, what, have you been fucking him all the time? How long?"

"That isn't... listen, I know this sounds like a cliché, but it's not what... it's not *exactly* what's going on here. It got... oh, Josh. It just got so complicated. I don't even know what happened." She wiped her nose.

"So complicated," Josh repeated. "So what, are you going to move in with this guy now? How long were you going to keep having an affair before you told me? If you hadn't gotten caught?"

Zoe looked at him with fiery eyes and wiped a tear impatiently away. "No!" she said. "No, that... that isn't what happened! This wasn't an affair. This is what *you* told me *you* wanted -"

"I said sneak around on me? I don't remember saying that!"

"That's not how it started! God!" Zoe pushed her hair from her face with both hands and shook her head again. "This isn't... that isn't what was going on."

"No?"

"No."

Deep down inside, he wanted to reset the conversation, but he was too enraged to do it. He reached for the wine bottle without looking and viciously twisted the cork out. "Get some glasses," he snapped at Zoe.

She looked at him, a brief cloud of fury brewing in her eyes, but then turned toward the cabinet with the wine glasses. "It started out as what you wanted. That's... all it was. I just didn't want to do it, like, I was nervous about it. I wanted to surprise you, I had all these conversations with Randy, and, I don't know, really, how it happened. I really don't."

"You don't know how his dick ended up in your pussy? Rea-"

"No, not that, not...fuck. Please just listen to me." She slammed the glasses on the table, and it was a miracle they didn't break. She reached for the wine and poured two glasses, sloppily, to the brim, before setting the barely half-full bottle down with the same, barely contained rage. Wine sloshed all over the place as she lifted her glass, and then set it back down before taking a sip.

"What I wanted to do, how this whole thing started," she said icily, "was that I wanted to do something for you. I wanted to surprise you. Randy seemed like... I don't know. The best choice. Or maybe, maybe I was

only willing to actually go through with it because Randy showed up again in my life. I have no idea. All I know is that I really did - really, Josh, you have to believe me - go into this with the intention of just... you know, doing something you wanted." She looked up. Her eyes were wet, and her face was contorted into what seemed to be a genuine expression of pain. It struck him right in the heart. "I don't know where it went wrong, I really don't."

His heart started to fall again, and he felt like everything in his abdomen was also falling, getting sick, getting exhilarated, full of pain.

"How wrong did it go?" he managed to say.

There it was, the question. There was no turning back from it.

Zoe's wet eyes overflowed. She shrugged, looked at her wine glass, sniffed, and blinked a tear from her eyes, which she impatiently wiped away. "Well, you tell me," she said.

For a moment he almost yelled back at her, "What the hell is that supposed to mean?!" But it caught in his throat, which was also forming a lump, a feeling he hadn't experienced since childhood. "Tell you," he repeated. "Wait, Zoe... what are we talking about, here?"

Zoe looked up from her wine. "What?"

"What happened, exactly? With you and Randy?"

"Uh... I mean... you said you heard it," she said, wiping a tear from her eye. "And then... I mean, that was the second time."

Josh felt his insides moving in directions he hadn't ever thought possible.

"I knew then that the plan was, you know, not going the way I thought it would. I'm sorry, I didn't expect him to be... when I talked to him about it at first, Josh, I swear, he really seemed like, I don't know, he was giving professional, clinical advice. You know? And I thought I could do it, under those circumstances, and just... push the boundaries a little bit. But... and I see now, I see that Randy just sort of... led me into it, he made me think it was my idea, but I think it was his all along -"

"What? What was his idea?" Josh interrupted, suddenly confused and impatient.

Zoe wiped under her eye again. "What?"

"Yes, what? *What* was his idea? This was... my idea, and then... your idea. What was Randy's idea?"

Zoe was slowly shaking her head. "No, not...this is what I'm talking about, it's so hard to explain. It was your idea - to, you know. And then *I* had the idea to talk to Randy about it and feel it out. I... I don't know, it was just a big coincidence that he showed up at that place and we got to talking about everything, and so he was just, like... available. To talk to."

Something almost accusatory glinted in Zoe's eyes. Josh hadn't ever really thought about Zoe needing to talk to someone about this, and begrudgingly, he had to admit that had been a mistake.

Zoe continued after taking a sip of wine. "So, I just wanted to talk to him, because he's a shrink, because we had that kind of advice-giving relationship, because...I don't know, I was drunk. All of those things. Talking to him about it just kind of... happened. And he was like... oh, yeah, this kind of fantasy is common, and normal, and can really strengthen relationships. And then when I talked to him about doing it - you know, with him - he was like, 'oh, I'd be honored if you'd do it with me, Zoe, oh, yeah, it's normal to be nervous...' and then, I don't know. It almost felt like *I* suggested it - to 'practice,' you know? Before I actually surprised you with it. Just so that, when I actually did it, I wouldn't back down or feel weird about it, and also because..." she paused, and inhaled sharply. "Because Randy has a, you know, really big..."

She looked up at Josh. "But now I see that he kind of... walked me into it. Maybe he manipulated me, I don't know. It's so hard to really, like, *describe* what happened. But then, it was just too much, and I just felt like... it was wrong, it had gone wrong, it wasn't the right thing after all. Like, I had gotten into something with Randy that wasn't turning out to be what I intended. At all. So I broke it off with him - and I was going to tell you about it, I really was. But then you had all this work stuff, and I thought maybe because I wasn't going through with it like... with you watching, then it would be, I don't know, something you didn't want."

She looked at him, and her expression turned helpless again. Her hands went limp with her arms and fell to the counter. "This isn't making any sense. I know. I don't really..." she wiped a tear from her right eye as she looked up. "I don't know what happened. I just... I started with good intentions, and then I was in this place where I thought that being honest wasn't going to be the best thing, and then I felt terrible about it, but it was over... and now Randy is like, showing up here unannounced, and I just... I

wish I had never done it." She looked down, and blinked, a tear rolling down her cheek.

"I really do," she said quietly. "I wish I could take it all back."

Josh didn't know what to say. He sat down on a stool, numb. The minutes ticked by.

"Why did he come over here? Today?" Josh asked.

Zoe rubbed her nose, and it was wet and squished a little. "He just... God, Josh, it's so embarrassing, okay? But... I might as well tell you. He came by, I haven't been returning his calls or his messages. Or, not all of them. But, yeah, I don't know: I wanted to just cut things off and it just didn't work like that. And then he came over, and he wanted to talk, and he's such an arrogant bastard, and I know he's like, manipulating me, and I hate it, and I know I need to just tell him to fuck off, but the thing is, I don't. Not entirely." She looked at Josh. "He's got some kind of power over me," she said weakly, her lower lip trembling. "I don't want him to, but he does. But I am still not, like, anything," she said, with a sweep of her hand that Josh supposed meant "zero sexual activity."

She looked earnest, and defenseless, when she said this.

He looked at his wine. "What kind of power does he have over you?" he asked her.

"I don't know!" Zoe said, a little more quickly and with more exasperation than he had anticipated. "I just *told* you -"

"Is it emotional, Zoe, or is it just sexual?"

"It's..." She narrowed her eyes. "I hadn't..."

"Don't invent your answer," Josh said.

"Josh, I love *you*. That's why... that's why all of this. From even thinking of doing this, to... to..."

"So what is it?"

Zoe looked at him for a long moment. Then down at the counter. "Honestly?" she said. "Maybe both. Mostly... sexual. You now? Which really gets under my skin. In fact, now that he's being so... so... I don't know, he's like, so arrogant and dark, *now* it's maybe 99% sexual." She paused. Inhaled. Her voice was shaky as she spoke. "But I'm going to be honest, because, I mean, I think you know the truth anyway... it didn't start out like that. I *wanted* it to be that way, and I think he recognized that I did, and gave me the illusion of what I wanted. So that I would do it, and then

he banked on my emotions getting..." she sighed up at the ceiling, looking for the words. "Tangled up," she finished at last.

Josh stared at the counter. His feelings were still fighting with each other in his chest, and they were the same feelings, but they pulled him in different directions now.

"That's why I say it was a mistake. And that I wish I could take it back."

Josh wanted to forgive her, and at the same time he didn't.

"I just want to... make it okay, Josh. That's what I wanted to say."

"What did he say to you?"

"Wha?" Zoe sniffed.

"What did he say?" Josh said, looking up at her. "At the door, after he kissed you and you said 'I can't do this?' He leaned in to your ear and said something. What did he say?"

Tears welled up in her eyes, but Zoe jutted out her chin. Josh knew he was going to get the truth.

"He said," Zoe told him, and then wavered for a moment. She looked down at her hand. "He said, 'you'll change your mind, because you can't get enough of it.' "

Josh ground his teeth. "And? Would you?"

"What?"

"*Have* you changed your mind? Not been able to get enough of it?"

"Why do you think I'm telling you all this?!" Zoe almost shrieked.

"And what the hell were you doing spying on me? Do you have *any* idea how bad I've been feeling?"

"Seems to me like your problem is that you've also been feeling pretty good."

Zoe glared at him, and then a light bulb seemed to go off in her head. "Why *didn't* you say something to me? If you knew?" But her eyes dropped to his crotch, even though she couldn't possibly see it through the counter, and he knew that she had already figured out the answer.

"So I'm not the only one who can't decide what I want," Zoe said quietly.

It was fair, and it hit him like a punch to the face. As much as he wanted to blame everything about this on her, it wasn't all her fault, and he knew that.

He inhaled shakily. "Zoe... I... God, I don't know either."

"Why are you so mad, if this is what you wanted me to do?"

Josh rubbed the side of his face. "I just wanted you to do it differently I guess."

Zoe let out a long sigh. She shook her head and looked at her wine. "I always figured there wasn't any way for this to work," she said.

Josh stared at his fingers. "Maybe we just should have been more honest with each other?" he suggested. He tried to make his tone lighter than the conversation, because now that a few minutes had gone by and he'd had some time to let the words and the story sink in, it wasn't nearly as infuriating as he'd originally thought.

"You can say that again," Zoe said, even managing to smile.

There was a long pause. Their tentative truce - that's what it felt like - had pushed the queasiness from the forefront of Josh's physical reactions, and now he was turned on again.

"So what are you going to do?" he said quietly, looking up at Zoe on the last syllable.

Zoe furrowed her brow in confusion and a little smile flickered through her lips. "I'm... what do you mean? I'm not going to see him anymore, if that's what you mean."

Josh shrugged. "Is that because of... all of this? Or because you just don't want to see him anymore?"

Zoe looked confused, and then she looked interested. "What are you saying?" she asked.

Josh shrugged. "I mean, as surprises go, it wasn't the worst idea you ever had."

"Oh, no?" Zoe said, coming around the counter. She leaned against it and looked at him. Because he was leaning on the island with his elbows, legs apart, feet on the bottom rung of the stool, she had a clear view of his crotch when her eyes dropped to take a quick look. She would easily have seen his cock burgeoning against his pants, he knew: his erection was so huge that he was pressing painfully against the seam, and he could feel the fabric stretching away from his thighs.

"If it had just been executed with a little more... I don't know... communication, or something, then..."

"Hmm," Zoe said.

"The truth is," Josh said, as Zoe slid closer to him, leaning on his side of the counter now with her elbows behind her. He placed his hands on her abdomen. "That call was pretty hot. Really hot. That's sort of the reason I didn't say anything to you. In fact, I think I was partly holding out hope that you had done it on purpose."

Zoe was sliding her right knee past his, her small thigh brushing against his as she wiggled into the space and rested her arms on his shoulders. Her skirt got bunched up as she did this, and he could feel the heat of her pussy near his knee. She dropped a hand to his crotch, and her fingers sought out the shape of him, crammed against the seam of his pants. Her touch was light, sending shivers through him. His cock pulsed, and he shifted in slight discomfort. "Zoe," he breathed.

Her fingers were at the button of his pants now, her other hand joining the first to unbutton them. She leaned close to his ear, and her breath was hot as it slid over his skin, making the hairs on his neck stand up on end and another ripple of arousal travel over his shoulders and back. "Maybe," she said, in a low voice, "we could pretend...?"

Her fingers tugged at his zipper, and he leaned back to allow them to work it down. The relief of his cock being freed, though still bound by his boxers, made him suck in his breath. Her fingers traced the shape of him again, hotter now through the thinner fabric. "I'm trying to think," she was whispering, "of what you might have heard."

Her lips floated along his jawline, while her fingers stroked his cock, and then her mouth was just in front of his, and she was looking at him with her large, pretty eyes, still damp from the crying she had held back just moments before.

She kissed him, and her mouth was hungry and wet. He plunged his tongue into her, and her tongue darted around his. He bit gently into her lower lip as they took a breath. His hands, which had somehow been paralyzed for a few moments, came back to life, sliding under her shirt, feeling their way over her hot skin to the wire of her bra, and then over the silky fabric, to her tightening nipples.

"I had to use my imagination," he murmured.

"And what did you imagine?"

He edged off the stool, a little clumsily, pushing Zoe up and backward, kicking the stool behind him so that it tipped dangerously and threatened to

fall over. As he did, he pulled her shirt up and she lifted her arms to let him peel it off her. He tossed it away and looked at her before kissing her: she had a smile on her lips, and a mischievous, foreign light in her eyes. He put his hand on her neck, felt her pulse against his fingers, and held her jaw so that he could tip her head back. "You tell me, what was I listening to?"

She closed her eyes and bit into her lower lip, then opened them. "I guess, if it was after you called, then he pulled me back on the bed, and started to finger-fuck me in the ass."

The picture materialized in his mind with each word: Zoe on all fours, Randy looking down to watch his fingers plunging into her ass. Her fingers were working his pants and boxers down, and she somehow had the flat of her palm on the tip of his dick, where precum moistened her skin and made it slide over him as she moved her hand in a circle. "Zoe," he breathed again.

"Randy told me you would like it if I gave you a really dirty, slutty, porn-star performance," she said, and his cock bounced around, which made her drop her eyes. An expression of pleased surprise transformed her mouth. Her eyelashes fluttered as she brought her gaze back to meet his eyes. "I think he wanted to work me up to taking it in the ass."

Josh couldn't move, except for his cock, which lurched wildly against her hand. He took in a deep breath and stared at his wife. "Was he right about that? Did you..." Josh breathed, almost afraid to ask the question. "Did you do it?"

She gripped his cock, starting a leisurely stroke. The veins of his dick pulsed against her palm, and he knew she could feel it. She wouldn't have to do much to make him come. He dropped his hand and held her wrist, stalling the next stroke. She smiled, and he saw in her face the delight that she sometimes got - rarely, truth be told - in her ability to drive him wild.

"We never got that far," she said, and he had to close his eyes and think of something, anything, to stop himself from coming in her hand.

He pushed her hand along his shaft to the end and away from him. His stomach was on another wild ride, cold and twisting and falling and rising, but whatever he was feeling there was drowned out by the ache in his dick, the throbbing of his own blood in his ears.

"Maybe you want me to show you," she said, almost innocently, fluttering her eyelashes again.

His cock responded for him, bouncing against her.

She slid away and caught his hand as she began to walk toward the corridor to the bedroom.

He followed, his eyes on her mostly bare torso, watching the strap of her bra slip from her right shoulder. The hall was dim, shadows playing over her skin until she reached the bedroom, where light was streaming in. The bed was unmade. She dropped his hand and climbed onto it, turning to face him while she reached behind her back to unhook her bra. Her hair was loose and messy now, and she tossed it, as if to get it over her shoulder, but it wasn't long enough and fell back across her cheek, obscuring one eye.

The bra fell away from her shoulders and peeled away from her breasts before falling to the bed. She unzipped her skirt next, shimmying from side to side to push it down to her knees. Then she hooked her fingers under her panties and slid them lower as well. With her eyes locked on his, she leaned forward, onto her elbows, her bare ass in the air. She scooted back, and turned her head to the side, her cheek to the pillow as she took her hair and spread it out on the bed. "I was just like this," she said.

Josh pulled at the back of his shirt to get it over his head, and shook his hips to get his pants to fall down completely. He stepped out of them and stared at Zoe as he walked around the side of the bed, looking at her face and her long arms splayed by her head, her hair spread out. He got on the bed behind her, on his knees.

"I didn't have a skirt on," Zoe purred.

He pulled at the bunched fabric of her skirt and her panties to free her legs, and after he did, she spread them apart. Her pussy was glistening and engorged. Above it, her tiny pink eyelet - a place he very rarely visited, and only then when they were extremely drunk, hovered above it, looking as tiny and unviolated as always.

"He was fucking me while he finger-fucked my ass," Zoe told him, bringing her fingers to her lips. "His cock is so big. I was scared the first time he fucked me, but he said you would like it. He said I would like it."

Josh reached out and made a circle on her anus with the tip of his finger, pleased that she shivered when he did.

"Do you want to hear the filthiest part?" Zoe said, in a low whisper. She pushed her ass toward him, lining her soaked pussy lips up with the tip of his cock. He sank into the silky hot wetness and her nether lips closed

around his crown. He gritted his teeth, so close to exploding all over her without so much as an actual touch that he was sure he would go over the edge from this alone. *The filthiest part...*

He was contemplating if he could hear it, but Zoe seemed to have decided that she was going to go ahead. She pushed herself up and her pussy encased his cock. He heard himself exhale, digging his fingers into her flesh just above her hip. She tossed her hair again, to the side, and looked back at him. Her eyes locked with his just when his balls met the sticky wetness of her pussy, and he could feel her engorged clit pulsing. "While I was on the phone with you," she continued, "he let a big drop of spit land right on my ass."

Josh groaned, and Zoe slid forward, and then back. The image of Randy's spit landing in the center of her tiny hole while she said goodbye to him seized his entire body. "Zoe," he said. "I'm going to come if you keep..."

But he was lost, he already knew, and Zoe pushed herself back against him, her ass meeting his thighs. She moaned, and her pussy tightened around his cock. He tried to hold her steady, but she arched her back and tilted her hips, and the resulting movement tipped him over the edge. As his cum boiled inside of him, he grasped her by the hips and sawed violently in and out, three times, while his cum exploded inside of her, making her sodden pussy squelch. He could tell that she was close, so even as the final squirts left his dick and the pleasure became excruciatingly intense, almost to the point of pain, he continued to fuck her until a shrill scream left her mouth, and the velvety flesh encasing his cock rolled in waves down the length of his shaft.

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They lay side-by-side, arms against each other's arms, feet entangled. Josh stroked her fingers with his. It was a sort of tentative truce, a physical representation of the feelings they shared: they wanted to come back together, but it was going to be a process.

"So what are you going to do?" Josh said at last.

Zoe turned her face towards his. He continued to look at the ceiling. He could feel her eyes moving rapidly over his features, searching for his feelings.

"I told you," she said. "I broke it off with him. But... if it's something you want to, you want me to do... if what you're asking is if I'd be up for more with him, then - and it's what you want - then... I guess."

Josh turned to her. He propped himself up on his elbow, taking her hand with his, fingers still entwined. He kissed her forearm, on the outside, and she shuddered, because it was such a strange place for him to kiss and it was shockingly arousing. He dragged his lips along her skin. "Is it purely physical with him now?"

"Now? Yes."

"Why do you like him?"

"Josh..."

"Tell me. This is what I want. I'm just being honest now. This is what I want to hear."

She looked at the ceiling. "It's so... I don't know... kind of embarrassing."

"Tell me." He nibbled at her arm.

She closed her eyes. "It's the way... he just, like, *dominates* me. He does whatever he wants, and I like it, I like it because that's what he's doing. I like that he does it physically and mentally. I guess... I almost like it that he's trying to bribe me, you know? To be honest."

Josh bit into her arm harder. It didn't hurt, it just stung slightly. "And you don't want me to do things like that to you?"

Zoe's eyes opened. She watched the ceiling intently, as if the contoured woodwork was going to feed her the answer. Josh watched her eyes moving back and forth.

"The thing is," she said at last, in a whisper. "You *can't*. I can't get this same, I don't know, *rush*, because, you know... you're you. I know that you love me. I know that you aren't really into the things... that... so, I don't think you can really do it. Not because you can't *do* it, physically. You know? Just... psychologically. It wouldn't be the same."

Josh's cock was throbbing back to life again, and he knew Zoe could feel it against her thigh. Her eyes had dropped to stare at him, as if she had to see it for herself, and she smiled before continuing. He leaned over her and pushed her hand up, holding it next to her ear.

"And what kind of things does he want to do to you? Hmm?"

Zoe bit her lip. "I think he wants to fuck my ass," she said. He could see the satisfaction that wandered through her expression when his cock pulsed to full thickness against her thigh. She smiled, chewing sexually on her pinky finger. "I think he wants to teach me to take his whole cock in my throat. I think he wants to fuck me full of cum in every hole." She watched Josh's face. "I think he takes Viagra, you know. But not to get it up, to keep going all night."

"He hasn't fucked your ass yet?" Josh said, his hands moving down her chest, stretching the skin of her tits to make her nipple pop up toward his mouth. He lapped at the hardened ball.

"Not yet."

"Are you going to let him?"

Zoe gasped as Josh bit into her nipple. "I'm sort of scared," she panted. "His cock is so big."

Josh's cock spasmed wildly against her skin. "Zoe," he breathed.

But he didn't have to explain to her that this is what he wanted. She had a gleam in her eye, and she understood. Whatever misunderstanding had existed before, they were coming together, aligning their fantasies, making them one.

She knew Josh couldn't do these dirty things to her. She knew he wanted her to do them, though, and she had sussed out exactly how he wanted to hear about it.

And if the gushing juices between her thighs was any indication, she was getting exactly what she wanted, too.

He rolled her over and slid into her pussy while she lay on her side. Cupping her breasts, and propping himself on a pillow that had been tossed aside, he could look down at the sweet peach cleft of her ass and imagine it being broken open by Randy's enormous dick.

He breathed into her neck.

"I want you to let Randy 'seduce' you again," he said. "But this time, I want to watch."

He watched his cock sliding between her buttocks, and imagined Randy McIntyre's fat cock there, breaking into his wife's back door for the first time.

Just the thought of it sent him over the edge.

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"Let him come to you," Josh said, answering her question.

It was a strange scene. They were dressed for work, sipping coffee at their kitchen counter, like any ordinary professional couple with no kids.

She swept her fingers aimlessly over her phone. Since their decision last night, she had developed a new kind of anxiety: that Randy would actually give up on having her, and their new plans couldn't be put into motion.

After talking to Josh about it, after the second time they had sex, with him fucking her from behind and her imagining that Randy had his cock not in her pussy but deep in her ass, she had laid awake thinking about it. Craving it.

She craved Randy now in a much different way: she craved the raw physicality of it, the way he was going to use her, the dirty things he was going to do. And she craved it all being done knowing that Josh was watching her.

It was a sudden turn of events, a sudden change in perspective. But it was clear now.

"Maybe I should call him," she said, uncertain.

Josh was looking at her. "Give it some time. Let him come to you, I'm telling you." He walked toward her and kissed her. She could feel his cock hard against her hip. It was crazy, especially given how much sex they'd had the night before, but it was true. Her chest felt tight with excitement: excitement for Randy, for feeling liberated to let him do whatever he wanted to her, and excitement for Josh to watch it.

He wanted to see the first time Randy fucked her ass, but that was the only requirement he'd placed on their arrangement.

That, and she needed to tell him *everything*.

When she had promised to do just that, it had come to her as a relief - a true relief. An exchange of something, a kind of payment, for her to be doing the thing she was doing. It had felt so wrong before she made that promise, even if Josh had told her time and time again that this was what he wanted. Somehow, the idea that she would have to give him the details of how Randy fucked her felt like a small price to pay: to recount the intimate details of her humiliations at Randy's hands, honestly, detail by detail.

So now, it was just a matter of going back to Randy or getting him to come back to her.

That, and keeping her head straight about what she was doing this time.

CHAPTER 6

It had been a gamble, waiting for Randy to chase after her again, one she had decided to allow to determine her fate. If he *did* contact her again, then all of this was meant to be. If not, then it was best to, well, let sleeping dogs lie.

There was a certain thrill to waiting, playing the game, like she used to when she first started dating someone. Because there was always a game, always contrived pauses and chases and retreats, uncertainty and longing. That was, after all, what made it exciting.

She herself had doubts about Randy's level of obsession with her. He was a grown man, after all. She was too young for him, married, and he surely would come to see the silliness of chasing after her. She was sure that he would think on it as he waited for her to contact him, and decide that he had been a crazy fool, taken in by youth and a need to console himself after his divorce.

Josh didn't see it that way. He was convinced that Randy wouldn't let her go, that having said such a thing - throwing down a gauntlet like that - he would pursue her as much out of his obsession as out of pride and competition.

In the end, Josh was right.

A full week went by, and then a few more days, and she began to give up on the whole idea. It had been fun, it had invigorated their sex life, and they had been more honest with each other than ever before.

But one Tuesday, the message arrived.

I have your purse and I'm holding it hostage. I'm sorry for being so crazy last week, please let me bring this to you in exchange for one last drink and a face-to-face apology. I'm a shrink. I need some kind of closure.

"He's so *not* going to just hand over your purse and apologize," Josh said, with a snort, when she showed it to him. They were at Meade Street Station, at her suggestion, where she had waited for Josh to come home from work. She had half-expected him to be late, to again have been pulled into his job, but he showed up remarkably close to on-time.

She wasn't so certain about the intentions of Randy's text. There was still a part of her that saw Randy as a pretty decent guy. Things happened,

and she hadn't exactly been a docile lamb in this whole affair.

"I don't know," she said, turning the phone back to look at the message, which had arrived hours before, while she was at work. "Maybe he really is."

"Closure is not what men are looking for when they say they're looking for closure," Josh said authoritatively. "They are looking for a way to get you back into bed. Even if it's one last time."

This made Zoe smile. "How many times have you tried to get some closure?" she mocked.

Josh smiled back. "True, but look, I know guys. I know what I heard. I know what this guy is thinking."

"So what do I do?"

Josh sipped a beer. "Use your imagination," he said, with a smile.

Zoe spent a long time typing and re-typing, while Josh watched her with a hungry look in his eyes.

Randy answered her text almost immediately, and she enjoyed herself, writing a conversation that Josh was salivating to see, smiling coyly, letting him simmer. It had been a long time since she'd had his undivided attention like this, and it turned her on, though in a much different way from Randy.

"Okay," she said, turning her phone off and putting it face-down on the table. "We're on for Thursday night."

"Thursday..." Josh groaned.

"I knew you had to work," Zoe said, spinning the phone on the table with one finger. "And I'm making him think I want to get to bed early, because of a big meeting on Friday. I'm playing hard to get."

She had her foot under the table, her shoe discarded. She was feeling the contours of his rock-hard cock with her toes while she watched his face. A breathlessness had overtaken her.

She couldn't be sure why she had chosen to come here, of all places. Maybe because she had met Randy here that first night, and it gave her a thrill. Maybe because she figured she wouldn't get caught here by Randy, who in his telling, never went to this place. Maybe because she believed there was a chance she *would* get "caught" here by Randy, and she liked living close to that edge. Maybe it was the guilt, the taboo, the recklessness of it all. Maybe it was the power Randy held over her and the permission Josh gave to her to let him.

Maybe it was what she was doing to Josh.

His cock pulsed against the sole of her foot and the pleasure of it traveled through her skin, all the way to the back of her neck.

"Do you want to see what I wrote?" she purred.

Josh reached for the phone, his eyes hungry and fixed on hers.

"I feel a little bit bad," she said, in a low whisper, sliding the phone to his fingertips. He picked it up and looked at it. "I need your PIN," he said. "You changed it."

"Huh? Oh. *Oh*," Zoe said. "Wait, what - ?"

"I tried to look at your phone that night you came home after being out with Randy, when you were in the shower? I'm sorry. I'll never do it again. But I need your PIN now."

She should have been mad, and if they hadn't hashed all of this out, she might have been. But she couldn't really get fired up about what Josh had done, when *she* had transgressed so heavily.

Also, she *had* changed the PIN for exactly that reason.

So fair was fair.

"3415," she said, with a smile.

He exchanged a look with her, and they smiled in complicity. He entered the PIN and she watched as his eyes scanned the messages, his cock getting harder.

"It's pretty devious," she said, in a low voice. She both meant that and liked that it made Josh so crazy.

Josh seemed to not have even heard her for a moment. When he looked up, he ran the tip of his tongue along his upper lip before speaking. It was something she had never seen him do before, not ever. It implied a loss of control in him, a reckless caving in to his own desires, and it aroused her enough that the guilt she might have been feeling began to evaporate.

"He's really into you," Josh said.

"What do I do? I want to make this work, but... I can't see how to do it on the first, you know... time I give in to him. Again. You see what I mean?"

Josh looked mildly ill, but that was an expression she was learning to recognize was part of the deal. With each passing day, she was starting to understand Josh better. What it was that appealed to him about this arrangement, that he liked feeling a little ill. The realization had come to her late at night, when she had made the connection between Josh's pursuit of

this sickening thrill and her own thrill-seeking: after all, didn't she feel her fear of heights right in the lowest part of her abdomen, in a gray area between her gut and her cunt? Maybe this was Josh's skydiving.

That she was having so much fun was just a perk.

But the guilt about Randy still gnawed at her. She didn't know why: as Josh had put it, Randy was a pretty dirty old man, who had been obsessed with his son's girlfriend since she was sixteen. He hadn't exactly acted with the most noble of intentions, and he had manipulated her with his smooth, psychiatrist talk.

All of this converged into hot sex that seemingly everyone wanted to have, but that didn't erase the *complications* that made it so hot. They would still be there, waiting to confront them. Zoe knew that, but it wasn't stopping her.

Josh lifted his beer, licking his lip again, Zoe noticed. There was something appealing about him doing something new, about having new gestures and traits for her to discover.

And there was something really, *really* hot about how worked up he was getting. She could be honest with herself: Randy's obsession with her was a little flattering. A little empowering. She had always been aware of the power women have over men, but it hadn't seemed so potent, so strong, until now.

Josh took a sip of his beer and set his glass down. His eyes were looking all over the restaurant. "This is where you came with him?" he said unexpectedly.

She rubbed his dick through his pants and nodded. He met her eyes and glanced at the phone again.

"I guess... you know him better, better than, uh... I do," he said.

Zoe felt a little rush. She curled her toes around the shape of his cock, waited for it to swell and throb beneath her skin. She leaned over the table and waited until Josh was totally captivated, his eyes on her mouth, his cock turgid and twitching, his breath ragged.

Such fun.

"I think," she said, "I should take him up on it. Pretend I want to break it off, but that he just..." she curled her toes where she felt the soft bulge of his balls, "pulls me back in. A little against my will."

Josh said nothing. His mouth was slightly open, his eyes fixed and disbelieving, the heat from his cock almost uncomfortable on her foot.

"I don't know if I'd be able to arrange it so you could see that," she said, tipping her head to the side. "But I think it would be more believable. And I promise to tell you. Every. Single. Detail."

Josh exhaled.

Zoe picked up her phone. She skimmed the last few messages from Randy.

"So?" she said, lifting her eyes to meet Josh's.

He nodded.

She smiled. "What do I say?"

Josh shook his head. He didn't know, he was dumbstruck, captive to her every whim.

And so, it appeared, was Randy.

She typed, smiling. She was aware of the way Josh was staring at her, and she liked it.

She flipped the phone to face him, enjoying the pulse of his cock as he read her words.

"Remember," she said. "I'm going to pretend like he's sucked me back in, has me lying to you again. This might take a few visits." She paused, savoring the words, aware of what would happen beneath her foot when she said them. "I might have to let him fuck me a few times, to make it really believable."

She smiled at her planned next sentence and bit her lip. She wasn't *really* going to say this, was she?

She crooked her finger and Josh leaned toward her. Close to his ear, she whispered: "I promise I'll save the best part for when you're there."

The best part, the part she was most nervous about. The part she couldn't actually believe she was going to go through with.

The part where she finally let Randy put his huge cock in her ass.

She'd been fantasizing about it. Thinking about it while Josh fucked her. Thinking about the way Randy would push her down into a submissive crouch, and fill her in that taboo place. It made her ass throb with the phantom sensation of his fingers, prying her wide, sinking into her flesh. Josh would never do that to her: he just couldn't.

But Randy could. And if she let him, Randy would. And Josh would watch it all.

"Let's go home," Josh croaked.

"I thought you'd never ask," she said.

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"What are you wearing to meet him?"

Zoe was in the closet, naked, her lean lines washed over by goosebumps from the chill morning air. A droplet of water was poised above her ass-crack, and Josh watched it as it gathered just enough moisture, swelled, and then slid down her skin between her buttocks, leaving a shiny trail behind.

"I thought work clothes would be more realistic," she said, distracted, looking at her rack of blouses. After a moment she turned her head, her hair swinging sexily over one shoulder, and slowly sliding back toward her face because it was not long enough to remain caught there. "But they're all sort of... not very sexy. You have any suggestions?"

Any suggestions? For what his wife should wear to meet her lover? He felt his cock thicken and he shifted his legs to give it some room. Zoe had been much hornier than usual since they had begun this adventure, and they'd had sex this morning. She was not one to have sex twice in the morning, and definitely hated having to shower twice, so he realized his chances were pretty slim that he would get any more. But it was worth just... putting it out there.

The sheet rose into a tent. Zoe had already turned back to the shirts.

"I like the green one," Josh said. "And that sort of long black skirt."

He watched as she said nothing and fished the two articles of clothing out of the racks. She sauntered back to the bed, holding them in front of her, smiling. "These?"

Josh nodded. Zoe gave the clothing a toss onto the bed and stood there for a moment, her nipples erect, a hand on one smooth hip. She let him take in the freshly manicured landing strip above her snatch, her smooth legs, her well-groomed body prepared for Randy's pleasure.

Then she walked over to her lingerie drawer. "And for underwear?" she said casually. She tipped her head to catch his eye, smiling. She saw his erection, but she didn't pay it any mind. "I was kind of thinking, with the underwear, go super sexy. So then he thinks, okay, she was really *hoping*

deep down inside that this would go a certain way, even if she did come straight from work. Like it was sort of an insurance policy or something."

"That's devious."

Zoe rolled her eyes, pulling two silky black items from the drawer. "Girls think about this stuff, you know. If you ever get a girl's clothes off and she has shitty underwear on, then she *really did not* expect to be having sex that night. If they're sexy, then she probably just... yeah, insured herself."

"Huh," Josh said. "Very enlightening."

Zoe had been wearing very sexy underwear the first night he had fucked her, in his car. He chalked up a mental score point in his favor.

Zoe slipped the underwear on and gave a little spin. It was a lacy thong, and it nestled between her full asscheeks and spread, like a delicate tattoo, on the round of her ass, before narrowing to barely a scrap at her hips. She was fastening the bra while he stared at her butt, and she spun back to face him as she slid it around her body in that complex motion women use to put on their own bras.

She adjusted her breasts carefully and then posed, beautiful, wrapped up like a present in black lace and patches of transparent gauze that allowed for a peek at the contours of her pussy. "What do you think?" she said. "Too much? Not enough?"

He thought it was cute that Zoe thought Randy would be pondering this type of question if he was doing something with Zoe that allowed him to see her underwear.

A stab of nauseous, cold jealousy hit him in the abdomen. "You look hot," he said, his breath sticky in his throat.

Zoe had her hand on her hip again, and there was a look in her eye, a look she'd been getting lately, that he wasn't sure what to make of. It was an expression of insight, a realization that she held an immense power over him, and it simultaneously thrilled him but also scared him to death. It was an unexpected outcome of the path they had chosen, and it made him uncomfortable.

But he also liked it. His cock shook the sheet tent hanging over it. Zoe smiled, without moving her eyes from his. "Okay," she said. "This is what I'll wear."

He watched her shimmy into her skirt, the material sliding first over one small hip, then over the other. The length of the skirt - it wasn't actually long, or even "sort of long," just down to an inch above her knee, but it was tight-fitting and had some off-black stripes that created the illusion of Zoe being much thinner but also more curvy than she was.

Josh, naturally, would not have provided that description, because he didn't know why the skirt made Zoe look hot, just that it did.

She pulled her blouse on and tucked it carefully into her skirt. She unbuttoned the top button. "Too racy?" she asked.

"Uh..." Josh said.

Zoe buttoned it and smiled. "I can always undo it."

She looked at herself in the mirror and gave a spin, checking out her butt. "What do you think?" she asked Josh.

He got up and walked toward her. She smiled at him in the mirror and tipped her head so he could kiss her neck. But when his hands dropped to the hem of her dress, she slapped his hand away and darted forward to get into the bathroom. "No!" she hissed, playfully. "I have to get ready. I'm going to be late."

Josh returned to the bed, turning over the idea in his mind of catching her on her way out, after she had fixed her hair and her makeup. His cock was throbbing, and he wanted to feel the sweet inside of his wife's cheating pussy again before she met with her lover.

But he also knew she'd probably actually get mad if he made her late, and the truth was: he sort of enjoyed the pain.

Zoe straightened her hair, wearing it down. The glossy brown fell exactly to her shoulders, tickling her exposed neck and shoulders alluringly every time she moved her head. She painted her lips with a red stain that looked like a nail polish brush, but gave her lips a very natural, just-bitten appearance. Josh stared in fascination: he had never watched Zoe get ready with so much attention, so he had never noticed things like this, the subtle changes in her lips and her eyes as she applied her various makeup tricks.

Zoe looked stunning even when she had no makeup on, but the effect was quite dramatic today, when she brushed a little shadow over her eyes and caked her lashes with a dark mascara. Her normally very innocent, hiker-girl appearance acquired a very slightly trashy, but alluring, look.

Josh's cock was so hard his stomach was hurting.

Zoe turned to him and held her hands out from her sides. "Ta da. What do you think? Too slutty?"

Josh stared at her. "Come here," he said.

Zoe's eyes dropped to his erect penis, and she shook her head. "Good, that's the look I was going for. And no way. I really will be late."

Josh lunged for her knee and caught her by it. "Just a kiss," he said, pulling her toward him.

"Josh," Zoe whined, but she was caving in. He could feel it.

"Just climb on my lap," he said, suddenly very serious. "I won't mess your makeup up. Or your hair."

"But..." Zoe said weakly.

Josh was pushing her skirt up and nudging the pretty panties aside to work his fingers into her slit, which was rubbery-wet from the shower on the outside lips, but juicy, slimy-wet inside. "It'll add realism," he said, with a grin.

Zoe looked concerned, made a noise that seemed like a complaint, but lifted her hips a little, so that Josh could slide his cock into her pussy. The panties scraped against his shaft, but he didn't care. All Zoe would need to do was roll her hips just a little, and he would explode in her pussy in no time.

They moved slowly, staring into each other's eyes, until Zoe's skin was hot and moist. He felt her thighs squeeze his and the distinct roll of her abdomen that marked when she was about to come.

"Oh God," he groaned. He lifted his hips to thrust deep inside of her. Zoe held on to him like he was a wild horse, bouncing on his lap, as she panted and squeaked.

She had her arms on his shoulders and was breathing heavily for a few moments, with her forehead next to his.

Then she moved suddenly, slapping him playfully on the shoulder as she pulled her panties up and hurried to the toilet without pulling her skirt down. "You shit," she said.

But she was smiling.

CHAPTER 7

He was waiting with her red "purse" - a change purse she had abandoned and forgotten after the night she'd fled his house in the wee hours of the morning after falling asleep. Seeing it in his fingers gave her a rush of empowerment: it was, as Josh had believed, purely an excuse to see her.

You hold all the cards, Josh had said to her. Randy wanted her, and he wanted her bad. And now she could let him have her, guilt-free.

His eyes were on his beer as she walked toward him, and she lost her resolve with each step she took in his direction that he didn't devour her with them. Maybe he really did just want to apologize.

She slid onto a barstool and leaned on one arm, knowing that her breasts were pushed forward by the posture, just enough to make them plump against the green fabric and spread the edges of the neckline open with the promise of a glimpse of her cleavage. Sometimes, the blouse shifted and she knew he would be able to see her black lace bra then.

He pressed his lips together in the grimace that so many politicians wear when they've been caught fucking a prostitute. He slid the change purse to her along the bar. "Thank you for agreeing to see me," he said. His voice seemed to carry a deep consternation, a genuine apology embedded in it, and Zoe's heart fell with typical female compassion.

She took the purse with her fingertips.

"I know it's just a change purse," Randy added, looking up. He had a whiskey in his hand, and his eyes went directly to hers as he took a sip. "So I appreciate that you're indulging me."

Zoe, abandoning all of her plans at once, looked down at the purse and smiled a friendly smile. She gave it a playful shake. "Could be a whole three bucks in here," she said, to lighten the mood.

The bartender set a drink down in front of her. It looked like Scotch.

"No Californication?"

"Have one last drink with me, and since it's the last one, I thought it should be a grown-up one. That's single-malt scotch, it's expensive, it's good."

He said all this with an air of resignation, and Zoe felt a pang of guilt. She picked up the drink and raised it to his glass. "Randy, I -"

He clinked the glass to hers. "Don't apologize," he said. "Don't... say anything. I understand."

Zoe looked at him, a genuine expression of confusion on her face. He understood? What the hell did he understand? Was he sure he understood?

She sipped the whiskey after sniffing it.

"What... sorry, I'm maybe kind of dull here, but... what do you understand?"

"All of it," Randy said, with the tone of well-earned misery of a man over fifty, and a sweep of his eyes toward the ceiling that indicated "all of it" encompassed everything.

Zoe set her glass down. "Wow. Wish you could explain some of that to me."

She had her hands in her lap, she was expressing a genuine sentiment, but when Randy looked over at her she realized that she had somehow stumbled on the exact thing, the exact pose and the exact expression of confusion, that sparked his interest. She saw it flicker in his eyes. And then it lit.

"How's your scotch?"

She rubbed her lips together, aware that some of the scotch lingered on them and shone in the dim light. "Tastes expensive."

Randy appraised her with this new look in her eyes, and she realized she had turned the evening around somehow. He was hungry now, a predatory glaze in his pupils. The downcast features of his face had lifted up, forming an altogether different expression.

It was the expression of a hunter who had zeroed in a tricky animal.

"How does expensive taste to you?" he asked casually.

Zoe was quiet, a half-smile on her face, some sense that the control she had felt walking in here had slipped, that the remorse she had felt had been misplaced, that she was now being chased, or perhaps she was already caught.

"I think everything expensive is better," Randy said, letting his bar chair rotate toward her. "Maybe I feel about expensive the way you do about risk."

A pause.

"Hmm?"

Zoe's breath was caught in her chest, dry and almost painful. She couldn't deny that Randy's transformation had made her wet, that her pulse was racing, that her lower abdomen was a ball of pleasurable, icy pain. She had lost the plot, though, and she was spinning rudderless: what was she here for? And who was trying to seduce whom?

She knew that she was supposed to play hard to get, and just moments before she had been about to leave out of pity for Randy. Now, she was afraid to make a wrong move, afraid that he might *not* take her home and peel her green blouse away and look at her breasts in their black bra, that she might not get spun around and tossed onto his bed, and feel his cock between her legs.

"Josh is working late tonight?" Randy said, when she didn't answer. She nodded.

Randy took a sip of his whiskey. He set it down, without taking his eyes off of her. "Finish your drink," he said. He leaned closer, and his hand traveled lightly over her thigh, never squeezing, not even a particularly sexual gesture. "You're gonna need it."

Heat crept across Zoe's cheeks. It was the crimson stain of a blush, the heat of shame - but the exact provenance of that shame was opaque. Was it the implication of what Randy was going to do to her? Or the deeper truth, that she liked the idea, even if it was shameful? Was it the humiliation of caving in to him, like she knew she would, of being outgunned by Randy's visceral masculinity?

She brought the drink to her lips and sipped it. She smiled, a smile meant to bring her back under control, but it faltered, and she knew it. "Who says I'm going home with you?"

His hand had moved to her knee, beneath her skirt, and had, by then, nudged her crossed legs open. Now his fingers were between her thighs, where her skin was hot and his hand stuck slightly to the thin, tacky layer of sweat there. His fingers traveled to the center of her legs, where he felt the stickiness of her excitement, the dampness of her underwear.

He smiled back, leaned in to bite gently into her lower lip after grazing it with his mouth. "You do."

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"I need to make sure that you understand," Zoe said breathlessly, after Randy walked her back into a wall using his fingertips pressed gently

against her sternum, "that all of this has to eventually lead to Josh watching... me. Otherwise it's... cheating."

Randy was hiking her skirt up, his hands seeking out her wet heat. His eyes were locked on hers, even more hawk-like than before. He twisted his hand to dive into her panties, fingers sliding through her greased slit with ease, and then inside of her. He curled them outward, cupping her against his palm and crushing a spasm of pleasure into her clit.

Zoe's eyes fluttered, and her mouth fell open. "Randy," she whispered, opening her eyes. She slipped her hands up to his chest, and tried feebly to push against him, but gave up against the solid bulk without much effort. "Really."

His fingers stroked her slowly, and she mewled. He leaned against her, crushing her body against the wall. His free hand was at the nape of her neck, gathering her hair into his fingers. He pulled gently, but firmly enough to send a stinging pain to her scalp, and force her to tip her head up to his face. She made a noise, a sort of weak whimper that turned her on as much as it did him: her legs were spreading and her body was pinned, and she wanted his throbbing cock to split her open.

He finger-fucked her with two, then three fingers, pulling on her hair until her eyes watered. She was close to coming, and tried to hide the shudders in her body, though her intentions were a mystery to her: she wanted Randy to agree to her conditions, but she knew she was powerless to stop him, both in desire and physical ability, so it made no difference.

And he knew it too.

And it turned her on.

He curled his fingers again against the root of her clit, making her limbs jerk. He slipped one finger out and let it graze her asshole as he plunged into her again. "But tonight, you're my little slut, aren't you Zoe? You're going to do just what I tell you to do, aren't you?"

It felt wrong, she thought, to not demand some kind of agreement from Randy. A little bit like betrayal. But she had very little time to contemplate the thought, because it was washed out to sea with the tide of her building orgasm. Randy's finger, drenched in her pussy juices, slipped into her ass, and he lifted her a little from the ground, so that she was up on her tiptoes and then one foot came away from the floor and her shoe fell off. Her head

tipped forward and she bit his shoulder through his shirt and he pumped her with his hand, making her bounce like she was on a seesaw.

Just as she was about to come, and the bite of her orgasm was just seconds away, Randy stopped fucking her, and let her feet fall to the ground. She wobbled, and he pushed against her to hold her up. She whimpered with need and tried to squirm against him, but his hand slipped from inside her and caught her wrist. He pushed it up against the wall, next to her head. "You're my little slut tonight, Zoe. Say it. Say it if you want to come."

"Randy," she whimpered in protest. But his stare severed her thoughts, and she went quiet with a pleading whimper. The ache between her thighs was intolerable. She could feel Randy's cock, bulging against her stomach, and she knew she was going to give into him so she could have it.

He let go of her wrist and brought his pussy-coated fingers to her mouth. When the pads of his fingertips brushed over her lip, she tasted her own tangy juices. "Say it."

She closed her lips around the tips of his fingers. He was holding her captive with his eyes, and she felt the dominance of his stare, the inner submissive nature of herself melting for him. She released his fingers with a light pop. "I'm your little slut tonight," she whispered.

She had expected Randy to smile with arrogance, but instead his face was serious, his expression one of an unexpected reaction to attaining something he wanted. He contemplated her for a moment, his cock throbbing against her. And then he stepped back, pushing her down the wall, looking at her face in almost disbelief.

She fell to her knees, and Randy held her by her shoulder, pressing her to the floor. Without looking away from her face he unthreaded his belt and freed his cock, stepping back a little again to make room for it between them. It sprang from his boxers and brushed over her forehead, the tip damp with precum, leaving a smear just above her eye. His hand moved to the back of her head, tipping her face up again, pulling her up slightly, cradling her in his hand.

Zoe reached for his cock, but Randy swatted her hand away. He shook his head. "No hands," he said. "Just your mouth. Look at me."

He guided his cock to her lips, and dragged it over her mouth, the shaft traveling over her lips while she sought to lap at it with her tongue. She

closed her eyes, unable to stand his intense gaze, the humiliation it heaped upon her, the submission it required to maintain it.

She felt the heavy thud of the meat on her lips. Randy had lifted his cock and let it fall against her face. "Open your eyes, Zoe. Look at me. Look me in the eyes while you... suck... my cock."

He faltered slightly at the words "suck" and "cock," his abdomen rippling beneath his shirt and the flesh against her lips pulsing.

She met his eyes, and warm humiliation traveled over her, like it had been poured from a bucket. His mouth was open slightly. He placed his crown against her lips and moved it back and forth, smearing a new drop of pearly cum over her upper lip.

"Lick it off," he breathed.

She obeyed, tasting his bitter cum, liking it, liking the humiliation of tasting such a salty, filthy fluid and lapping it into her mouth. Her eyes watered. Randy was watching her mouth, immersed in watching his seed dissolve on her tongue.

"Now open," he told her. "Open up, nice and wide, and keep your eyes on mine. That's it, you little slut," he inhaled sharply. "Oh, fuck."

Randy's cock was silky smooth, smelled of a musky soap, and tasted of salt and cum. It stretched her mouth wide and pushed her jaw down until it hurt. He entered her slowly, filling her mouth, until he reached the back of her throat and she gagged. Her eyes went wide in alarm.

"Yes you can," Randy said, in a voice so low she wasn't sure if she had heard it, as if she had voiced her objection. He pulled out a little, letting her breathe loudly through her nostrils. Her eyes were watering, and Randy was staring her down, a faint smile developing on his serious mouth. "Is that the biggest cock you've ever had in your mouth?" he asked her, at the same time as he incongruously pushed a strand of her hair from her forehead in a tender gesture. She moved her head ever-so-slightly to nod, and he sucked in his breath again.

He fed himself to her again, and she gagged when he reached the back of her throat and squeezed her eyes closed. She made a sound, but Randy held her hair in his fist and would not release her. She struggled to breathe, and to contain her gag reflex.

"Open your eyes, look at me."

She obeyed, but she felt as if she were pleading with him now, water running from the corners of her eyes. Her jaw ached already, but the gagging sensation was passing. Would she be able to take it, swallow his whole cock, feel it stuffing her throat until she couldn't breathe?

For some reason, she desperately wanted to. She closed her eyes slowly to tell him, squeezing a tear from the corner of her eye.

"That's it," Randy said. "Just open up, let it slide right in. All the way. You can be a good girl, can't you? You can take it all. Eyes up here, Zoe. Look at me, that's it."

His cock was entering deep into her throat now. When she tried to breathe, her chest expanded but nothing entered her lungs: her throat was filled with cock, the salty precum draining down the back of it, the taste just discernible. Her eyes went wide with a moment of panic, and she tried to move. Randy held her in place for a moment, and then slid his cock from her mouth.

She gasped for air, and drool splashed across her chin, falling to her chest. He left his cock heavy on her lower lip while she gasped.

"This time take it all," Randy said.

"I can't," she gasped. "I want to but -"

Her final words were cut to a wet garble by Randy's dick sliding back between her lips, and so she opened wide for him, and gagged, and then felt him sliding further, deeper. But several full inches of his cock remained still to be swallowed, and though he pushed her head against him, she couldn't do it. Her throat constricted, another gag threatening to make her vomit. She closed her eyes tightly and tried to take more of him in.

He released her again. "Eyes up here, Zoe," she heard him say, and she lifted her eyes to meet his.

Rubbing his cock over her lips, savoring her tear-streaked face and the spit and precum that welled from her mouth, he played gently with her hair again. "Is that the best you can do, Zoe? Hmm? I think you can do better. Tell me you'll try."

"I'll try," she spluttered, her voice raw. She was still gasping for air.

Randy didn't change his expression, but pleasure glimmered in his eyes. His gently stroking fingers grabbed her hair, pulling tight as he fed his cock to her again. This time he stepped forward, waddling until he was over

her, pushing down into her. Her thighs weakened and she fell to rest on her calves. Randy had to crouch to shove his dick further into her mouth.

"Look at me," he ordered her. "Look at me and take it all."

The inches continued to disappear, until her face was covered by his pelvis. She closed her eyes when he pushed her face into his groin. Her chin crushed against his balls, and she put her hands on his thighs, to steady herself from falling to the side.

He put both hands on her head and gripped her, holding her steady as he began to fuck her throat. "Oh, fuck," she heard him say, over the sloppy spurts of his thrusts. "That's it, Zoe, good girl, you're being a good little slut."

He let her breathe one last time before pushing himself into her throat again, pulling her hair back. She lifted his eyes to meet his.

"I'm going to come," he told her, with a shaky voice.

But she knew that, because she could feel the veins of his dick straining against his skin, the pulsing of his meat, somehow even more rigid than it had already been. She struggled to stare up at him, her lungs screaming for air, her pussy throbbing wildly with the submission of her act.

"Swallow it," he told her, as the hot liquid gushed directly into her throat. He pulled her head away from him slightly, until his cock filled only her mouth. The spurts of sharp-tasting cum bounced against the back of her throat, filled her mouth, poured from the sides of her lips. She couldn't swallow with his dick stuffed in her mouth, so she waited, being ground to a submissive whore by his stare, until he slowly retracted his cock.

Absently, she brought her fingers to her lips. Cum poured from the corners of her mouth before she closed it, and Randy stared as she swallowed, her eyes burning with the pungent, bitter cum.

Randy dropped his hand to her chin and pulled her mouth gently open. As he inspected her open, empty mouth, his head tipped to the side slightly. She waited for his verdict, his face revealing nothing. He swept a rivulet of cum into her mouth with his finger. "Good girl," he said, at last, as she sucked it clean.

He tugged at the back of her head. She put her hands on his forearm and he lifted her that way to standing. Her legs were shaking, and her pussy was aching to the point of pain now, an experience in desire she had never

before felt. Her eyes dropped to look at Randy's cock, to see if he would have it in him to fuck her with it.

When she looked back at him, he was smiling.

"Don't worry," he said. "You'll get plenty of that."

The same shame that had washed over her in the bar washed over her again, but she knew that she was powerless to do anything about it, so she didn't try. Randy had a dangerous expression on his face, and it unsettled her, but she knew she was completely helpless against it.

Randy contemplated her face for a long time, and she could see that he was taking perverse pleasure in the streaks of mascara, the smeared red of her lips made puffy and distorted from stretching and rubbing, the saliva and cum that was now drying shiny on her jaw and chin.

"Take off your blouse," he told her.

She did, never breaking his stare, because without him saying so, she knew that was what he wanted. He watched her mouth while she unbuttoned the blouse, and dropped his eyes to her breasts only once the green silk slid from her shoulders.

He touched her chest with his fingertips, his face in an expression of appraisal that went dark at the last moment. "I'm going to come all your tits," he said, almost as if speaking to himself. Then his eyes snapped up to meet hers. "Take off your skirt."

Her skirt was bunched up around her waist still, so she pushed it down to reach behind herself and unzip it. She had to shimmy to push the tight fabric over her hips, and then past her knees.

Randy dropped his eyes to look at her in her lingerie. The look was long, possessive, unsettling, and yet still arousing. He put a hand on the wall behind her, and leaned in, his other hand tracing a line from her chin, down her neck, between her breasts, to her abdomen.

He jerked his head to the left. "Go get on the bed."

Zoe looked at him for a moment, a final attempt at putting up a fight against his inappropriate, visceral, filthy, possession of her. But they both knew it was not a real challenge, just the kind of "no," that submissive exchange in BDSM. For thrills.

She turned and walked unsteadily toward the door to his bedroom. The hall light was on. He stayed where he was, and though she couldn't see him, she felt his eyes on her backside, especially hot where they were glued to

the black thong that rubbed slightly against her anus as she strutted down the hall.

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In the bedroom, he pushed her onto the bed, onto her hands and knees, and then, leaning over her, her head to the bedsheets. He moved each hand above her head, straight in front of her, and she knew that it was as good as tying them there, she was not to move them if she knew what was good for her.

He took his time, and though she couldn't see him, she knew he was standing behind her, looking at her, enjoying his attainment of something he had obviously coveted for a long time. It was fucked-up, the implications of how fucked up it was were at the edges of her mind, but her pussy was throbbing and she needed him to fuck her, to give her the relief she craved, more than she cared about how wrong any of it was.

He had flicked the light on. The mirror was to her right, and she could have looked over at herself if she wanted to, but she didn't dare.

She felt his weight shift the bed beneath her, as he climbed on behind her, first one knee, then the other. Her body moved in anticipation of him touching her, and a murmur left her throat. Neither reaction was conscious, and she cringed that she did them, that she was rutting for him like a little slut, out of control.

She exhaled loudly when his fingers landed on either side of her hips, hot, tacky with dried cum that scraped against her skin deliciously as he made teasing, torturous circles over her skin. At last he settled on her panties, hooking his fingers beneath the thin straps on her hips and pulling them taut, upward toward her lower back.

The fabric of the thong cut into her gash, and she whimpered with the painful pleasure of it. "Did you wear these pretty panties just for me, Zoe?"

She nodded, moving her head with an exaggerated motion so that he would see it. He tugged them, pulling them away from her ass and peeling them down to her thighs. They stuck momentarily in the viscous juices of her pussy, before snapping wetly down between her legs.

"I like that. Good girl."

He placed his hands on her legs, just above her knees, and lifted her to jerk the panties down. They tore with a liquid snap and a sharp slap on her calf. Undeterred, Randy lifted her, pushing her ass into the air, closing her

legs, scooting her forward so that her knees were almost at her face. Her ass was high in the air, and her back was curved sharply, but Zoe was flexible and Randy knew that.

His hands were first, palms on her buttocks. His tongue started in the wet mush of her cunt, but moved from there to her ass, circling the eyelet. She curled her toes and mewled into the bed as he traced wet circles, driving her wild. After driving her crazy, she felt his tongue working into her ass, his lips closing around her hole.

She was making noises she had never made before, and was powerless to stop herself. They sounded like the whimpers of a feral animal, as Randy's tongue pulsed inside her ass. No one had ever done this to her before, and she had always felt repulsed by the idea. But it was driving her to near-madness, stars forming at the corners of her eyes.

After teasing her for what seemed like an eternity, Randy's mouth was gone, and his fingers slipped into her ass, stretching her with ease, plunging rapidly as he fucked her.

"Oh," she howled, crawling forward.

Randy leaned over her and pushed her hair from her face, turning it to the side. His fingers still plunged in her ass, spurting with each thrust.

"You want me to fuck you, Zoe?"

"Yes," she gasped.

"I want you to beg me to fuck you."

He leaned back, still fucking her ass with his fingers.

"Randy," she whimpered.

"That's it," he said. "Lie there while I fuck your ass and beg me for my cock. Use my name."

Zoe stared at the wall. Somewhere in the periphery of her mind, she was conscious that Randy was acting out his own fantasy now, one that had the feel of a long marination in his wet dreams. But she *wanted* him to fuck her, and she *wanted* him to fuck her like a slut. She wanted to be made to beg.

She whimpered, and purred, demurring for a moment. Randy, she could see in the corner of her eye, was looking down at her, watching his fingers spread her ass open. Would he fuck her in the ass if she begged for it? She wanted to keep her promise to Josh, but if she begged to be fucked, Randy would do what he wanted to do.

"I want," she panted, "I want you to fuck me, Randy. I want you to fuck me, but please don't fuck me in the ass."

She turned to look at him, just as his eyes almost rolled in the back of his head with pleasure. She could see an enormous glob of precum squeeze from his already hard dick.

"Say it again, little girl," he said, curling the fingers embedded in her ass toward her tailbone. "Say it again and really beg me, and maybe I'll give you what you want."

"Oh!" Zoe yelled. "Oh, Randy, Randy, please, please!" she panted. "I want you to fuck me. I want you to fuck me, just... please... don't... not my ass, not yet, I'm not ready, it's...too big. Please."

"Tell me you want me inside of you," Randy growled, edging the tip of his dick to her sopping slit. He tipped it with his fingers so that it rubbed against her clit. The thickness of it pressed against her hole, reminding her that she would need to stretch to accommodate him. A dull ache rolled through her membranes in waves.

"I want you inside of me," she panted.

"You want me to fuck you full of cum," Randy breathed, his voice lower, his eyes glazing. He was sinking into the fulfillment of his fantasy, his obsession betrayed by his trance-like state.

Zoe stared at him, unsure if she should fuel this fantasy, unsure of how deep and dark it might go. But the need to feel him inside of her was too great, she couldn't wait. "Randy," she pleaded, in a whisper that was breathy and full of sexual whining that she had not intended to be in it, "Please. Please fuck me. Please fuck me full of cum, Randy."

His eyes left her ass as his fingers slowly withdrew, a scratchy pain making her squirm. He guided his crown up, pressing it to her distended anus, wet and pulsing.

Zoe put her hand to her lips. "Please Randy. Please, I want to feel you in my pussy, please don't fuck me in the ass yet, please, I can't take it." She couldn't believe the words she was saying, and she didn't know where they were coming from, but she could see that Randy wanted them, that she was driving him wild.

"Please," she said, almost for the thrill of it. "Randy, please, I was a good girl and I swallowed your cum. Please. I want you to fuck my pussy."

When he lost control, when she saw it break inside of him, she knew what she had been trying to do, that she had hit upon her power over him and won a battle of sorts. He plunged his cock into her pussy with a single, ferocious thrust, and she opened her mouth to scream but no sound came out.

Randy grabbed her hips and began to fuck her as hard as she had ever been fucked in her life. At first, it was a medium-paced fuck, but deep, all the way to the end of her canal, his balls swinging to slap against her slit with a wet smack. The only sound she made was the sound of air being pushed from her lungs by the impact. *Slap, slap, slap*, his thighs smacked her ass.

"Oh god," she whispered, when she felt herself starting to come. It was, she could tell before it even built up fully, a fiercer and more violent orgasm than any she'd ever had in her life, and a twinge of fear for its encompassing violence went through her as a tremor. But it was too late - too late to stop it, far too late to do anything about it.

She closed her eyes, and heard herself screaming, and saw stars cascading from the sides of her eyes to the center. Pleasure that had gotten so intense it was confusable with pain, like cold so cold it is mistaken for heat, gripped her for a moment that both seemed to last forever and only a split-second. She heard Randy fucking her, heard the spurting of her pussy as he rammed it harder and faster, heard him telling her he was going to fuck her full of cum, and then things seemed to turn to a high-pitched, grayish fuzz.

When it cleared, Randy was still hammering away at her, and her pussy was sore, but she couldn't move or speak, just lie there, taking it, until he thrust hard and deep and she felt the warm liquid of his seed gushing inside of her.

CHAPTER 8

"I got some bad news, buddy."

Josh kept his eyes on the screen of his computer and his face as unemotional as he could. Pete Stark's voice, he thought silently, was the most annoying sound in the world. Why? Some day he would have to analyze that.

Josh pressed his lips together to keep from smiling, because little did Pete Stark know that what he was about to say would actually be a welcome distraction for Josh, whose only other option was to go home and pace the floors of his house, trying not to drink so much that he couldn't fuck his wife when she returned from having sex with Randy.

"Don't tell me," Josh said, and he sounded more flippant than he meant to, but he also didn't really care. He put his hands behind his head, interlocking his fingers, and gave himself two quick rubs on the back of the head. It was a satisfying, plausibly deniable mocking of Pete, because Pete did it every time someone came to him with a question or an issue and he was seated, pretending to work.

He typed, and looked at his screen, and pretended not to be listening, until he did this thing with the hair and looked up at you.

Josh lifted his eyes to meet Pete's, with his lips pressed together in a thin smile. "You need me to stay late, Pete? And render all those versions we worked up today for the batch file? Not a problem, Pete. I'm your guy."

Josh leaned back in toward his computer and tried to keep a straight face. He could *feel* the eyes of the rest of the group wandering over to his corner, and to Pete, and he had to really work not to smile.

"Uh... yeah, so. Okay," Pete stammered. He had a batch of papers rolled in his hand, and he tapped them violently, two times, on Josh's desk. "Thanks for not giving me any trouble," he said authoritatively.

Then he marched off.

Josh lifted his eyes to see Jim Reid looking over his computer at him. Josh couldn't see his smile, but Jim lifted a magazine from the table he was sitting next to, rolled it silently, and very slowly lifted it and tapped the table silently, two times.

Josh grinned enough that Jim could see it in his eyes, and then, like a boss, went back to work.

Victory for Josh Wilson. Pete Stark couldn't possibly know that working late was better for him than waiting alone in his house, chilled and feverish, sick and aroused, for his wife to come home from fucking another man.

*

Josh threw himself into his work with a little too much gusto, which was something he had always been able to do. It was probably the thing that made him capable of being a freelancer: he worked best when he was trying to distract himself from a distraction, and distractions abound in this modern world, especially in the tech sector.

He was home by nine, however, so he still had plenty of time to brood and pace.

This was his plan, after all. His idea. Zoe would never have done any of it if he hadn't nudged her in that direction all through his marriage. It was what he wanted. And yet every high that he began to achieve thinking about it came crashing down around him in a sea of troubling doubts, paranoid whispers, and that ceaseless cold blood that froze him to the core.

After all, Randy was not a cutout or a prop. He was a real person, and his hold over Zoe was strong. Randy had convinced Zoe to do things that were way outside of her personality, way outside of their marriage... and how long would that have continued if Josh hadn't seen Randy that afternoon? What if Zoe was lying to him, and she had never planned to tell him about Randy at all? What if she would have kept deceiving him, and seeing Randy behind his back? What if this was all just Zoe's elaborate plan to keep fucking Randy, guilt-free?

He paced, poured himself a drink, and then sat down in the darkness on the couch. His cock was in a state of rigid pain. He had only to hear the phantom moaning and wet slapping of Randy and Zoe, on that long-ago phone call, to make his cock start throbbing, painfully. He didn't dare touch himself, or jerk off: Zoe could be home any minute.

Any minute.

Maybe Zoe was telling him the truth now, he thought, falling into another steep, dark, trough in his mind, but Randy's physical prowess would overwhelm her. What would she do if that happened? Would he ever be able to satisfy his wife again? Would she forget about Josh, and abandon him for the older, wiser, hotter, richer, more experienced Randy? Randy who had

plenty of time on his hands, it would seem, to fuck Zoe and coddle her and drive her around in his Jag.

A slow-burning anger had begun to eat at him, crawling from the back of his neck to his face and down his forearms, when his phone rumbled on the table in front of him. The sliver of ice that floated in his largely un-drunk whiskey shook and dissolved with the force.

He read the message.

Coming home now. In the car.

The spiral of arousal curled and rose through him, vaporizing the anger and doubt, making him buoyant again. She had sent him a message, after all, which meant that even if she was sitting in her car with a sore pussy and Randy's cum leaking into that tight black skirt, she was thinking of her husband.

*

Zoe closed the door quickly behind her. "Jo-? Oh," she said, with what he hoped was a happy note in her voice. He had flicked the light on and was walking toward her.

Zoe set her purse down. She was clutching her blouse with one hand at her abdomen, and when she let go, the crumpled fabric fell apart to her sternum: only one button remained in the material to hold it together.

Josh sucked in his breath: every part of her was marked with the manhandling by Randy. The button-less blouse, the wrinkled skirt. Her pink, dry lips, from which all trace of lipstick had been rubbed away, either by Randy's mouth or by the constant rubbing of his cock between her lips. Her dark mascara was gone from her eyelashes, and had been wiped away hastily from her cheeks, but telltale smears of black beneath her eyelids and on one side of her face told the story of dark rivers smearing her porcelain skin. Her hair was wavy, disordered, and wet in places.

She smelled like sex, he detected it within a few feet of her. A feverish flush had stained one cheek pinker than the other: this was typical of Zoe, and usually only happened in the snow.

She stood, waiting for Josh to come to her. He reached for the button of her blouse, and pulled it open with one hand. The fabric opened to expose her breasts, and no bra.

"I couldn't find it," she whispered.

Josh pushed her blouse over her shoulders, exposing her round breasts and the engorged nipples in the center of her pinkish-caramel aureole. They were fat and distended, obviously twisted or bitten, and a musky, non-female sheen of sweat -and he shuddered at the implication of what else - had dried on her skin, giving his wife an unfamiliar odor. When he touched her skin it was tacky, like she had been for a run and dried in the heat of the car.

"Are you okay?" he asked, tenderly moving his hands over her torso.

She reached behind her to unzip her skirt, which changed shape around her hips but was too tight to simply fall to the floor. She pushed it down with two hands until it slid, heavily, to her ankles.

She wasn't wearing any underwear. The scent of cum - strong, rivers of it trickling down her thighs - rushed to meet his nose. She didn't need to explain that Randy had probably torn her panties up.

Josh's voice was shaky. "What did... what did he... tell me what he did."

His eyes were on her pussy, reddened and engorged, glossy with cum. His fingers moved to her gooey slit and he traced his way between her lips, over the ridge of her clit, making her exhale sharply, her head close to his chest.

Zoe didn't answer right away, so Josh glanced up at her eyes in alarm. He caught her in a moment of reflection, thinking about something, but it seemed to him an intellectual exercise and not reverie. The image of her face in that brief moment burned into his skull, and he would think about it later. About how it was the look of someone crafting a narrative, a half-truth, or a lie. A person weighing what to say and what cards to hold.

The look disappeared immediately. Zoe was almost exaggerated as she brought her fingers to her lips and sucked on them. It was hot, and Josh's cock stiffened, but he read it as a distraction, an overcompensation for her moment of illicit thought, and the fact that he had read it in her eyes.

This could have all been bullshit, he realized, but it gnawed at him anyway.

"It was a lot like the last time," she said, making her voice throaty and teasing. "Except for the one thing... I did first. That he made me do."

An electric shudder crawled through Josh. All the skin on his body was awash with goosebumps.

Zoe put her finger in her mouth and closed her lips around it.

Josh's stomach went cold.

She popped her finger from her lips. "He made me suck his cock. All of it. He put it all the way in. And he came. And I swallowed it."

"Oh God, Zoe," Josh groaned.

She leaned close to him, putting her arms on his shoulders. "I didn't get any pictures, Josh," she said. "I'm sorry. But I can show you what I did."

Zoe slid to her knees, pulling his pants and boxers along with her as she lowered herself to the floor. She looked up at him, with her fingers closed around the bottom half of his cock. Josh stared at her, his balls aching, as she turned her face up to him and rubbed her face along the underside of his shaft. Her lips were open, and he could feel the wet heat of her mouth grazing his dick. Her tongue, however, stayed inside her mouth.

He watched a drop of pearly cum form, fatten, and fall to her forehead as she looked into his eyes and rubbed his dick over her mouth. "Randy likes to ask me," she said, breathlessly, "if that's the biggest cock I've ever had in my mouth."

Josh shuddered, and his cock bounced enough to gently slap Zoe against her lips. He exhaled, and his mouth was open, but it took him a few moments to croak: "And was it?"

Zoe moved her lips to the tip of his cock. She rubbed the precum onto her mouth, and then fluttered her eyes back up to him. "It was. And it was also the only time I ever took a whole cock all the way down my throat."

"Oh God," Josh said. He felt like he had been punched in the abdomen, right above his dick, at that moment. "Did you... did you... swallow?"

Zoe opened her mouth, and then seemed to change her mind. She licked a new glob of precum from his crown. "Let me show you what I did," she purred.

His shaft disappeared into Zoe's mouth. He watched her lips spread around his pale pink meat, and then each inch disappearing into her.

Zoe gave blowjobs very rarely, and he recalled that when she did, it always seemed to be a struggle to accommodate him. Now, his cock disappeared, and Zoe kept her eyes on his, and he was at the back of her throat in no time, with ease. Further, and her nostrils flared as she struggled to breathe.

Her lips touched the base of his cock. His hand dropped to the back of her head. She was pulling back, slowly. Then letting him sink into her again.

"Zoe," he said, as his orgasm began to boil inside of him.

She was at the end of his shaft, so she could smile. She had her teeth gently pressed against the tip of his cock as she did.

Josh made a feral noise and gripped her hair.

Zoe pushed her face forward again, taking him deep into her throat, but he was already spurting cum before she closed her lips tightly around the base of his shaft. He heard the gurgle of her throat full of semen.

And all the time, as she never had before, Zoe looked up at him. Her eyes watered as he filled her throat for the second time that night, the second man to do so, with hot cum shot directly into her spasming throat.

Zoe let him fall from her lips when she released him, and his cock splatted against her chin before falling in front of him. A long string of opaque spit, milky white, fell to her chest and her lap.

Josh supported himself on her head, shaking and exhaling.

Zoe smiled, and then stood up. "And that's not all."

*

Zoe headed for the shower, and Josh suggested she take a bath. He ran it for her, and while she waited, the tub filling up slowly around her, bubbles rising over her pretty but used body, he finger fucked her while she told him about Randy's stretching of her ass with his fingers, and his huge cock filling her up. Eventually, Zoe's words came more slowly, and her eyes grew distant, as she lost the thread of her soliloquy, and her body stiffened.

Beneath the water and the bubbles, Josh's fingers were squeezed and rolled by Zoe's thrashing inner pussy. She bobbed slightly in the bathtub, rutting against his hand, as she mewled in a way that he had never heard before in all their marriage.

Josh climbed into the tub with her. He was hard again, but Zoe may not have seen it, because she had her head leaning back and her eyes were closed. She smiled sleepily as he worked himself into the oversized tub with much sloshing of water, some of which spilled onto the floor. He blew the bubbles amassed on his side of the tub away with an exaggerated puff of air.

Zoe took one of his feet in her hands and massaged his foot weakly. Josh took hers and returned the favor.

"So I think I have an idea," Zoe said quietly. She seemed half-asleep.

"Oh yeah?" Josh said, blowing bubbles from her pretty foot. Zoe always took the time to paint her toenails. It was an odd, incongruent aspect of her, and he realized that he rarely saw her doing it. He could only think of one time: she crouched with one knee hugged to her body, as if she were tying a shoe, and applied the paint briskly. Zoe was such a naturalist about everything else, it struck him as fun, and eccentric, that she had bright red toenails.

Well, hot, too.

He bit gently into her big toe and Zoe jerked, laughing. She was too ticklish to have him play with her feet. "Stop it," she said breathlessly. Her eyes were open, and alive.

"So what's this plan?" he asked.

Zoe sat up straight and blinked slowly at him. "I don't know if I can tell you," she said, coyly.

Josh stared at her.

"I don't think I can take any more tonight," she said, smiling.

Josh's cock jerked under the water and slammed into Zoe's leg, in a mystery of physical entanglement that he could not see beneath the bubbles. Zoe smiled.

"I promise not to get worked up," Josh said, in a voice he reserved for deliberate lies he wished to be known as such.

Zoe lifted her arms out of the tub and rested them on either side of her. "As long as you promise," she teased.

"I do," Josh said. He knew Zoe could see the pathetic hunger that he knew was glimmering in his eyes, and she wouldn't believe him. Not about that.

Zoe waited, dragging the moment out, dragging her teeth over her lower lip. She had produced a hairband, seemingly from nowhere like all women seemed to be able to do, and piled her hair up on her head. "I had the idea," she said slowly, moving her legs so that it rubbed his cock. She paused for a long, long time, moving beneath the bubbles, deliberately stroking his aching dick. "And I already mentioned it to him," she continued, dragging each word out as long as possible. "So I hope you think it's a good one... otherwise..."

Josh waited. Zoe was smiling faintly.

"Otherwise?" Josh prompted. His chest was compressed from the inside, and the ache in his dick had spread slowly to his balls. He was going to fuck Zoe in this bathtub, but not until she told him her idea.

"Otherwise," she said calmly, "I don't know where you're going to stay this weekend."

Josh felt like time had stopped, and the air felt suddenly very thick and silent. He could hear a trickle of water as it sloshed into the overflow drain. Zoe shifted beneath the bubbles, and her fingers brushed over his cock, then came back to move tenderly over his crown. "Because I told Randy..."

Josh waited, stomach aching, balls feeling crushed.

"... that you are going out of town. Over the weekend."

Josh's mouth fell open.

Zoe let go of his cock and leaned back. "And I'm going to suggest to him," she said, smiling because she could see how Josh was wrapped around her finger. He was sure that she knew. "...to come..."

"...over..."

"...here."

CHAPTER 9

"You listening to me at all, man?"

Josh was pulled through a viscous, flesh-colored, moaning haze back to reality by the voice of Jim Reid.

He blinked slowly. "Yeah. Uh, yeah, Jim."

Jim narrowed his eyes.

"Okay, not really," Josh said, closing his laptop and folding his hands over it to show Jim he was, now, giving him his full attention. The laptop could have been open to anything at all, and Josh couldn't have told anyone what it was for a million dollars.

Jim straightened up and folded his own hands over his belly. "You all right?"

Josh cleared his throat, putting his hand in front of his mouth in a fist. "I am, uh... yes. Fine. Distracted. I have... stuff going on at home." He cleared his throat again.

"So do you want to divide this up piecemeal, and I'll take on fixing the art on the shopping cart page? And then you can take on the product pages?"

"Right, with, uh..."

Jim stared at him. "We've gone with knolling for the gallery," he said quietly. "You're gonna do it with the product photos we already have."

"Yes," Josh said enthusiastically. "Yes. I'm, yeah, that's almost done."

"Good for you," Jim said. He tilted his head. "Seriously, Josh. You doin' okay? You look pale."

Josh scooted his chair in and opened his laptop. He cleared his throat with his fist in front of his mouth again, a gesture he wasn't sure why he was doing. He was sick, very sick, but not in a cold/flu sort of way. "I, yeah man, just... coming down with something maybe. It's not a problem. Just making me kinda foggy."

Jim was silent, and Josh stared at his screen, trying to make sense of what he was looking at. The only thing he could see, though, was the last text message he had read on his phone. The feel of it vibrating against his right thigh, fifteen minutes earlier, still lingered in his muscles, sexual and arousing. The words had seeped into the tissue of his eyes like a burn from the sun.

I think he's on his way now.

So wait a while.

I'll text you.

She would text him. She would text him, and then he would sneak into his own house, creeping into the downstairs bedroom where they kept an office, and wait. And then, creeping around like a burglar in his own home, he would do his best to remain unseen while his wife and her lover fucked and fucked.

It was an absurd plan. Just thinking of it elevated his heart rate and made his palms sweat, as they were doing now. He wiped them on his pants and put his fingers back on the keyboard. Just imagining creeping through the shadows of his own home gave him the shakes, and he didn't want Jim to tune in to it.

But he already had. "Dude, maybe you should go home," he said, and when Josh looked up, he saw that Jim was staring at his right hand. "You have plenty of time if you want to get me -"

Josh was already shaking his head as soon as Jim started his sentence, a reflexive, knee-jerk, and much too violent head-shake. "No," he interrupted, hoarsely and with too much force. He softened his tone. "I can't... uh... I can't be home right now. Until later. So, this is... fine, I just want to wrap this up."

"You got exterminators or what? You got bed bugs?"

Bed bugs were the scourge of the city right now. It was an easy out, but Josh wasn't quick enough on the draw. "No, man. Just... you know. Wife is doing something."

Jim didn't reply, just grinned and clicked away.

A few minutes went by, and then Jim said, out of nowhere. "She doin' one of those sex toy parties?" he asked, grinning at his screen. "My wife did that."

"Kinda."

Jim grinned. Then he leaned out from his own screen and toward Josh conspiratorially. "Dude. I recommend avoiding anything she bought for you. That shit is crazy."

Josh looked at Jim. He seemed genuinely concerned. Josh managed a smile. "You speak from experience?"

Jim leaned back in and looked at his screen. "That's all I'm gonna say," he said, deadpan.

Josh treated him to a smile, but it was hard to muster.

Zoe's plan, when she had told it to him, had seemed ridiculous. It was the sort of high-risk, insane thrill Zoe liked, and so she hadn't even seen the craziness of it all for herself. Why would Randy want to come to their house, anyway? He had a pool in his house. Inside his fucking house. How would he, Josh, go unnoticed in the house for however long Randy decided to stay? Why couldn't she just ask Randy to let Josh watch them, like they had originally planned?

Zoe had answers for all of this. She had only dropped the hint that Josh was going out of town this weekend. She hadn't invited Randy over; she was planning to blow him off all week, think she was being hot and cold, and then lure him to the house letting him believe it was his own idea. She had no details about how she planned to do this. It was more of an art, she had explained.

She didn't think Randy was going to agree to letting Josh watch her. It was a different game for him, now. Randy wanted to dangle that possibility in front of her and never give it to her, she thought. Randy was playing a complex game, and Zoe wanted to beat him at it.

As she had explained all of that to Josh, he had seen a new and very different light in her eyes. It was similar to the glimmer in Zoe-the-skydiver's eyes: thrill-seeking, already decided, high on adrenaline. Unable to see the possibility of mistakes or accidents or failure.

There was something else in her eyes now, too, and it was new and unsettling.

But what had Josh done? What he always did when he saw that look in Zoe's eyes: he stepped aside and let her drag him along for the thrill.

If it worked, he was getting what he wanted.

It wasn't going to work, though, because it was insane.

He had said so much to Zoe, who at the time had been seated on his lap, his cock inside her, throbbing.

Zoe had taken a moment to let the sentence flutter about in her head, but the glimmer in her eye flashed it all away, and she rocked slowly on his hips.

"But what if it *does* work?" she had purred, her velvet inner flesh rolling over his cock, sucking the boiling cum through his shaft in pre-orgasmic pulses. "Think about *that*."

*

Jim left around eight. Josh claimed he was still working, but his gallery shots had been finished for an hour. The nice thing about this kind of job is that you could make a legitimate claim to still being "futzin'" with something for as long as you needed the excuse.

Jim didn't look like he bought that story, but he gathered up his stuff, punched a bike helmet on his head, and left. As he spun around to back himself out the door, he called out: "Remember. No anal beads, my friend."

Josh raised a hand and swung his finger in an arc in a pistol shape. Gotcha, Jim.

His eyes drifted back to his phone. His stomach, which had begun to feel like a living reptile inside of him, twisted again. Nothing yet. Nothing from Zoe.

He stared at his screen, shifting through open windows. He was the last man standing, yet again, and he didn't even need to be.

The minutes ticked by.

Eight-thirty.

"God, fuck it," he said, exasperated. He picked up the phone.

He would call, if he were out of town. Wouldn't he?

He looked up at the ceiling. The truth was, he realized, he wasn't really a responsible husband when it came to keeping in touch with his wife. He thought about her, and he loved her, but he often blew through three hours of late-night work without even remembering to call her to tell her he'd be late.

He dialed anyway.

The rings droned on sluggishly. One, two, three, four, of course she wasn't going to answer -

"- er it!" Zoe's voice was a hiss, a whisper to another party near her. "Honey. Hey."

Josh could hear in her voice the imitation of what he'd heard the night she had gone "clubbing" - in truth, fucking, at Randy's house.

"Hey," he said, and his voice sounded strange to himself. Was this part of the game?

"Did you get in okay?" Zoe said, a slight note of hysteria at the end of her question.

"In... yes. Got in fine," Josh said. "Just calling to tell you I'm a-okay. Tell you goodnight. And I love you. Did you have a nice day?"

This conversation sounded ridiculous. They never chit-chatted like this, it just wasn't their thing.

"Just another day in the paradise of Hessler Insurance. Right?"

"What're you doing tonight?"

There was a pause, a strange muffling sound. "Just... you know. Staying in."

Josh smiled. "You sound out of breath," he said. A knife of queasiness went through him, dredging up the feeling in his stomach the night he had called Zoe and said the same thing.

"I just got done... uh... running, actually. I went on a run."

Josh scanned the ceiling. What would he say to that, if this was a real conversation?

"A run?"

Zoe panted. "Gotta get back into shape," she said. "Thought about doing a marathon."

"Are you running -?"

"Yeah, I am, I'm just... finishing up right now... you mind if... I, uh... go, just gotta finish this... last bit..."

"Sure," Josh said woodenly, and the emptiness of his voice reflected the sudden hollowness that overtook his insides. She was really there, in their house, and so was Randy. "Just called to tell you I love you."

"I love you...too, honey...." Zoe panted.

"Okay, so -"

"Hey," Zoe interjected. "Don't forget you have that appointment. At nine."

Josh's chest felt cold.

"At nine."

"I'm pretty sure that's when it was."

Josh was silent.

"You told... me.... told me to remind you."

What was Randy doing to her right now, Josh wondered. Licking the inside of her thigh? Worming his fingers into her ass? Fucking her, already?

"Thanks. Yeah, okay, nine," Josh said.

"Sharp."

"Gotcha."

"Okay," Zoe said, and beneath the single syllable there was a moan craving to be released. Her voice strained with the struggle. "I love you."

"I love you, Zoe."

He heard the dead air, just before he said, "Bye."

CHAPTER 10

He could hear them upstairs. For a moment, he stood in the darkness of his own home, nothing but the light from the upstairs bedroom - *his* bedroom, the one that he shared with *his* wife - and listened to the sounds of another man fucking her, unable to believe that this was not some dream like so many others he'd had, where he would be unable to see her through a crack in the door, and only be able to listen, jerking himself endlessly but never coming.

This wasn't a dream, though. The slapping of skin, the spurting of fluids, the mewls and panting that were coming down the stairs to his ears were real.

The upstairs bedroom was on what was essentially a third floor: the stairs wound up to half-floors all the way to the top, each half-turn a different room. A studio that could also be a bedroom preceded the short flight of steps to the high-ceilinged bedroom suite, and a strange little anteroom preceded the bedroom. That was where he would be able to stand, and peer in on his wife and Randy, and he could almost feel himself standing there right now.

"Oh my, oh my, oh my God!" Zoe screamed upstairs. Josh's blood ran cold. For a moment he thought Randy was tearing her apart, and that her shrieks were screams of pain. But they ended in a faltering, strangled sort of pleasure, and the slaps of wet skin and wet organs sawing at each other continued afterward, so Josh knew that Zoe had come and was now lying limp, being fucked, enjoying the shudders of a wild orgasm.

He was thankful that the house was new as he crept up the stairs: not a creak, or a sound, could be heard. The slap of Randy's thighs against Zoe's skin became louder with each step, making his cock swell to a painful state of turgidity.

It was difficult to know if Zoe had staged the scene or not. There was no way for her to know when he would arrive, or even if he would arrive. If they had been going at it as long as it appeared they had, given the state of the bedroom. The bedding was crumpled or piled on the floor, in heaps that broadcast a dampness to them, the mixture of sweat and cum heavy in the air. A bedside lamp had been knocked against the wall, and leaned with its shade tipped up, drunkenly viewing the scene in the bed.

Randy was on top of Zoe, his skin darker than Zoe's, his frame enormous on top of her petite body. Zoe's limbs protruded from beneath his slowly shifting weight, legs spread wide to accommodate his hefty build in the sweet center of her pelvis. Her left foot, visible to Josh, clawed at the sheet, which had come off the mattress and bunched beneath her toes.

Randy covered her body completely, his fingers in her hair, her face beneath his chest as he moved slowly inside of her. Josh could hear Zoe moaning in almost a sob, and above the sound of her pleased mewls, Randy's raspy voice, just above a whisper. "That's it, little girl, get me nice and wet, get me ready."

Even though he had known, and asked for, and wanted what he was walking into, the cold fist of jealousy punched Josh hard in the chest, and sank through him, turning to a potent, ice-cold fire of arousal and nausea in his groin. He almost said aloud, "Oh God," but caught himself in time.

Zoe was making incomprehensible noises beneath him, but Randy was so large that he pressed her firmly into the mattress with no effort, and all she could do was flop her limbs uselessly at his sides. Maybe she was saying "I can't, no more, oh Randy, God," but Josh could not be sure.

The hiss of Randy's whisper cut through her moans. "Sssssshhhh. That's it, be still. You don't want to make me come, Zoe, or you're going to have a - Zoe, Zoe, I'm going to come if you don't hold still..."

Josh stared, frozen, as Randy's words trailed off into a groan and he drove deep into Zoe's pussy with a loud spurt. Zoe whimpered, and Randy threw his head back, as the muscles of his back seized and the arteries and veins in his arms bulged, just before he yelled loudly with the unbridled pleasure of an intense orgasm, throwing his head back.

He thrust into Zoe with the jerky, final stabs of a man emptying his seed. The image burned into Josh's eyes, and for a moment his vision went blurry with rage.

But it came back into focus when Randy rose onto his knees, his cock flopping from inside Zoe and slapping his thigh. It glistened with the juices that had mixed and mingled in her pussy, and was still stiff, throbbing and pulsing back to life.

Randy's cock, as Zoe had recounted, was in fact enormous. Not so astoundingly long, but thick and veined, almost a caricature of an adult toy

Josh had once seen. Beneath it, his heavy ball sacs swung for a moment with Randy's heavy breathing.

"Stay like that," he said, and it took a moment for Josh to realize that he meant that Zoe should remain as she was, her legs spread open, her arms above her head. Randy hovered over her, breathing like a fit man who had just exercised heavily. His hand dropped to his cock and felt for its hardness, while his eyes remained on Zoe's body, laid out for him on the bed like an opened present.

"That's okay," he said, as if Zoe had said something. He put his hand between her legs, and while Josh could not see what he was doing, the motion of his arm and the howl from Zoe, floating over the squelch of Randy's fingers in her cunt, told him what Randy was doing. "This will get you nice and lubed up. But you're going to have to take it for a lot longer."

Zoe's legs jerked suddenly - Randy had hit a nerve in her pussy - and she tried to snap them closed, dropping her hand between her legs. Randy pushed her legs open roughly with his elbow, keeping his hand where it was.

Josh watched as Randy pushed deeper between her legs, and Zoe's limbs fell open obediently. She grasped Randy's forearm, but she could do nothing but hold onto it. She lifted her head to look at what Randy was doing, and then threw it back, a long howl leaving her lips.

Her legs, butterflyed, started to close again.

"Lie down, lie still," Randy told her authoritatively. "Spread your legs open, that's it."

Zoe mewled and obeyed, and the next few moments were silent except for her soft howls, and the sloshing of Randy's ever-deeper plunging hand.

"Good," he said at some point. "That's good."

This went on for a while, and Zoe's breath became more ragged. Quite suddenly, Randy slid his hand slowly from inside of her, and reached for her left leg, pulling it by the knee toward her right side. "Turn over. It's time."

Josh's cock throbbed and he felt dizzy for a moment. He watched his wife roll over obediently, Randy holding his monstrous cock in his hand and watching her rise into position on her hands and knees. Using his own legs, he nudged her legs together, centering her between his legs. He lifted his cock and let it fall on her back, in the ridge just above her ass. It landed with a slap that echoed through the room.

He dropped his hand and reached low to draw the juices from her pussy up to her asshole. Placing his hand on her lower back and buttock, making her arch her back, he sank his thumb into Zoe's ass.

"Oh!" Zoe squealed, drawing her breath in sharply.

"Relax," Randy told her calmly, his hand twisting as he embedded himself in deeper. He reached with his free hand as he leaned over Zoe, and pushed her hair to one side, turning her head toward him. "Look at me, little girl. I want you to look at me, that's it." He drew his breath in sharply. "Oh fuck, that's hot. So nice and hot, and silky, and tight."

Josh's eyes were fixed on Zoe's face, the way she was looking at Randy. Her eyes were beginning to glaze slightly. Randy fucked her with his thumb for a few moments, staring at her face, his mouth open with the hungered, fevered look of a man who is about to get everything he wants.

He shifted his hand, twisting it to sink two fingers into her ass. As he did, Zoe's butt leaned slightly to the right, and Josh was treated to the sight of Randy's fingers plunging deep into her ass.

"Uh, uh," Zoe said, turning her head, making sounds Josh had never heard her make, ever. "Oh!"

"Turn around and get those eyes back here, little girl, that's it," Randy said. Zoe turned back to face him, her mouth hanging open. "Relax," Randy coached. "You're going to have to relax, that's it, oh yeah, that's so hot and tight, I can't wait to fuck your tight little ass full of cum."

He started to fuck Zoe with his two fingers, the sticky sound of it crackling over even Zoe's mewls and their heavy breathing. Zoe watched, and then, as the fucking became more rapid, her chest collapsed to the mattress, her eyes still on Randy, her hands balling the trashed sheets in her fists.

Randy slowed what he was doing and started to feel Zoe's ass, almost like he was sampling the feel of a material he wanted to buy. "So hot," he said. "Now you're nice and wet." He leaned his head over her body, and Josh's heart fell with the glistening drop of spit that he let fall from his lips to the center of her ass.

"You ready, little girl?" he asked Zoe.

Zoe made a sound, and then Josh heard her pant before murmuring, "I don't know. I don't know if I can do it."

"You can do it. You're going to push out just like I taught you, just like you're doing now. Just let it slide right in. I'll go nice and slow, baby, just to break you in. You're going to love it."

"Uhn," Zoe said.

Randy met her eyes, and continued finger-fucking her while he stared down at her, as if to underscore his dominance.

Suddenly, as if he had been taken by a whim, he pulled his fingers out and used his right hand to tip Zoe to the side, causing her to fall into a fetal position. Quickly, he pulled and jerked her body around, Zoe limp like a ragdoll in his hands.

"What?" Zoe said meekly, but the question almost faded away before the final sounds, as if she didn't care about the answer at all.

Randy pushed her legs up, holding them next to her ears.

"This is your first time, right? First time a man has ever fucked your ass?" Randy said. He didn't wait for her answer. "I want to see it, I want to see your face while I break you in." He moved her hands to her legs, and placed them on her thighs, mid-way down. "Hold on just like that."

Josh stared, unable to process that Zoe was behaving like Randy's puppet. She seemed to have forgotten all about Josh, all about anything except what Randy was ordering her to do. She held her thighs and let her knees bend. The position was obscene and filthy, and Josh loved it as much as it gnawed at his soul.

He pictured himself briefly, as the urge to relieve the tight pressure of his confined cock occurred to him. A man behind a door, peering through the crack to watch his wife let another man fuck her like a dirty whore. The pain was almost unbearable, but he didn't dare unzip his pants for fear of the spectacle it would make if he were somehow caught.

He licked his lips. His mouth was dry and his breath almost scorched him. Randy was scooting in toward Zoe, pushing her legs up and out further, tilting her ass up to him. "This way all that cum in your pussy will roll right down and get you nice and wet. You're gonna need it," Randy said.

He lifted Zoe by the hips and set her ass on the edge of his knees. "Here we go, baby," Randy said. "Just relax, let me slide right in. You can take it."

"Uh!" Zoe cried, as Randy pushed the tip of his cock against her ass. Josh could see the pressure against him, bending his cock slightly, as Zoe's

ass clenched against his force.

"Don't fight it," Randy said. "Just push out, and then I'll go... yeah, like that... right in. Look up here. Yeah look at me, I want to see your face..."

Josh's abdomen ached, and his cock felt like it was going to burst. Randy's long, thick cock sank forward, disappearing into Zoe's ass. He was sure that he could hear a sort of splitting sound - nothing breaking, but a kind of crackling of sphincters and flesh being stretched incredibly wide, almost too wide.

"Oh, Randy, I can't... I can...t...oh!" Zoe was saying. Her voice was a murmur, one that faded as she spoke, until it trailed off into a mumbling moan.

Randy's pelvis was sinking, sinking down, his cock going further and deeper. "Oh, fuck, yeah baby, fuck, yeah, that's good, just a little further, oh you're so fucking tight, your ass is so fucking tight, just relax..."

And then he was in, balls against her ass, grinding himself deep into her hole. Zoe was silent, staring up at him, her hands falling away from her legs, which were pinned by Randy now anyway. He leaned into them, and then sank on top of her.

"Oh, fuck," he groaned. His was the pleasure of a man who has just been deep into another man's wife, who feels her for the first time. It was a sound Josh had only imagined and never heard, but it had its own, immediately recognizable sound.

Randy pushed Zoe's hair from her face and looked at her. His hips rolled over her body, but Zoe was silent, mouth open. Her leg shook, and Randy continued to roll slowly on top of her, moving slowly and steadily.

"Come for me one more time, Zoe," he said. "You like that? You like how it feels, don't you? Your husband never fucks you like this, does he? You have no idea how long I've wanted to fuck you in every hole."

Zoe made a sound. Her thighs trembled, and she squirmed beneath Randy, her mewls a mixture of discomfort and pleasure. Randy was grinding against her, rubbing her clit, and Josh recognized the shaking of her body that preceded an orgasm.

He stared, the world closing in around him, the reality of what was happening becoming starker and more real with each second, as his wife shuddered and spasmed, and then went stiff beneath Randy's moving body. A long, low scream crept from under his shoulders, and then it was muffled

in his arm as Zoe clawed at his back and shook underneath him. The sound of her pussy spewing cum and fresh juices wafted beneath all of her screams, which died slowly into Randy's shoulder like the trembling of her legs.

"That's it," Josh heard Randy growl. "Now you're good. Now you can just lie down, and take it."

He flipped her again, back to her hands and knees. Zoe was limp, her eyes vacant, and she allowed Randy to move her into position. She sank to her chest again, arms tucked under her, and that is when, at last, her eyes met Josh's.

Or did they? He couldn't tell if her glassy-eyed stare contained any recognition, or if she just happened to be looking in that direction. Could she even see him through the crack? Did she even care about him anymore?

Her body slid slightly, but her face remained lost and expressionless as the wet, cracking sound signaled that Randy was sliding into her ass again.

Her lips parted slightly, and then she was rocking and sliding against the mattress as Randy began to saw into her.

Randy took his time at first, elongating each stroke of his cock, pulling out nearly to the tip, and then plunging back in. His eyes were on his own cock, and Josh imagined his view: Zoe's tiny ass between his legs, his cock sinking into her ass. The feel of her flesh squeezing tightly around him.

He started to fuck her more quickly, and with more force, until he had her by the hips and was hammering so hard his balls were slapping into her soaked pussy with an audible, wet smack. "Oh fuck, Zoe. Fuck, you feel so good."

This went on for a long time, while Josh stared, rigid from head to toe except for his throbbing cock, at the sight of his wife being ass-fucked thoroughly and soundly by another man. It felt like a dream, but he knew it was real.

How long Randy fucked her like that, it was impossible to know. He showed no signs of fatiguing, and Zoe began to squirm and moan, but her moans were moans of pleasure.

Randy slowed and thrust his hips to barrel deeper inside of her. He reached forward and grabbed her hair, and, leaning back on his heels, pulled her up with him, settling her onto his lap.

He rested Zoe's back against his chest and took her tits into his hands. Zoe leaned back and closed her eyes, rocking her hips and squirming in his hands while he twisted her nipples in his fingers until they were red. His mouth was against her ear and he was saying something Josh couldn't hear.

"Yeah," Zoe moaned, in the most sexualized whine Josh had ever heard from her. Randy kept talking, and Zoe's hands dropped to his imprisoning thighs and began to push against them, lifting her body from his lap, then falling back down. "I can do it," she mewled.

Randy leaned back on one hand, getting a view of Zoe's ass. His other hand remained on her right breast, kneading and mauling it.

Zoe rose on her knees, and the many inches of Randy's cock slid slowly from inside her ass. Then she went down again, and back up.

"That's good. That's good. Keep riding that cock, oh fuck yeah. That's so hot."

Josh could not believe anything he was seeing now: Zoe, her hair damp, her skin glistening with sweat and fetid fluids, working so hard to ride Randy's cock *in her ass*.

She was, in that moment, so distinctly different from the woman he married, that he felt as if he had been transported to some other place, where some other woman was fucking like a wild whore.

"Go all the way. Get it all the way out," Randy said. "I want to feel you spread open again."

"I don't, I don't think...I...can..."

Randy gripped her hip and pushed her as she rose the next time, until his cock swung away free, a loud slurp announcing its exit from her ass. Abdominal muscles straining, he used the hand he had been resting on to guide his crown to her gaping asshole, where he positioned it in the wet, closing center of her eyelet.

Zoe flipped her hair and it stuck to her cheek as she whipped her head to look back at Randy. The vacant look in her eyes was gone, replaced by one of wild hunger. "I want it, put it back, Randy, please, it's going to... oh, oh..." And then the sound leaving Zoe's mouth became a strangled scream. Her head fell forward, and then fell back, her mouth open in a silent scream.

Randy's hand dropped between her legs. "You dirty slut," Josh heard him say. "You're going to come again?"

Josh couldn't see anything more than his hand, rubbing Zoe between the legs - but he could hear perfectly the sticky sound of Randy's fingers working on her clit. Zoe's breathing crescendoed to a wild, screaming chorus of "Oh, oh, *oh!!!*" as she bounced herself wildly on Randy's lap. "Oh! Oh... god... oh... oh my god..."

Her voice went in the opposite direction, becoming softer, disintegrating into a whisper. Then she was silent as her body shook wildly, and she came, unable to even make a sound. She fell forward in a silent scream, to her chest again, and Randy began to fuck her as she lay there, limp and trembling.

"You want me to come now, baby?"

Zoe made a noise that could have meant anything.

"Say it. Or I'm going to fuck you all night long. You'll have to say it, or your ass is going to be good and sore."

Zoe made another noise, and lay there taking his punishing thrusts for a few moments.

Then, her arms trembling, she turned back to him again. "Please," she panted. "I... I can't... I want to feel your come in my ass. Please."

Randy fucked her a few times before murmuring, "That's good. Keep talking like that. You want me to come?"

"I want you to come," Zoe panted.

"You want me to come, keep telling me that you want to be my little sex slave, that's what I want to hear. Tell me that you want to make me happy, you little slut. And look at me, look at me while you tell me."

Zoe rolled her head to the side, and Randy lifted her arm over her ribcage and flung it behind her back, turning her torso to the side. Her tits bounced and she looked at the door, right to where Josh was - surely she knew he was there - before she looked up at Randy and mewled.

"Say it," Randy growled. "I won't be able to come until you say it. Tell me you want to please me, you want to be my sex slave."

Zoe panted, indecisive, or perhaps unable to speak. Randy had been hammering away at her ass for almost ten minutes now.

"Say it."

"I want," Zoe panted. "I want... to be your... I want you to come in my ass."

"You want to make me happy."

"I want to make you happy," Zoe repeated listlessly.

"Like you mean it. 'I want to make you happy, Randy. I want to be your little sex slave.' Say it, say it like you mean it, and you'll get a big load of cum."

"I want to make you happy," Zoe whimpered. "Oh!"

"That's good," Randy slowed, dragging his cock slowly from inside her. He slid in just as slowly. "That's good, say it again."

"I want to make you happy. I want to be your sex slave. Randy. Please."

Randy dropped his hand to her ass and patted it. "Good girl. Tell me that you love it when I fuck you."

"I love it when you fuck me."

"Say my name. Tell me how much you love it."

Zoe was breathless. Randy was sawing at her, his teeth gritted, his eyes fierce and intense. It was at this moment that Randy's obsession with Zoe was laid bare and clear to see: making her take his cock in her ass while she told him how much she loved it was so obviously the man's deep fantasy, an enactment of his personal masturbation material, that Josh could scarcely believe he hadn't seen it before: Zoe had never led any of this, it had been what Randy wanted all along. Randy didn't care about Josh or his fantasy, he was seeking his own.

"Say it, Zoe."

Zoe pushed her hair up and looked at Randy. She mewled. And then she said, in a high-pitched, jaggedly mewling whisper:

"I love it when you fuck me, Randy. I love it when you fuck my ass. I love it, Randy, I want you to fuck my ass full of cum."

Her words traveled through Randy's body like an electric shock, and he slammed violently into her, his orgasm already gripping him. Veins stood out in his temple as he groaned, and then yelled, and then smashed his pelvis hard against her as he emptied his load inside her ass.

Zoe mewled and stretched her arms in front of her, taking her damp hair with her hand to push it from her face. Randy shuddered as her body moved around his cock. He was still deep inside her, staring at his meat sunk deep into her tiny ass.

"Stay like that," Randy said quietly, as she began to stir.

"Oh," Zoe half-whimpered, half-moaned. "Randy," she said breathlessly. "I'm so... I'm too..."

His hands dropped to her hips and clutched her narrow frame in a vice-grip, indenting her skin until it turned pink. Zoe's eyes went wide and she tried to turn back toward him.

"Randy," she panted.

"Stay like that, I'm not done with you yet."

There was a pause, and then Zoe's voice, a faint whisper. "Randy..."

Randy's mouth was partially open, and he was staring down at Zoe. Perhaps his stare was what made her cease to object, to lie still, his cock still filling her just-fucked ass. She squirmed, her ankles twisting, but she didn't object, or try to pull away from him.

"I knew you'd be the kind of girl who liked it in the ass," Randy said, stroking her bottom. His left hand still gripped her hip, and he made broad, casual strokes over her backside. Zoe squirmed.

Randy moved his hips, and Zoe's eyes fluttered closed. She bit her lip and sucked in a breath with a high-pitched squeal of pleasure. Then her eyes flew open. "Randy," she purred, lifting a hand to her ass, reaching for his cock. "I can't, I can't, I can't take it again, please, not yet..."

Josh felt fear in his chest, a sudden desire to burst in and save Zoe from this manhandling goon. He steeled himself for the confrontation: Josh wasn't confrontational by nature, and Randy, with his faded tattoo and strong physique, did not look like a pushover.

He opened his eyes, heart pounding, and was just about to take a step into the hallway, when Zoe squealed, followed by a wet slap. Randy's cock, still rigid, only slightly deflated by his adventures in Zoe's every hole, had slipped from her ass.

Randy dropped his hand to her asshole and appeared to swirl his pointer finger around the rim. Zoe's eyes closed, but she made no sound.

"You've been a good girl, Zoe," Randy said, almost absent-mindedly. His eyes were on his finger, swirling in her ass. "So I'll let you take a break. But I'm not done with you yet." He pushed Zoe onto her back, and folded her legs to one side. He held his dick, which was throbbing back to life in an almost terrifying nod to the power of Viagra, to her soaked slit and ass, rubbing it menacingly between her legs.

"Not done at all," he repeated, leaning over her, pushing her legs up by the side of her face. He kissed her on the mouth, and then rose up to his knees, while Zoe's legs fell slowly to her left.

Then Randy, as if he owned the place, scooted from the side of the bed, stood up, shook his dick, and strolled into the en-suite bathroom. Josh heard the water turn on and splash loudly on the tile.

Josh stepped out from behind the door, and Zoe let her legs fall down and to her left side. She stared at him, her eyes almost vacant, her arms spread open. They looked at each other, and for a moment Josh was unsure of what direction things would take.

She brought a thumb to her mouth and chewed on the tip. "Did you like it?" she mouthed.

Josh shuddered and swallowed before nodding, solemnly. It seemed strange to do anything else. He quashed the idiotic notion to give her a thumbs-up, and was grateful that he restrained himself. Zoe smiled. He smiled back, unsteadily.

She rolled to her side and onto her knees, facing him. Her hair was tangled and wet, clinging to her face. Her lips and nipples looked used and swollen. His eyes dropped to her engorged slit, to the red puffiness of her outer labia, the cum snaking from inside her and down her inner thigh.

Zoe let him take her in, the full, filthy mess of her. And then, she rolled to a seated position, and put her feet on the floor, and stood up.

For a moment it seemed like she was coming toward him, but then she heard the splash of the shower, and she looked toward the bathroom.

She mouthed something to Josh before turning to walk into the bathroom. He didn't know what it was. He had missed it, looking at a patch of filmy white on her shoulder.

She had smiled, and he had tried to open his mouth or move a hand to tell her to wait, that he hadn't seen her lips moving.

But it was too late, and she was slinking into the bathroom. She disappeared.

Moments later, he heard the water splashing strangely, the slap of wet flesh, and a low, male groan.

He gave it some thought: the idea of creeping forward in his own bedroom to where he would be able to glimpse Randy and whatever he was

doing to Zoe in the shower. The thought tantalized him, curling like a fist around his balls and squeezing. But ice-cold fear twisted along his spine.

He retreated into the shadows, and listened, the ache inside him violent and sharp.

*

Josh stared into the small, dark patio area, called a "yard" in the real estate description of the townhome. It was covered in "maintenance-free" rock of a color curated to match the aesthetic of the townhome. In the dark, washed over with the dim light of street lamps, it looked bleak.

He glanced at the clock again. He did this too often: time felt as though it had stopped. The noise from upstairs had ended, he was sure of it, but phantom screams and moans still pervaded his mind so realistically that he doubted himself. Randy couldn't still be going *at it*, he reasoned. *Zoe* couldn't still be going at it, for that matter.

That was *reason*, though, and Josh was not in a reasonable state of mind. Hiding like a fugitive in his own home, while Randy had his way with Zoe upstairs. It was a fantasy beyond anything he'd ever fantasized about Zoe with another man: longer, more filthy, more visceral. But it had come with a price, jagged edges that cut him every time he maneuvered through this nightmarish dream.

It was 2:32am. His eyes were itchy with tiredness, but his heart was still beating too fast to sleep. Who could fall asleep in a position like this? All he could was sit, slumped in the chair of his boxy home-office, and wait for the minutes to tick away until Zoe and Randy roused themselves again.

Would they just go on and on like this? How many times would Randy fill her with his cum? What had he missed as he slunk away into the shadows? Would he ever be able to fuck Zoe again without the image of Randy's dominance casting a shadow over his own inadequacies: the size of his cock, the unwillingness to fuck Zoe like a whore until she made those feral sounds?

Minutes stretched into hours, and he felt suspended in time, his pain and arousal never ebbing. At last, his eyelids grew heavy.

The sound that broke into his near-sleep was not a creak or a squeak: this house was too new, too carefully engineered for that. It was the soft sound of footsteps, very light ones, but it shattered his reverie into a million pieces and sent his heart racing. Maybe he had been asleep: the room was

dark and the shadows menacing. The memory of the whole sordid evening swallowed him whole, and he felt like he should run.

But where?

The footsteps came closer, and then a shadow moved across the wall.

"Josh?"

It was Zoe, her voice a barely audible whisper. He turned in the chair so she could see him, and he held up a hand to stop her from speaking again.

She was wearing a long t-shirt, and somewhere in the back of his mind he understood it was not his, or hers, but Randy's. A shiver of the nauseated-aroused kind shook his chest, and he opened his mouth as though to say something, but had nothing to say.

Zoe walked toward him. The expression on her face was obscured by the darkness, only patches of grayish light gave him a glimpse of her face as she moved. Was she smiling? Serious? Taunting and grinning cruelly? Or open-mouthed and hungry? He couldn't know.

She stood before him for a moment. He could feel the heat of her body first, and then the scent of her skin came to him, complex and partly foreign. There was the scent of *her*: the tangy sweetness of her pussy, the ripe sweet scent that lingered at her neck, their shared soap. And strewn among these scents, there was the smell of sex. Of Randy's cum, of sweat, of another man lingering on her body.

She slid her knees to either side of his body, first right, then left, and the mixture of scents grew stronger as her legs parted so that she could sit on his lap. He could tell from the strength of the scent that reached his nostrils that she had no underwear on: there was nothing between her freshly, thoroughly-fucked cunt and him but empty space.

"Randy's asleep," she said quietly, her lips close to his.

She could feel his erection: he was in his boxers only and it was twitching insanely, growing to a firmness he could barely stand.

"Are you okay?" she asked. "Was that okay?"

His hands were moving independently of his thoughts: somehow, they had arrived at her waist and pushed beneath the shirt that smelled like aftershave and men's deodorant, and not his. Her frame swam inside it, and he ran his hands along her ribs and up to her nipples. Patches of her skin

were tacky to the touch, maybe sweat, maybe cum, maybe spit had dried there and clung to her smooth veneer.

Her nipples were erect, but they seemed fat beneath his fingers. The thought washed through him: they were swollen, distended from Randy's endless biting and massaging and twisting. He felt her body shudder tiredly beneath his hands.

"I'm so sore," she breathed. "Everywhere."

His cock throbbed against her leg. He lifted the shirt over her head, and let it fall to the floor. He had hundreds of things he wanted to say but couldn't quite bring any of them together as a sentence. In the dark, her body looked the same, but everywhere his fingers could explore, she felt used, tacky, and slightly swollen.

"Randy's asleep," she said again. Her hand moved to his cock, and she fished it out of his boxers. Her fingers closed around his shaft and squeezed. She moved her thumb over his oozing crown, where precum made her skin slippery against his.

Looking into his eyes, she guided his cock to her slit. It was hot, and so slippery and wet he couldn't tell where his dick was being guided to, exactly. She rolled her hips, and pushed him inside of her hot, sticky mess of a cunt, then pushed her pelvis forward to get him deep inside. A light whimper of pleasure left her lips, but she cut it short. "You have to be quiet," she said.

He stared at her mouth as she moved on top of him. It was serious, open, and beneath her lower lip, he could see what looked like a dried dribble of cum.

Her pussy engulfed him, so wet that there was almost no friction as she rocked on top of him. That barely mattered, he only had to think of Randy's cock deep in her ass, her eyes staring vacantly at him through the crack, and he was already climbing to his peak.

"Did you see it?" she asked.

He slid his hand over her hip and down to her ass-crack, where she was sticky and wet, and his fingers found her asshole. It was gaping, just slightly, and hot liquid gushed in small waves over his finger with each roll of her hips.

"Zoe..." he breathed. "I'm going to..."

Her lips curled at the corners in a little smile, and then her mouth fell open again. She continued to fuck him, slowly, deliberately, watching his eyes as she moved him at a tedious, almost unbearable pace, to his orgasm.

When it gripped him, he clutched her buttock and his middle finger plunged into her ass. White, blinding light flashed at the corners of his eyes, and he feared for a moment that he would have a heart attack. His entire body seized up and he swallowed the scream he wanted desperately to let loose, grunting ferally instead and thrusting himself deep into Zoe's well-used cunt.

His own seed barely made a dent in the slop that already filled her. She smiled, and squeezed his shoulder, leaning back to look at his face.

He spluttered, trying to submerge another cry that wanted to escape him. He tipped his head forward to her shoulder and stared at his cock, at the shiny flesh that had parted for it, and Zoe's toned thighs.

His heart pounded violently against his chest. He lifted his head and touched Zoe's lips. "I'm sorry," he said loudly. He dropped his voice to a whisper. "I didn't... you didn't..."

Zoe put a finger to his lips, and smiled, before kissing him fully on the mouth.

Then she moved off him, her lips still on his, until she was standing and leaning down to kiss him. She bit his lower lip gently, and scooped the shirt from the floor. "Sshh," she said, very quietly.

She pulled the shirt over her head. "I'm going back up. I love you."

She retreated, walking backward, and when she turned to walk down the hall, he noticed the slight change to her gait.

It was only seconds before his cock, so recently relieved, began to twitch again, as he realized that her ass was probably so sore that she had to change how she walked to accommodate the effects of Randy's abuse.

He glanced at the clock, what seemed like hours later.

3:17am.

CHAPTER 11

Zoe crept back to the upstairs bedroom after getting a glass of water from the kitchen. She needed it, desperately, and chugged a whole glassful standing by the sink, before pouring herself a large glass from the chilled water in the fridge and sneaking back upstairs. The water was meant to provide a plausible reason for creeping downstairs while Randy was sleeping, but as she crept into her own bedroom, the insanity of that idea struck her like a hard slap.

Randy was sprawled on the bed, face-up, just as he had been when she had left him. The sheets had long since been twisted and wadded into damp, sordid piles that lay strewn about the floor, so he was naked. His cock, at long last, had returned to a flaccid state, but his muscled body seemed coiled with his insatiable hunger.

Zoe walked gingerly to the bedside table and set the water down. She was shaking a little: this was likely the combined effect of exhaustion and the sneaky thing she had just done with Josh. Her pussy and ass were sore with the kind of well-used muscle soreness that a strenuous workout brings, verging on discomfort but not fully there. Staring at Randy, hoping he wouldn't wake, she eased her weight carefully onto the mattress and lay down. She stared at the ceiling, her mind a wild blur of thoughts and feelings. But sleep claimed her almost instantly.

She awoke lying on her side, the feel of hot skin against her back. Fingers moved over her body, and against her left butt-cheek she could feel the stiffening of a cock. For a brief moment, she was floating in a thought-free miasma, but as Randy's muscled arm draped over her body she recognized it as his, not Josh's, and the entire sordid night came back to her.

Randy pulled her body tight to him and meshed his fingers in her hair. His breath was hot on her neck as he grazed her shoulder with his bristly jaw. Her eyes were open, and she tried to turn toward him. Perhaps she meant to defer his attention, or tell him she couldn't possibly get at this again. But Randy pinned her to his body with the arm draped over her chest. His hand went to her jaw, pressing only hard enough to claim possession of her, a pressure that was final, decisive: she was his to do with as he pleased.

Worry flickered through her but was extinguished by the arousal his raw, dominating grip spread through her. Her body was exhausted, depleted, and yet deep inside her every hole she felt a rapidly growing ache, her tissues welling up with juices, a desire to push against Randy's body and let him do as he pleased.

He must have sensed her submission, because his hand released her jaw and traveled down her chest, between her breasts, not even pausing there. He turned his palm toward her and cupped her slit, sinking his middle finger into the pulpy center and stroking her clit.

Her eyes closed and her throat purred like a cat. Neither action was anything she had control over: her body was Randy's puppet, and her mind had lost any battle against that slavery.

Randy was kissing her neck and her exposed cheek, mawing at her ear. This was not done with any particular sophistication: it was the animal mauling of a caveman.

But the sticky slop of her pussy could not tell a lie: it was turning her on wildly, making her crave his huge cock inside of her, wherever he wanted to put it. That it would press against the slightly bruised fruit of her body with a consistent ache that her pleasure would not entirely mask didn't matter to her, in fact, the idea of that particular pleasurable pain only made her pussy gush more fluid onto his fingers.

Her limbs jerked involuntarily when he pressed his finger against her clit and dragged it slowly up and then back down.

"That's good," Randy breathed in her ear. "That's a good girl. You're so fucking wet, Zoe, you little slut. You want it so bad."

He didn't waste any time from there. He shifted his hips and lifted her leg by nudging his own beneath her knee. She felt the fat crown of his cock against the opening of her pussy, and for a moment it seemed too big to take again. Her insides throbbed with the memory of the consistent, seemingly endless fucking he had subjected her to the night before, and another flicker of hesitation and fear traveled through her.

But it was gone as his meat spread her open. A twinge of sharp pain as her pussy stretched to accommodate him, and then waves of pleasure as her body spasmed around his cock and he filled her. He let her leg fall, and pulled her close to him, spooning her. His hand went to her neck, closing

gently around it, then more firmly, just before his grip would have constricted her throat.

The pressure of his dick stroked the left side of her canal more firmly. The sensation was new enough to be unsettling, to make her almost desperate as he slowly fucked her. Everyone becomes used to the way their lover fucks them, the way their own fingers bring their own bodies to orgasm. The strokes are expected, formulaic. Now Randy was rubbing some dimension of her that never received the focus of attention, and it was maddening.

He fucked her slowly, adding to her madness. Within minutes she was desperate to come, and if he would push her to her stomach or flip her on her back, it would take only a second to satisfy her. But he didn't: he just kept sawing inside of her slowly, his hand around her neck, tipping her head back against his chest. His breath caressed her temple, and her forehead occasionally bumped against his stubbled chin.

After a while, it was too much for her to take in silence. She heard herself whimper, then mewl, then howl like an animal. "Oh," she managed to say. "Randy... oh.... uhhnnn...."

"You want to come, don't you, my little slut? That's what you want?"

"Randy..." she breathed. Tears were forming in the corners of her eyes, the pleasure and pain of longing too much for her to tolerate.

"Not yet," Randy whispered. He drew his cock out with an excruciating slowness, and Zoe heard herself make a noise almost like a sob.

"Randy, please," she moaned. She *needed* to come. Her pussy was throbbing and raw, and it felt almost like a wild animal had been loosed inside of her.

Randy moved his cock to her ass. Her eyes, falling closed in a stupor, flew open. She gasped and made a feeble effort to squirm away. But his hand was firmly on her neck, and she didn't really want to escape.

"I don't think I can..." she whined. "Oh, oh, Randy, I can't, I'm too sore...." Her final word trailed off in a warble, because Randy pushed his cock inside her ass in that moment. Slowly, methodically, but insistently.

Her eyelet had returned to its regular size, so she heard the same crackling sound at the time that a sharp pain gripped her momentarily. She opened her mouth to cry out, but by the time she realized she was making

no sound at all, the meaty fullness of Randy's cock was sliding smoothly into her, filling her, and the sharp pain was gone.

Patches of her ass were rough, a little dry, and the friction of his cock in those places was intense and brutal. Elsewhere, the loads of cum he had fucked into her the previous night, and her own juices, sliding endlessly down her perineum and into her ass, made him glide against her tender flesh.

"There you go," Randy said quietly. "That's good. Just like that, take it all. I'm going to fuck your ass full of cum again, Zoe. Would you like that?"

Zoe whimpered. He closed his hand a little tighter on her throat. "Yes," she panted. "I'd like it."

Randy was sliding back out, and her ass throbbed emptily. She was relieved when he filled her again. He fucked her slowly like this for a few long, excruciatingly pleasurable minutes.

"Make yourself come," he told her.

Zoe mewled and moved her right hand to her pussy. Even to her own fingers, her flesh felt strange: engorged, so wet it seemed like a liquid. When she found her clit in the soupy mix it was too tender to touch. She gave a squeaky whine and stopped moving her hand.

"Make yourself come," Randy said. "I want you to come while I'm in your ass. That's what I want, and you're going to give it to me, aren't you? Because you're a good little girl. Now touch yourself."

Zoe obeyed, and closed her eyes tightly as if that would block out the intensity of the pleasure as she stroked her clit. She was almost crying.

"Randy, I can't... I..."

He closed his fingers on her throat until she couldn't breathe, and then released her. She moved her fingers obediently.

Her hips moved, and Randy moved within her as she stroked her clit. The orgasm built long past when she would have expected to come, rising to a screeching, mind-numbing pain that made her think she wouldn't come, ever. "Oh," she complained, desperation building inside of her.

"I'm going to fuck you full of cum, little girl, if you can be good for me. You're so close, aren't you, you little slut? Keep going, I want to feel you squeezing me like a little whore."

Zoe moved her fingers faster and started to shake. Would she never come? Would she be consigned to this excruciating pain and high altitude

forever, forever craving? "I... can...t..." she panted, braying.

But then, at last, she was violently tumbling over the crest. Her whole body turned rigid for a moment, and the air was squeezed from her lungs by the pressure of Randy's arm against her chest. He closed his hand tightly on her throat, and waves of pleasure so intense they were painful fell over her in starry, bright, waves, eating away at her consciousness from the sides of her vision. Her ears were ringing loudly, and she was sure she was going to lose consciousness.

How long she was in the grip of this semi-asphyxiated orgasm, she would never be able to figure out. The feel of Randy's cock rose to prominence in her consciousness, as her ass clenched tightly around it and she was unable to control the pulsing of her muscles. He was fucking her: she could feel him inside of her, feel her pussy gushing hot liquid between their legs, feel his skin hot against her back.

This went on for what seemed like a very long time. Slowly, she floated back down to earth, and could only feel Randy in her ass. It was all she could think of, even as the starriness receded from her vision, and the sounds of the room overtook the high-pitched clamor in her ears. She could hear the soggy spurts of his cock inside of her, feel his muscles tensing up. His cock seemed to grow, her ass began to ache.

He thrust hard, suddenly, ramming his cock even deeper inside of her, when he came. He squeezed her tightly against his chest and she could not have breathed if she had tried, but she didn't: she was suspended in a silent scream. Traveling through was a small crest, a lot like an orgasm, a wave of pleasure that faded away in throbs.

In her ass, she felt a wet heat. Randy thrust hard inside of her three more times, at ragged, random intervals, a grunt escaping his throat that reverberated against her back.

His mouth was at the top of her, against the back of her crown. She could feel his breath through her hair, hot, cool where she was damp with sweat. Inside her ass, his still-hard cock pulsed away the last splutters of his orgasm.

"You okay?" Randy whispered, bending his left elbow, which was extended above him and beneath his head, to put his fingers in her hair.

I don't know, Zoe thought, just before she moved her head feebly in assent.

She was exhausted. Her eyelids felt, suddenly, like they were weighted, and they fluttered closed.

Minutes may have gone by. She was deep in the last, green-gray layers of consciousness when she heard him - far enough down in the silent, numbing sea of sleep to question whether she had heard him at all. But whether it was real or not, it made her blood rush through her with a loud clap in her ears, and her eyes flew open.

"I love you," Randy may or may not have whispered.

*

Josh heard Randy leave - and all that happened before he did - in the early hours of Sunday morning. They slept on Saturday until the afternoon, while Josh quietly seethed and starved and didn't dare leave the office except to pee in the bathroom across the hall without flushing.

They awoke sometime in the afternoon and started fucking again. Josh crept up to watch: the door was wide open and he could lean across from the stairs enough to see all that he dared to see: Randy and Zoe spooning, the grunting and screaming and feral sounds his wife made as Randy fucked her from behind.

They seemed to fall asleep again after that episode. Shaking, Josh returned to the office, creeping into the kitchen to quietly open a cupboard and grab the first thing he found. It turned out to be a bag of expensive, trendy olives that Zoe must have purchased, which sent a momentary rage through him that almost sent him storming upstairs to kick Randy the fuck out of his wife, and his bed, and his house. He hated olives.

He ate them anyway, staring at the wall, ear attuned to any sound from upstairs.

But Josh was as tired as they were, so, propped up against the wall on a daybed in the corner of the office, he fell asleep, the open bag of olives in his hand.

The doorbell rang. Josh's eyes flew open and his heart stopped cold in his chest. The olives tipped and the warm oil spilled into the joggers he'd dug out of the closet of junk in that room. The sensation was akin to warm cum on his thigh, psychologically equivalent to having come just after watching the filthiest porn imaginable and still having it on right in front of you, displaying the filth and depravity of your mind long after the testosterone and cum have left your body and you no longer crave it.

Heavy footsteps thudded down the stairs. A flash of jealous rage gripped Josh, and his dick stiffened.

The door opened, and friendly banter ensued. Josh was perplexed for a moment, until he heard the rustle of a paper bag after the door closed.

Take-out.

The footsteps went into the kitchen. Josh heard his refrigerator being opened by the man who was fucking his wife. Wine bottles were jostled and clinked, the pop of a cork echoed in the nearly-silent house. The footsteps, and a tinkling of glasses and the rustle of bags, went back up the stairs.

The back of his neck grew hot with a new kind of jealousy. Sure, it had seemed like a great idea, this weekend of Randy fucking his wife where he could easily watch it - it had been *his own fucking idea, after all* - but now the guy was eating Chinese in his bed? After fucking the living crap out of his wife?

He looked down at his oil-stained joggers. His cock, predictably, did not have the same reservations about Randy as Josh's mind did. Josh leaned his head back against the wall with a thump that he worried for a fleeting second would be too loud.

He gave it a few minutes before sliding off the daybed. In many ways, it felt like a dream as he moved through the halls of his own house. From upstairs, the voices of Randy and Zoe bounced, rising and falling, laughing and then slow and serious. Josh stood at the foot of the stairs and listened: he could hear no more than the cadence of their voices. The occasional word reached him with clarity, but those words were prepositions and conjunctions, they told him nothing.

Of course they had to talk and eat food. They had been fucking like rabbits for a full day now, it would be crazy to think they wouldn't stop to eat and get boozed up again. But something about Randy and his wife in *his* bed, eating take-out and chatting away like this, grated on him deeply.

Their voices fell away into a rumble of unidentifiable sounds. Then the crackles of wet flesh, then moans, then the feral, grunting sound of two people fucking.

Josh crept up the stairs again. The door was ajar at a forty-five-degree angle. He couldn't see much, and he didn't dare go down the hall to peer in, only to have Randy swing the door suddenly open and be face-to-face with him.

Instead he listened, as Zoe was worked up by Randy over and over again, panting, whining, murmuring half-hearted protests, and then ascending into a cacophony of mewls and moans. Randy's voice was clear when he told her to beg him, to tell him how much she loved his cock, and Josh could hear Zoe distinctly as she whined:

"Please. Please fuck my ass full of cum, I love it so much."

This lasted for what seemed like an eternity but was probably only a few hours.

Josh retreated to the office.

Zoe did not visit him that night.

Randy fucked her again in the morning, and then left.

*

Zoe was asleep, a twisted, wrinkled sheet over her hips, clutched in the hand that had pulled it over her carelessly, at her chest. Her hair was splayed across the pillow, stuck to her cheek and neck, wild and a little curly, as if she had been to the beach.

The scent of sex was heavy in the air. It was mostly the sweet tang of Zoe's cunt, but stabs of pungent cum broke through the sweetness. Randy's cum. It was everywhere: all over Zoe, in her ass, in her pussy, in her mouth.

Josh walked over to her quietly, so as not to wake her. She seemed exhausted, her mouth open slightly, her breathing deep and slow. Her lips seemed puffy, bitten and used and stretched to accommodate Randy's huge cock. Some cum was dried on her cheek. Josh let his eyes wander over her body, and lingered on her knees, which were slightly red and rug burnt. The skin on her bottom was pink where Randy had slapped her ass or gripped it fiercely, or both.

Josh's cock was in such intense pain he could barely stand it. He shimmied out of his joggers, pushed his boxers down, and shook himself until they all fell to the floor. He was already stroking his cock by the time they fell to his knees. His hand was getting wet from the precum that had oozed from his hole at a nearly steady drip for the past 24 hours.

He didn't want to wake Zoe: he knew it was selfish and wrong, that he should let her sleep, that Randy had used her so thoroughly she probably couldn't take any more. He could just jerk off here, let his seed fall all over her, masturbate to the scene before him, and let her sleep.

Or just jerk off in the shower and wait to reclaim her later, after she rested.

But sanity had long since left the building. He felt like he was watching himself as he edged himself onto the bed and straddled Zoe's hips. He leaned down and pushed her hair from her cheek. It stuck for a moment, before finally releasing and brushing away: it was stiff, sticky. Covered in dried cum.

"Zoe," he sang softly. He touched her cheek. Zoe didn't stir.

"Zoe," he said again, not sure if he was trying to wake her or deliberately *not* wake her.

He pulled the sheet away from her, pushing it down to her knees. Zoe stirred, and mumbled something incoherent.

"It's me, Zoe," he said. "It's Josh."

Zoe turned, and brought an arm to her head. He thought he saw a faint smile on her lips. She could still be asleep, and yet she might also have been surfacing from a heavy sleep.

Josh reached for her right hand, strung over her still-twisted torso. He brought it to his cock and closed her fingers around it. She gripped him, though loosely, and he let go of her fingers.

Zoe moved her hand, a little listlessly, and her eyes opened. Her eyelids were heavy, she had to fight against them closing. "Josh," she said. She smiled. "I'm so tired," she said. Her eyes drooped shut, and then she fought to open them. "Was it too much?"

Josh pulled her hips so her lower body lay flat, aligned with her torso on her back. The scent of her pussy, overflowing with cum, poofed into the air. "It was so hot, Zoe," he said, his voice shaking. "You did so good."

Zoe opened her eyes again. Her face was serious, but the smile was on her lips for a beat, before a deeply troubled expression crept across it.

"Zoe, I loved it," Josh said, to assure her.

Zoe's eyes seemed a little vacant for a moment. Then she looked at him.

"What?" she said, as if she really hadn't heard what he said.

It was a moment to talk to her and not to fuck her, and Josh knew that at the time. But his cock was the only thing he could feel at that point, all of the searing pain in his chest and the sickening waves of nausea in his

abdomen, and all of the brutal arousal and jealousy that had pulsed through him for almost two days, had settled there, in his balls, and his cock.

"I said I loved it Zoe, don't worry," he told her. He sank onto her body, his cock sinking into her sloppy-wet cunt without so much as a minor adjustment or push. Her flesh was hot, and she quivered inside. Her mouth popped open, and her eyes seemed to retreat again for a moment. "It was hot," he whispered, beginning to fuck her. He stroked her hair. The cum-soaked strand fell as one chunk onto her cheek, stiff like it had been submerged in hair gel.

Zoe squirmed, and her eyelids fell heavily again. A high-pitched moan left her throat, and she opened her eyes again.

The troubled expression was there, and then she blinked, it seemed almost deliberately, to erase it. "You liked it?" she murmured.

Josh pushed himself as deep inside of her as he could go. "It was so hot," he told her, again and again as he fucked her, "you did so good, Zoe." She tried to keep her eyes open, but she was half-asleep when he slammed his seed into her used pussy. She gave him a smile, and her hand meandered over her face. When he rolled over to his side and propped himself up next to her, she was definitely asleep.

"I love you, Zoe," he said.

"I love..." Zoe murmured, but she never finished the sentence.

CHAPTER 12

Zoe poured herself an enormous coffee, using a mug that it was well-known to all belonged to Alicia, and, hoping Alicia either wouldn't notice or would forgive her, she walked unsteadily back to her desk.

Everything at Hessler Insurance was the same: the same unenthusiastic typing clattering from behind the gray cubicle walls, the same low-murmured arguments with insureds, the same occasional peal of laughter, devoid of true inspiration, likely in response to a cat video - the last bastion of civil office discourse about the outside world.

Zoe wondered if people could see the change in her. If she was giving away the lingering tenderness in pussy and ass, a pleasant reminder of her weekend adventures, by the way that she walked? Did people know that a perpetual well of her sweet pussy juice kept her panties soaked almost all day long, that the reason for this was just a momentary lapse into the memories of the weekend before? Did they see in her face that she was an adulterer, but even worse than that, an *approved* adulterer, a woman who wantonly gave herself to an older man outside of her marriage, while her husband lurked in the shadows and watched, and then hammered her pussy full of his own cum while she was still saturated with Randy's?

She felt a little like she had after losing her virginity, when she had gone to a nanny job she held over the summer the next day. Everyone *seemed* to be looking at her differently, like they somehow knew about the lingering pain between her legs, the fact that she was no longer a virgin. And yet it was impossible that anyone had known. She was the one who had changed, and the change only mattered to those who knew about it.

In the end, she hadn't told Josh about Randy's final, heart-stopping whisper that night. By the time she could have told him, she herself wasn't sure she had heard it. And she was less likely to bet on it being something Randy *meant*, even if he had murmured it just before falling asleep.

She was a little naive, but she was old enough to know that men said all kinds of crazy shit after they fucked someone, and what was the adage? "If men say 'I love you' within fifteen minutes of ejaculation it really means 'I love fucking.'" Or something like that. Anyway, it was probably true. Based on all of that, and the fact that she just didn't want to deal with a complication that big, she had chosen to toss that detail into the void.

She sat down at her desk and booted up her computer, hoping to get plenty of work done. She was behind on her claims - because of Randy - and she needed to catch up.

"You know that's my mug," Alicia said, deadpan, statement and not question, but she didn't stop as she walked by Zoe's cubicle, and she seemed to have a smile on her lips.

Zoe fished her phone out and set it on her desk, just in case.

God, she was acting like an adolescent. Clinging to her phone, checking it every twenty minutes, her heart fluttering in her chest every time she received a message.

Almost as if on cue, the two hums of an incoming message vibrated through her desk and to her knee, which was folded over the other as she sat primly at her desk.

She sucked in her breath.

Then she slipped open her phone cover.

I want to see you tonight.

Her insides went on a wild ride, soaring and dropping. The cold thrill of attraction blossomed in her lower abdomen; the grip of Randy's sexual power over her swelled in her pussy. Fear chased along behind these sensations, Randy's phantom, possibly imagined, dangerous "I love you" repeating in her head.

She bit her lip and flipped the phone closed with a flick of her wrist. Twisting her face into an expression of diligence, she pulled up her diary and stared at the piling actions she needed to perform, but she saw nothing.

When she looked back down at her phone, she realized she was breathing more rapidly than sitting at her desk would have warranted for a 400 pound 80-year-old with emphysema, let alone herself. Using the edge of her pinky finger, and staring at her screen, as though the universe might not notice what she was doing if she only did it surreptitiously enough, she glanced back down at the message.

I want to see you tonight.

And what Randy wanted, she thought with a shiver, Randy got. She shifted in her chair and looked back at the screen, a throb of pleasant soreness traveling through her ass to her tailbone.

She liked Randy's obsession with her. His domination of her. She liked him fucking her in all the ways that Josh just... couldn't. When she thought

of Randy making her tell him she was his sex slave, it made her pussy froth and sent a cold chill up her spine.

And Josh liked it, too.

So what was the problem?

She stared at her diary, turning it over in her mind.

"So what's the deal with this Kristy...Krista... Malekavie, MacLevie?"

Alicia almost yelled.

Zoe jumped, and turned around to see Alicia with a file in her hand, scowling. She looked up at Zoe and gave her a strange look. "Krista Mackelvie," she said slowly. "She's called the AAs like thirty times this morning, something about a pharmacy bill the auto isn't paying?"

Zoe blinked.

Alicia slid the file toward her, over the top of the cubicle. She tsked in her typical way, but very softly. "Zoe, girl, you need to get it under control."

Zoe reached for the file. "I got it," she snapped. Anger flared through her. "This woman is crazy, she's been cut off her PIP by the adjuster, there's nothing I can do about it."

Zoe was surprised by how vicious she sounded.

"Right," Alicia said. "Well, we can't do anything about it, either, but this is why they pay you the big bucks, am I right, *muñeca*?"

The relationship between the agents and the support staff was not unlike that between doctors and nurses, in terms of the vast disparity of pay and the way the lesser-paid group shoveled most of the shit.

Zoe caught the file just as Alicia tipped it slightly off the fulcrum of the cubicle wall, sending it into Zoe's airspace. She made a tight-lipped smile, with raised eyebrows, and sauntered away.

Zoe tossed the file on her desk. Work was definitely piling up, and people were starting to notice. She was distracted, and it wasn't good.

She stared at her diary.

Then she picked up her phone and typed a message to Josh.

Randy wants me to come out tonight.

Then she set the phone down, stared at the screen, and sighed in frustration, before opening her bottom desk drawer and tossing the phone into it. She clanged it shut with a loud noise, just as Alicia went walking by on her way to the break room. Zoe was pretty sure she shook her head.

*

She managed not to check her phone until 11:00, by which time there was still no message from Josh. She considered waiting, and making Randy wait, because if she had any dignity at all, that's what she would do. She set the phone down again, typed a few incomprehensible notes in a file she barely recognized, and then picked the phone back up.

Maybe.

She set the phone down. That should keep Randy at bay, keep her conscience clear about Josh, and restore a little bit of dignity to herself. After all, she wanted to be in control of... all of this. And she definitely wasn't. Let Randy stew for a bit. She wasn't *actually* his sex slave, after all.

The phone buzzed on the table again.

She looked at it, pressed her lips together, and let her heart pound noisily in her chest. She could hear her ventricles opening and closing in her own ears.

What time do you take your lunch break?

Zoe flipped the cover closed, as if doing so would erase the image of Randy's message, and the implications of it, from her mind. Now her chest was tight, and she could feel a bead of sweat forming at her temple.

She knew Randy wasn't asking a question like that so he could take her for a casual lunch at Applebee's.

The Center, where Hessler Insurance was cloistered away among a series of low-rise and unmemorable office buildings, was also home to numerous, numerous hotels. Hotels for business travelers. The kind of rarely fully booked, high-end hotels that didn't balk much at a room being checked out of two hours after checking in.

Zoe made a concentrated effort to read through a pressing issue on her diary before picking up her phone.

I only have half an hour

she typed.

It was sort of true; it was the kind of thing she wished *was* true. It would be prudent for her to only take a half-hour lunch today, and probably even more so for her to skip lunch entirely, because her diary was only falling further behind, and it wouldn't be long before it entered the vicious-cycle stage, where her inattention to old issues started to set everything on fire and all of her time was spent putting fires out and never getting ahead.

No one liked being there: it could last for weeks or months, and the more shit that ran downhill to the AAs, the less helpful they would become.

Her phone buzzed and she put her hand on it, just as Alicia walked by, giving only a suspicious glance in her direction.

"Jesus," Zoe muttered, putting her phone in her lap to open it.

Take more. Take it at one. I'll come by the front.

The arrogance. The sheer fucking arrogance of the man.

She started to type a response, angrily: *I seriously only have half an hour.*

But she stopped mid-sentence.

She wondered if Randy was at the other end of the message, watching the rolling balls at the bottom of the screen, aware that she was typing. He would know, then, that she chickened out, if she didn't send him anything.

She deleted what she had written, and then quickly typed:

Maybe.

Determined to get something done, she tried to throw herself back into her work.

*

The clock, one of those clearly labeled, boring, black and white office clocks in offices all over the world, was visible to Zoe just over the edge of the corner where the two tall sides of her large cubicle met. She was aware as the minutes ticked away to one o'clock. Aware of the moment that the hands lined up at that time. In the corner of her desktop, she saw it as well.

Her stomach was cold, and blood was pounding in her ears again.

She wanted, so much, to have the fortitude to sit there, and let Randy do whatever Randy was going to do. He hadn't texted, hadn't asked if she was coming, and yet she knew he was out there, assured of himself, believing with his cocky, arrogant smug face that she would come walking out the front door and get into his car.

And the part that really steamed her, is that as the clock ticked away from 1:01 to 1:02, with an incredible, painful slowness, she knew all along that she was going to do what she did next.

She picked up her phone, and languidly pressed the buttons to adjust her outgoing message. She sent a text message to Neil, telling him she had to run some errands and would be gone from 1-2, which was a standard

lunch hour there, and the sort of thing nobody really cared about people returning late from, as long as they worked an eight-hour day.

She stood up, gathered her things with a trance-like meticulousness, and walked calmly to the bathroom. It was almost like she was watching someone else: she watched herself pee, watched herself adjust her makeup, put lipstick on, and purse her lips to look at herself in the mirror. She watched herself wipe the lipstick away - mostly away - with a square of toilet paper - because Randy shouldn't know she put lipstick on just for him.

And then she watched herself wave at Ruth, the receptionist, who gave her a strange look on her way out the front door, because Zoe always entered and exited at the back, and only saw Ruth at company Christmas parties.

He was in his Jag, looking calmly ahead. He had parked right in front of the walkway, and when he saw her coming, he leaned over to open the door for her.

She watched herself as she pulled it open and slid into the passenger seat.

"You're late," Randy said quietly, in the calm, clinical voice he used for everything. "I was beginning to worry you weren't coming."

"Really?" Zoe said, pulling her seatbelt over her chest.

Randy looked over at her as he put the car in gear. He shook his head first, smiled second, and finally, quite seriously, said, "No."

He reached for her, putting his fingers beneath her chin, resting his thumb lightly on her lower lip. The weight of his thumb, no more, pulled her mouth open slightly. Randy's stare was feral, and it turned her inside out. She was unable to say anything, unable to even think straight, unable to collect the words and emotions and anger she would need to reject his gesture, whatever it meant.

Instead, hot, creamy liquid seeped into her panties, and she sat there quietly, until Randy turned away from her, and began to drive.

*

It was the Center Hilton. They didn't say anything as they parked and walked into the hotel lobby. Zoe had been there before, for a cocktail party thrown by a rental car agency, and she was surprised how little it had changed, even in the tiniest detail, from that evening. Randy walked past registration to the elevators, so she followed. He held his hand out for her

and she stepped into the elevator. Randy pressed a button for the eighth floor.

Silence as they rose. Zoe's stomach flipped again, but it could have been the elevator, which rose with alarming speed.

The doors opened, they walked down the hall, Randy taking her elbow to guide her to the room.

She stepped inside. "I have to be back by two, Randy," she said quietly. She looked behind her, to catch him closing the door quietly, his eyes on her body. "That's a hard line."

"Yep," Randy said, diffidently, turning her toward him.

She didn't want to simply bend to his will, but she did it anyway. His fingers moved along her collarbone, and she shivered. He began to carefully unbutton her blouse, his eyes on her mouth, his expression frighteningly hungry.

"Randy," she said in a whisper. "I need to... this is... I need to tell Josh, I need to tell him what we're doing."

Randy's face was impassive. He carefully pulled two buttons apart before answering. "Did Josh figure out what you got up to this weekend?" he asked.

"Not exactly," Zoe said, after a pause long enough for Randy to unbutton two more buttons.

"Then why," Randy said. It wasn't a question; he meant it as a statement, a finality imposed by him.

Zoe sucked in her breath. Randy pushed her blouse over her shoulders.

He leaned in close to Zoe's ear. "I don't want to hear about Josh right now, Zoe. I want to hear how much you want me to fuck you." His fingers were expertly undoing the clasp of her skirt, at the back. He put a hand down the waistband as he lowered the zipper, sliding his finger neatly into the crack of her ass, pushing away her panties with a rough impatience.

She heard the sticky wetness of her cunt as his finger sank into it, but she would have known how wet she was by the way his finger glided over her perineum and into her pussy. "Are you still sore from when I fucked you?"

Zoe met Randy's eyes, and nodded. She tried to trap a warble in her throat and failed, as Randy's expert fingers found her clit, pulling her close

against him so she could feel the mass of his cock, hard for her, ready to fuck her again and again.

Randy slid his finger from her pussy slowly, trailing a cool wetness along her ass-crack and then her lower back. He pulled her skirt down, and turned her around, gently prodding her to the bed, letting her step out of her skirt as she went.

He pushed her forward onto the bed with a not-so-gentle shove, and she went, submitting to him, enjoying the pleasing rush of humiliation that traveled through her.

"Stay just like that," Randy said. He walked over to the dresser, where a small suitcase was propped open against the wall. Zoe followed him with her eyes, perched on her hands and knees. The hotel mirror gave her a view of herself, her blouse bunched at her back, around her shoulders, her ass in the air for Randy. She was rocking slightly, unable to contain her arousal, unable to stop her hips from rutting slightly. She looked like a woman from a porno, almost cartoonish in her arousal.

"I brought something for you," Randy said, fishing a tube that could only be lube from the suitcase. "Since I knew you'd be short on time." He held it in his fingers and turned around. "Do you want it?"

"Randy," Zoe complained. "I don't -"

"Do you want it?" Randy repeated, more sinisterly, walking toward her. His warm hand was on her ass, and she sucked her breath in. She hung her head between her shoulders as he moved his fingers to her pussy and drew some of her juices up to her ass.

"You want it. You want me to fuck your ass," he said.

It was true, and she hated that he was right, so assured. She hated that he had made her crawl and beg for it, and that she was going to. What sort of woman was she, that she so desperately wanted to feel a big, thick cock in her ass?

Randy pushed her chest down to the mattress. He pulled her right arm by the elbow and slid her blouse off first her right and then her left arm. He set it neatly next to her on the bed. Then he took her right arm again, and pulled her hand up to her ass, where he placed it.

She felt the cool lube as he laid down a line of it between her pointer and middle finger, after carefully pinching them together.

"Be a good girl Zoe, and get yourself all ready."

"Randy..." she moaned. But she didn't have any way to finish the sentence, or any strength to protest: she *wanted* him to humiliate her, to fuck her in the ass at 1:30 in the afternoon and then take her back to work and leave her there with an ass full of cum.

He pushed her wrist down, and her fingers slipped into the valley between her buttocks. She felt the rubbery ring of her anus at her fingertips, and she squeezed closed when the cold of the lube hit her eyelet.

Randy guided her fingertips into her ass, pushing insistently. For a moment, her eyes stung as she was stretched open, but she relaxed and the lube helped with the rest: her fingers slid right in, stretching her open.

"Fuck yourself," Randy told her. He leaned over her, pushing her hair from her face, then sat back on the edge of the bed to watch her. She was facing the wall, not the mirror, but she didn't want to see herself that much anyway. Randy's breath became ragged as she pumped her ass with her two fingers.

"That's it, show me what a good little slut you are. Keep going. Be good, be good and I'll make you come." He slid a finger languidly through her slit, pushing against her clit as he went, sending a shudder through her thighs.

He watched her fuck herself with her fingers for what seemed like an eternity, until at last he placed a hand on her wrist and stopped her, with her fingers still deep in her ass. He pulled them from inside her, and with a firm, almost painful grip on her wrist, he pulled her to her knees and turned her toward the mirror.

Zoe stared at the woman in the mirror: the panties stretched between her middle thighs, her hair damp with sweat already, the man behind her who was about to fuck her in the ass.

Randy used his free hand to tip her head slightly to the side. He pushed her hair away from her neck and grazed the length of it with a dry kiss. His stubble was just soft fuzz at this time of day. Randy tugged on her hair to get her to face herself in the mirror.

Then he brought her fingers to her mouth, and using his grip on her jaw, he pushed her mouth open and shoved them in.

Zoe didn't even register the taste of the lube and the metallic flavor of her ass, only the visual, and Randy's voice, as he met her eyes in the mirror.

"That's it. That's fucking filthy, that's so dirty, Zoe. You filthy, dirty little slut, suck your fingers, that's so dirty. That's a good, dirty, little slut."

Randy's eyes were terrifying: they were locked on her mouth, and nothing short of twisted obsession burned in them.

But Zoe had little time to contemplate that because he pushed her forward suddenly, and she had to catch her fall with the hand in her mouth.

She heard the spurt of the lube, and felt a glob of it drop into the center of her ass. Randy's hot cock pushed straight through the cold, and into her tightening sphincter, giving her a sharp bite of pain that faded quickly.

"Now Zoe, be a good girl. And tell me what I want to hear."

Zoe brought her fingers to her lips and rested them on her lower lip. She wasn't sure why she did it until she heard Randy take his breath in sharply. A thrill traveled through her: it was the thrill of control, the grip of a ski on a hill you were careening down with no control, the turn that you make yourself after free-fall, the catch of a rope in your hand.

"I want you to fuck me, Dr. McIntyre," she purred. "I want you to fuck me however you want."

He was inside of her, and her eyes had rolled into the back of her head and opened again before she even became intellectually conscious of the fact that she had called him "Dr. McIntyre." But when she strained to look at his face, she could see the effect it had on him, and even though it was dark, and terrible, and fucked up, she found herself moaning and then saying, in a very deliberate, breathy whisper:

"Yes. Fuck me just like that, Dr. McIntyre, yes, I want to feel you fuck me full of cum."

She drew her free hand between her legs, to find her own clit in the slosh of her pussy. It took almost nothing, even using her left hand, to rub against her hardened button until she felt her legs trembling and her ass squeezing around Randy's cock.

Randy leaned against her ass and over her body to grasp her left arm and squeeze it tightly enough to make her wince. He pushed it up, dragging her fingers from her pussy. She continued to flick them at her clit, because she was desperate to come, but Randy leaned on her arm and pushed it into the mattress hard, all the while sawing in and out of her ass. "I didn't tell you you could come," he said, gruffly.

"Randy," she panted. But her plea went unanswered, his weight pushing her arm deeper into the soft mattress, her chest compressing along with it. He slowed his fucking, dragging his dick to the very rim of her ass before slowly feeding it back inside of her. Zoe whimpered, and tried not to let Randy hear in her moans and mewls how much he was torturing her, how badly she needed relief.

Sneakily, she edged her right hand toward her waist, but Randy caught it and lay down on top of her, his heavy body smashing her into the pillows. His hot skin was on her back, and the change of position pushed his cock against different, untouched, insides of her ass. She writhed and pushed against him, trying to squeeze her legs together and get some friction against her pussy, but Randy pinned her easily.

It was then that he began the slow, methodical fucking that seemed to last forever. Zoe began to feel dizzy, like she might lose consciousness, partly from the unending clamor for relief between her legs, partly from Randy crushing her beneath him.

Before he came, his calves flexed and his thighs went rigid. His cock sank so deep inside of her she seemed to feel it everywhere in her body, and then he grunted loudly, and the heat and slippery wetness of his cum filled her deep inside.

He held her wrists at her side and lifted his torso to thrust his final, shuddering spurts into her.

Zoe tried to squirm, and from her chest she heard something that seemed almost like a sob.

Randy's hot skin fell down over her back, inch by inch, until his mouth was next to her ear again, and she could feel her breath. "I want you to go back to work, and think about me all day, until you see me again. And you're going to be a very good girl, and not make yourself come. Do you understand?"

"Randy," she sobbed. She tried to squirm. "Randy, I can't... you're..."

Somehow, he made himself heavier, and she was pinned in complete helplessness beneath the weight of his body, his hands firmly around her wrists. "I won't let you go back to work until you promise me," he said.

Zoe's eyes were open and she stared at the beige-gray curtain, the sheer white beneath it, as she tried one last time to wriggle her way out from under him. Her pussy throbbed with a pain and a need she had never

experienced before, and it threatened to swallow her like a wave would suck her under the sea. "I can't, Randy, please," she complained, but was instantly sorry she had said that. She could just tell him that's what she would do, after all, and then not do it.

"Okay," she breathed. "Okay, okay. I'll do it."

She tried one last tactic, squeezing her ass around his cock.

"I don't believe you, Zoe, do you know that?" Randy said quietly.

"Randy," she moaned. "I have to... I have to get back to work, I can't..."

"Promise me, Zoe. You want to be a good girl for me, don't you? That's part of the thrill? So be good. Promise me you won't make yourself come, until you come back to me tonight. Show me you know how to be a good girl."

Zoe squeezed her eyes closed.

"Okay," she said, relaxing her ass in surrender. "Okay."

"Okay...?" Randy repeated.

"I promise you."

Randy licked the side of her ear. "Say the whole thing, Zoe. Make me believe it."

Zoe bit her lip. Her gut twisted above the throb of her needy pussy, and somewhere inside she recognized a new arousal, different than any game she'd been playing thus far.

"I promise, Randy," she whispered after a pause. "I promise I won't come until I see you tonight."

Randy sank his weight onto his knees, and pulled her up by the hair to sit on his lap. He brushed the hair from her face, over her shoulder, where it clung briefly before sweeping back to cover half of her face. It was impossibly tangled, and her mascara was smeared, and she looked filthy. His cock was still inside of her, semi-hard, slithering from her ass in increments. She stared at her image in the mirror as Randy held her chin and looked at her, in the mirror, from over her shoulder.

He kissed her shoulder with an incongruous tenderness, and then met her eyes again. In his burned a masculine, dominant power. "Be good, Zoe. I'll know if you aren't."

A mildly hysterical sound escaped her chest. It was short, nothing more than a chirp. Randy's cock pulsed at the sound of it. A tense moment passed, and then he pushed her forward. "You better get dressed," he said calmly,

moving his knees one at a time to edge to the right side of the bed without taking his eyes off her.

Zoe sank to her calves and stared at herself in the mirror, fingers to her lips. Randy crossed in front of her, fishing something from his small suitcase. Zoe looked at him in alarm when he faced her, a black object in his hands, and when she saw him, he smiled.

"Stay like that," he said, and his thumb pressed the screen of his phone.

"Randy -"

"That's for me, to hold me over," he said, cutting her off. "And it's for you, if you want to send it to Josh. But only if you can be a very, very good girl, Zoe."

Her hand was shaking, and so was her voice. "That sounds like blackmail."

Randy looked at her. Then he dropped the phone into his suitcase and strolled casually toward the bathroom without saying anything. "It's two o'clock," he called, in a deadpan voice, after the water turned on.

There was no time, at all, for her to even think about "being a bad girl," or Randy's pseudo blackmail, or the humiliating fact that it had only turned her on more than it had infuriated her. She had gathered up her scattered clothes, and straightened the wrinkles the best that she could, and pulled her hair back in a ponytail, using a headband as a scrunchy, which looked absurd, but was all she could find.

She assessed herself in the mirror quickly, as Randy strolled casually out, naked, and picked his clothes up from the floor as if it were a Sunday morning.

"I have to get back to work," she snapped at him, and hurried into the bathroom to pee, which she found herself unable to do, because her pussy was still throbbing and engorged. Briefly, she wondered if she could just slip her fingers into her slit and... but the minutes were ticking away and she was on very, very thin ice at work as it was.

She fished, shaking, into her makeup bag and did her best to repair the damage that Randy had done. In the end, she faced herself: her skirt and blouse wrinkled, her hair in the ridiculous scrunchy ponytail, and absolutely everything about her appearance screaming "I went out and fucked someone at lunch."

"Whatever," she said aloud, as if she had been arguing with Randy.
"Let's go."

No time to think about it as Randy strolled along, a smug expression on his face that made her want to punch him, or as she waited behind the front doors for Randy to drive off, so she could creep around the building. No time, picking her way among the hacked, dry bushes and the sharp-edged rocks of the landscaping that had been designed to be seen from far away and only in the corner of the eye of an unlucky lost soul who had turned into the wrong parking lot. No time as she emerged from the bushes and crept to the back door, silently praying that no one in Casualty would be looking out the window. Even after she settled into her chair and breathed a sigh of relief for having entered unnoticed, there was no time to even consider Randy's absurd task. Her phone was blinking with messages, and a sticky note, with the odd, both curly and jagged script unique to Alicia, written with red permanent marker, was taped to her screen.

Call my desk when you get back.

CABRONA

It was unclear from the way it was written who the "cabrona" was, but Zoe had a feeling it was her.

Chapter 13

She was out of control.

Things were out of control.

On her phone was the single message from Randy:

Don't forget your promise. See you at eight?

And no message from Josh.

It was nearly seven o'clock, and almost everyone had left, except for a few people in a department she knew vaguely as "special investigations," who always stayed late and whom the company had affectionately nicknamed "The MIB." Somewhere, distantly, a janitor was starting up a floor cleaner.

Zoe had finally wrapped up the mess on her diary - at least, the parts that needed the most water thrown on them. Technically, there were several items still smoldering, which she should probably stay and sort out.

That's what Zoe-In-Control would do: stay and finish her work, blow Randy off, and go home and tell Josh everything that had happened today, confess that she had lost control of herself, and of Randy (as if she had ever had any control over *him*), and hope that Josh would find some elegant solution for disposing of the whole sordid affair.

It would be best if it all could disappear from her life. She was being a terrible employee. She was humiliating herself more with every encounter with Randy. This afternoon she had felt, briefly, that she had wrangled his control away from him, uncovered his soft belly, but somehow he had turned it around on her.

The worst part was that, while in theory, intellectually, she wanted to ignore his message and blow him off this evening, there was another animal inside of her that wanted to go to him. A devilish side that wanted to defy him and see what he would do, or if he would know - because how *could* he know if she masturbated in the bathroom or her car or even at her house before she went to him? And then there was a strange, submissive craving inside of her, a part that *wanted* to obey him, to satisfy sexual needs she was just now realizing that she had. Or perhaps had never wanted to admit to herself; she didn't particularly like them.

Finally, if she dug deep, there was part of her that was actually afraid of defying him, or of losing him, or of both. She recoiled from this thought

almost as soon as it surfaced in her mind, though, because that was not how things were *supposed* to be.

Minutes after she had returned to the office, Alicia had stomped over to her cubicle. Her features seemed to flare when she was all fired up - it was not just her nostrils, but her eyes and her mouth and her wild hair. But when she had archly surveyed Zoe's appearance, she simmered down and handed her the MacKelvie file with a sort of suspicious pity.

It was not a sentiment Alicia had ever dispensed in Zoe's presence, and it made her flush with shame. *Jesus*, she thought. *Alicia, the office slut, is ashamed for me.*

Zoe wondered if it was stunningly obvious to everyone, or only Alicia, and if Alicia had the sort of perception that allowed her to know not only that she had gone to fuck a guy in the middle of the day, but that she had let him fuck her ass and wait to come until she crawled back to him this evening.

"You run out of hairbands?" Alicia had asked, in the unreadable, deadpan voice that made Alicia so dangerous.

Zoe had taken the file. She had cleared her throat, and said quietly, "I'm feeling a little sick."

Alicia had hovered there, staring at her, while Zoe looked through the file without meeting her eyes.

"I got a hairband at my desk," she had said, before turning and walking away.

She dropped off said hairband without comment, so while Zoe couldn't tell exactly what Alicia knew and didn't know, she had the uneasy feeling that Alicia had seen everything much for what it was.

Now, a full hour after she usually went home, Zoe's fingers hovered over her phone. Should she call Josh, or text him, and ask him what to do? How would she explain, exactly, what her predicament was?

The afternoon at the hotel flashed through her mind, searing her as it did. Her heart thumped erratically, and her pussy, which had been simmering steadily on a low-grade ache, squeezed and flared to full arousal.

She was supposed to tell Josh everything. That was their deal.

But what if *everything* was too hard to tell? What if she was ashamed of herself and what she had done? How in the world could she tell Josh that she'd gone to a hotel with Randy for an hour, and sucked lube from her own

ass off her fingers, and not even gotten an orgasm out of it, and was now endangering her employment by sitting at her desk unable to think of anything but how much she wanted to come with Randy's huge cock inside of her? How could she tell her husband she hadn't satisfied her cravings, as if she were some kind of superstitious slut who actually believed that Randy would know what she had done?

And how could she explain to Josh that she was going to see Randy tonight, crawling to him just to be turned inside out again and again?

She could tell him it was only because Randy had alluded to his perverse "blackmail" of her - the photo. But she didn't really believe that was blackmail, and Josh didn't need a single picture after he had observed the whole weekend, and all of its sordid details.

A cold chill rippled through her: what if Josh heard the desperation in her voice, and told her not to go see Randy tonight? What if he found the blackmail, however pointless it was, to be a bridge too far? What if Josh told her she couldn't see Randy anymore, before she got to have his big, thick cock inside of her again?

She stared at her phone. Her thumb was beginning to cramp, and shake, held above the keyboard for so long.

She began to type.

Randy wants me to come see him around 8. I think I can get you some pictures???? What do you think?

It wasn't the truth, and it wasn't a lie. She leaned her head back on the chair and closed her eyes. She had just gotten to a place with Josh where all the lies were cleared up, and here she was, sliding down a slippery slope again.

She felt her phone buzz in her hand. She made a solemn vow, before opening her eyes, to do whatever Josh told her to do, to answer any specific question he might have.

And to, after going to see Randy, tell him everything as soon as she got home.

That's hot

She stared at the message, unable to believe it. An odd anger flared up inside of her. Hot? That was *hot*? Here she was worried about Josh's feelings and he thought it was "hot" that she was going to go over to Randy's and maybe get him some pictures?

"Huh," she said, and turned the phone off. She tapped it on her lips a few times, and then, muttering to herself almost as if she'd had a spat with Josh, she gathered up her stuff, shut down her computer, and left.

*

She started the car and glanced at the time: 7:27. She fished out her phone and looked at the screen lock, considering typing a message to Randy, telling him she'd be late.

She thought better of it and put the phone back in her purse. She stared through the windshield, giving her internal pandemonium a few more minutes' thought. A glance in the rearview mirror confirmed for her that she was the only vehicle in the parking lot. She turned around to make certain.

Thinking about Randy had turned her on again. She let her hand fall to the gear shift and moved her foot to the brake, but then she paused.

Who did Randy think he was? she thought. He wasn't a mind-reader. He was just a guy.

Her pussy throbbed.

She had lied to her husband. So it only seemed fair, suitable, *right*, even, for her to lie to Randy.

She moved her hand to her thigh, and then awkwardly adjusted her leg so it was leaning up against the gearshift, and she could slip her fingers down her legs and under her panties, into the wet mush of her pussy. She could smell her own arousal, and Randy's cum. She paused for a single moment, actually considering her obedience to Randy.

But Zoe was not one to stand so close to the edge and not jump.

The first touch of her finger against her clit made her leg jerk. She became hot, her hair sticking to her neck, almost instantly. Her fingers made a rhythmic sticky sound in her cunt as she stroked herself within seconds to an orgasm that made a heavy, thudding sound in her ear, almost like a rapid change in altitude. A little scream left her lips, and she shuddered away the wild high.

The sweat turned cold instantly, and she shivered. Her eyes darted around the tops of the buildings, as she had the sudden thought that there might be security cameras. She didn't see any, and her mind worked quickly to reassure her: even if there were, the footage was not that great on security cameras and they would almost certainly never look at the footage unless some kind of crime was committed here, tonight.

She steadied herself, looked in the mirror to make sure her face was calm and her makeup perfect. She had forgotten about how trashy she looked, and she flipped the mirror back in place immediately.

Then she put the car in reverse, and backed out, without looking behind her. Which is how she thought she should drive through the rest of this adventure.

*

"You're late."

Randy's voice, as always, revealed nothing about his thoughts, and even less about how he might feel about them. There was no admonishment, no tease, no anger, no joy - only statement of fact. He pushed the door open wide and held it for her without changing the position of his body. Zoe stepped under his arm, without having to bend her knees much, and into his living room.

"I was at work until at least 7:30," Zoe said quietly, shrugging off her light jacket from both shoulders at once. She looked back at him. "Making up for all the work that didn't get done earlier."

Randy could have said anything to that. He could have joked, or smiled at his own doing, or even apologized for causing her troubles. He did none of these things, and instead closed the door and leaned against it.

"*You* have been a very, very bad girl, Zoe."

The statement was so sudden, so unexpected, that Zoe had no time to prevent the look of shock that snapped into her features. She had no defense to such a statement of fact; she would never have expected him to just throw it at her like that.

"I," she began defensively, and then changed course as her mind began to catch up to the current moment. She made a confused face, which felt preposterous even to her, and tipped her head. "Wait, what?"

Randy's lips turned upward a little. It was the faintest trace of a smile, but Zoe saw it, as Randy pushed away from the door and stalked toward her.

"You've broken your promise."

"Randy," she said, slouching and incorporating a very adolescent, millennial, accent to her voice that made her cringe inwardly. "What promise?"

She knew how foolish she sounded as soon as she said it, and wondered why on earth she hadn't anticipated Randy saying something like this as soon as he closed the door. She had prepared for lying as he peeled her clothes away, and asked: "Did you keep your promise?"

Not for this.

Randy was close to her now. She was smiling a little ridiculously, shrugging things off, and she couldn't stop herself. "What?" she said idiotically, as he touched her cheek.

"You made yourself come," Randy said simply.

"What, why... uh, what makes you think that?"

"And now you need to be punished."

A new, frightening thrill vibrated inside of her. Never in her life had anything like her "knees going wobbly" occurred to her, but that was exactly what happened, and her pussy squeezed juices from it until her panties felt like they had been put on straight from a hot water wash.

"Where did you do it?" Randy asked, pulling her mouth open with the tips of his fingers. He ran one finger along her lower lip and teeth, almost like a dentist.

"Randy I don't know what - "

His fingers moved down her chin, then along her neck, as he flexed his wrist forward and let them follow behind his palm. "Don't lie," he interrupted. "Don't lie any more, or you'll really be in trouble."

She shook when his fingers reached the neck of her blouse and pulled down, stretching the material. "Where?" he repeated. The blouse began to croak with the stretch, threatening to rip. His fingers were at her sternum, now, and her bra was uncovered. "Where did you do it?"

Her voice shook. Randy was staring at her and burning a hole through her body. Her voice was shaking, and she heard it as if it was someone else's when she spoke:

"I, I..." She considered, however briefly, of flinging one last lie at him, but lost her resolve. "In the car," she whispered. "In the car, in the parking lot."

Something flickered in Randy's expression, but it was unreadable. His eyes left hers and traveled with his hands down her body. The button of her blouse had popped while she was stumbling over her confession, and now

the next one fell open. She heard it rattle on the floor, spinning in a large arc before it fell over.

"What time was this?" Randy said, casually stroking her belly before moving to the next button.

"Se -" Zoe started, and her voice caught in her throat. "Seven-thirty," she managed to say in a warble.

Randy smiled, though what it meant was unknown to her.

The next button popped away. He tugged fiercely, and so did the last. At the same time, he stepped close to her, shoving his hand down her skirt and beneath her panties, cupping her pussy. His fingers sunk into the mush of her pussy. She stumbled backward and into the wall dividing the entranceway from one vast living room. Randy pressed up against her, squeezing some of her breath from her chest.

His fingers darted over her clit, and her open mouth expelled a sharp gasp.

Then, he slid his fingers from under her skirt, unexpectedly and suddenly. He smiled again before stepping away from her.

"Where are my manners?" he said, in a voice laced with sexy danger. "Do you want a drink?"

Zoe panted, her mouth gaping in disbelief. "I don't... I..."

"I want you to have one," Randy said quietly. There was a beat of silence, and Zoe waited, because she knew something else was coming, and she knew, deep in her abdomen and at the root of her tortuously aching clit, that it was going to turn her on.

Randy had moved closer in the interim, she didn't remember him stepping toward her. She felt drunk already. Her spine tingled, and an eternity seemed to pass before he said, in a low voice, his mouth close to her neck, his breath hot on her shoulder. "I want your mouth to be cold when I put my dick in it."

Only then did he turn and walk to the room where he had fucked her the first time, and began to make her a drink, without looking back to make sure she had followed.

END BOOK II

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